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- Shri Narendra Modi, Prime Minister

”

Shaping an Inclusive Future



BUILDING FOR RESILIENCE, INNOVATION,
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BRICS SUMMIT

12 - 13 September 2026 New Delhi, India

As BRICS completes twenty years, India's Chairship marks a defining moment. It is uniting emerging and developing economies to build resilient, innovative, sustainable and inclusive societies.

HIGHLIGHTS

- 400+ Meetings
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- 10,000+ Participants

DUSU elections: ABVP, NSUI declare panels; voting on September 18

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University's campus politics found its two main contenders on Friday, as the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad and the National Students' Union of India each announced their four-member panels for the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections, setting the stage for polling on September 18.

The ABVP fielded Yash Dabas as its presidential candidate against the National Students' Union of India (NSUI)'s Vijay Shankar Meena and the All India Students' Association (AISA) and Students' Federation of India's (SFI) joint candidate

Ananya Raturi. ABVP has nominated Ishu Maurya for vice-president, Riya Chhawadi for secretary and Lakshya Raj Singh for joint secretary.

Dabas, who is from Kanjhawala in Delhi, is currently pursuing a master's from the Department of Buddhist Studies of Delhi University. He is an international-level tennis player and has participated in ITF competitions in Spain, Australia and Serbia, besides representing the DU at university-level competitions, the RSS-affiliated student organisation said on Friday.

Maurya, who is from Varanasi, is pursuing law at Campus Law Centre and has been associated with ABVP since 2021. He has served as

president of the Satyawati College (Morning) unit and co-convenor of Students for Seva.

Chhawadi, a fourth-year BA Programme student at Sri Aurobindo College, is an inter-college-level basketball player, while Singh is pursuing law at Campus Law Centre. Singh has represented India in handball at the Asian Games and World Championship, according to the ABVP.

The Congress-affiliated NSUI has fielded Meena for president, Vir Chatrath for vice-president, Namrata Chaudhary for secretary and Gopal Choudhary for joint secretary.

The organisation, in a post on X, said its campaign would focus on putting "student



NSUI National President Vinod Jakhar (centre) holds hands with party candidates for the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections 2026-27 (L-R) Gopal Chaudhary (Joint Secretary), Vir Chatrath (Vice President), Namrata Chaudhary (Secretary), and Vijay Shankar Meena (President) during a press conference in New Delhi on Friday

interests first" and building a "prosperous, safe and better" Delhi University.

Meena is originally from Rajasthan. He completed his graduation from Rajasthan University and is enrolled at Department of Buddhist Studies, the NSUI said in a statement.

With a strong understanding of academic and student-related concerns, Meena has been actively associated with issues concerning student rights, social justice, and democratic representation, they added. Chatrath, a resident of Delhi, is also pursuing an MA from the Department of Buddhist Studies, according to NSUI.

Choudhary completed her graduation from SPM College,

University of Delhi, and, like Meena and Chatrath, is a student of Buddhist Studies.

Gopal Choudhary, originally from Rajasthan, completed his graduation from Satyawati College at DU and is also pursuing an MA in Buddhist Studies.

Gopal Choudhary, the joint secretary candidate for NSUI, has been actively working on issues concerning students and remains committed to creating a better academic and democratic environment on campus, NSUI said in a statement.

The AISA-SFI alliance has nominated Raturi for president, Akshat Shikhar for vice-president, Stanzin Deskyong for secretary and B Parijaat for joint secretary.

Mandatory police verification of school staff ordered

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta directed authorities to make mandatory police verification of school staff, bus and van drivers, attendants and sanitation workers.

The Chief Minister also called for a stronger, NGO-backed campaign to make Delhi free of child begging, at a Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights (DCPCR) meeting on Friday.

Chairing the meeting, the Chief Minister said the Government's priority was to bring children out of begging and connect them with education, skills and a dignified life. She directed the commission to strengthen the anti-begging campaign through public participation, calling for willing non-Governmental organisations, civil society organisations and resident welfare associations to be brought on board to expand the drive's reach at the local level. The meeting was attended by DCPCR chair-



man OP Vyas, commission members and senior officials.

Placing child safety at the top of the agenda, the Chief Minister suggested that awareness campaigns on the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act be made a continuous, ongoing activity rather than a periodic exercise.

She stressed that mandatory police verification of all school-linked staff, including bus and van drivers, attendants and sanitation workers,

education and qualifications, and skills acquired.

The Chief Minister said merely providing shelter to children leaving these institutions was not enough, and that they needed to be connected with education, skills and employment to become self-reliant.

On school nutrition, the Chief Minister directed the commission to inspect arrangements for mid-day meals prepared by school cooks, as well as the nutritional food provided at anganwadi centres, particularly during National Nutrition Month.

The meeting also discussed preparing reports through interns to review facilities at anganwadi and palna centres, along with assessing the behaviour of anganwadi workers toward the children in their care.

The Chief Minister additionally suggested promoting career guidance arrangements for students studying in Government and municipal schools.

Absconding Satya Niketan PG operator surrenders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Absconding accused and PG operator Shubham Tyagi surrendered before the Patiala House Court on Friday in connection with the Satya Niketan building collapse case, which killed seven people, including five students and two labourers. The police produced Tyagi before the court after his surrender and sought his custody for two days for questioning and further investigation into the circumstances leading to the collapse of the five-storey building, police said.

The court granted Tyagi two days' police remand. Police said they will question Tyagi about the paying guest accommodation he was allegedly operating in the building and seek details about its functioning, the lease arrangement and the construction being carried out at the property.

Police will also question him on several aspects related to the PG, including



who was involved in its day-to-day operation, the number of occupants and the circumstances in which repair and extension work was being undertaken in the building, police said.

Tyagi's mobile phone will be sent for forensic examination to ascertain his communications with others regarding the building collapse and to find out what was discussed immediately after the incident, sources said.

The sources also said the forensic examination of the phone is expected to help investigators establish the sequence of events and the conversations that took



place among those associated with the PG after the building collapsed.

Tyagi had been absconding since the incident, and police teams were searching several locations to locate him. His surrender came a day after a court rejected his anticipatory bail plea.

While rejecting his plea, the court took into consideration the stage of the investigation and the requirement to ascertain the circumstances surrounding the collapse. The rejection of the anticipatory bail paved the way for police to seek his custody after he surrendered before the court.

According to police, Tyagi



was allegedly operating the paying guest accommodation in the building in south Delhi and had taken a floor of the property on lease from its owner Hariram Gupta.

Tyagi and co-accused Sudhanshu Lovneesh were allegedly running the PG in the building. Lovneesh is already under arrest, and investigators are examining his mobile phone and online chat history to ascertain what transpired immediately after the collapse. Police said Lovneesh's phone has been sent for forensic examination and the digital evidence is being analysed as part of the probe.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

Due to an error in my son Ishaan Nishad birth certificate, my name has been recorded as Kranti Nishad, whereas my correct name is Kranti Kumari. Both names refer to the same woman.

Kranti Kumari W/o- Surya Prakash, R/o- Village- Mulli, Post- Mahadeva, Itawa, Dist- Basti, Uttar Pradesh- 272181.

Due to an error in my son Harshiv Sharma birth certificate, my name has been recorded as Priyanka, whereas my correct name is Priyanka Sharma. Both names refer to the same woman. Priyanka Sharma W/o- Ajay Kumar, R/o- RZ- 104A, Street No. 2, East Sagar Pur, New Delhi- 110046.

I, Rachla Ramalashamma, Mother of- No.15801976K NK(GNR) Rachla Kambaiah, R/o- H.No. 2-154, Vill & PO- Singanapalle, Dist- Nandyal, Andhra Pradesh- 518196, have changed my name from Rachla Ramalashamma to Rachla Ramalakshamma, vide affidavit dated 11/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Shilochna Devi, W/o- JC-708196A Sub Vedpal, R/o- Vill+ PO- Mehri, Teh- Sadarsahar, Dist- Churu, Rajasthan- 331403, have changed my name from Shilochna Devi to Shilochna, vide affidavit dated 11/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Dheeraj Arora S/O Lalit Kumar Arora R/O 164-B, MIG DDA Flats, MAN SAROVAR PARK, Shahdara, North East Delhi, Delhi-110032 have changed the name of my minor son Kiyansh Arora aged 04 years and he shall hereafter be known as Parth Arora.

I, Dheeraj Arora S/O Lalit Kumar Arora R/O 164-B, MIG DDA FLATS, MAN SAROVAR PARK, Shahdara, North East Delhi, DELHI-110032 have changed the name of my minor son Kiaan Arora aged 04 years and he shall hereafter be known as Paras Arora.

I, Somwati Rana W/O Surender Kumar R/O 41, Near Village Chaupal, Sahipur village, Shalimar Bagh S.O., North West Delhi, Delhi-110088 declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Somwati in my minor daughter Srishti aged 15 years in her 10th class educational documents. The actual name of mine is Somwati Rana, which may be amended accordingly.

I, Somwati Rana W/O Surender Kumar R/O 41, Near Village Chaupal, Sahipur Village, Shalimar Bagh S.O., North West Delhi, Delhi-110088 declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Somwati in my minor son SHOBHIT aged 15 years in his 10th class educational documents. The actual name of mine is Somwati Rana, which may be amended accordingly.

I, Mohd Farooq S/O Mohammad umar daraj R/O C-14, Okhla Vihar Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025 declare that My Passport my name is written as Mohammad Farooq instead of Mohd Farooq. Mohd Farooq and Mohammad Farooq is one and the same person.

I, Geeta Devi Jain W/O Subhash Kumar Jain Resident of Tower9/606 Panchasheel Prime Rose Ghaziabad 201013 have changed my name from Geeta Devi Jain to Geeta Jain. Henceforth I would be known by the name Geeta Jain for all future purposes.

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Geeta Sharma had acquired Entire Fourth Floor measuring 1776 Sq. Fts. approx. on Plot No. 2495, Sector-A, land measuring 286.67 Sq. yds., part of Khara no. 63/17, Green Field Colony, Village sarai Khwaja, Tehsil Badkhal and Dist. Faridabad, Haryana vide Sale Deed dt. 30.11.2023 executed by Ravi Prakash Bhalla HUF throughs Karti Ravi Prakash Bhalla and Mr. Surender Kumar. Now Mrs. Geeta Sharma is the undisputed owner of above said property and willing to Mortgage the above said property with CFCFL.

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform to the public at large that Mr. Ram Avtar Gupta had acquired Plot No. L-9, measuring 500 sq. yds. (except area 108.55 sq. yds., Sold area) out of Khara No. 1015/72, situated in the area of Village Saboli Illaga Shahdara Delhi vide Sale Deed dt. 01.09.1999 executed by Mr. Ramesh Gupta through his CPA. Mr. Ram Avtar Gupta. Now Mr. Ram Avtar Gupta is the undisputed owner of above said property and willing to Mortgage the above said property with CFCFL.

OR
Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance whatsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her/their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client. Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi -110024

NEW OKHLA INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Administrative Building, Sector-96, Noida, (UP)
Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE
E-Tenders are invited from eligible firms/contractors for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these website for any changes/ amendments & corrigendum etc.

A) (Rs. 30.00 Lacs to 100.00 Lacs)				
S. No.	Job No.	Sale Start Date	Sale End Date	Tender Opening Date and Time
1	Job No.- 05/ E-TENDER/SPO/2026-27 Name of Work- Procurement of Printing & Stationary Items, Estimated Rs. 79,97,200.00	14.09.2026	21.09.2026 upto 5:00 P.M.	22.09.2026 11:00 AM
Office Sector-39		Store Purchase Officer, Noida		
CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA				

NOTICE
Locker Hired by MR. ANIL SHARMA having address at 111 GHS ANTRIKSH VIKASPURI NEW DELHI 110018 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at GROUND FLOOR, SHOP NO.- 2 & 3, VATIKA BUSINESS PARK, SOHNA ROAD, BADSHAHPUR GURGAON - 122002 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 8 Months and the rent due for the last 7 years.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. ANIL SHARMA calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. ANIL SHARMA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

NOTICE
Locker Hired by MR. RAJESH KHANNA having address at MF-29 ELDECO MANSIONZ SOHNA ROAD GURGAON HARYANA 122018 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at GROUND FLOOR, SHOP NO.- 2 & 3, VATIKA BUSINESS PARK, SOHNA ROAD, BADSHAHPUR GURGAON - 122002 remains un-operated from last 8 years & 10 Months and the rent due for the last 5 years.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. RAJESH KHANNA calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. RAJESH KHANNA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

PUBLIC NOTICE
General public is hereby informed that my client Leel Kumar Gupta (UID 9936 0357 5261), S/o Shri Kashmini Lal, R/o 285, Sector-9, Shastri Nagar, Meerut, U.P. 250004, is the exclusive & absolute owner of property No. 415 alongwith its whole of the structure with roof/terrace rights, situated at Mohalla Maharam, Pandav Road, 30ft. Road, Shahdara, Delhi-110032, who acquired the said property after the death of his sister-in-law, Smt. Pushpa Devi, D/o Shri Behari Lal, W/o V.D. Gupta, by operation of law as legal heir of the said deceased. Smt. Pushpa Devi had purchased the same vide proper Sale Deed regd. No. 5286, Book No. 1, Volume No. 1105, on pages 44 to 47, dated 22.05.1964, in the office of S.R.L. Delhi. Some time ago, I came to know that some unauthorized persons want to deal with or sell the above said property to any third person(s). Anybody dealing with any such unauthorized persons regarding the purchase of the above said property will do so at his own risk and responsibility, and my client will not be responsible for any acts, deeds or dealings done by him.
Rakesh Kumar Advocate

PUBLIC NOTICE
Public at large is hereby informed that Freehold DDA built up LIC Flat No. 1089, Ground Floor, Pocket-C, East of Loni Road, Shahdara, Delhi, presently owned by Smt. Krishna Devi by virtue of Sale Deed duly registered vide Regd. No. Regd. No.5588, dated 31.10.2012 and the same is proposed to be offered as security with State Bank of India. Branch : SME, Bholanath Nagar, New Delhi and as per present version, the said property is/are free from all sorts of encumbrance, except at present mortgage with SBI SMECC, East Delhi, Bholanath Nagar, Delhi and (1) Allotment cum Demand letter dated 03.07.1989-08.07.1989 issued by DDA in favour of Sh. Gautam Singh (2) General Power of Attorney dt. 02.04.1996 executed by Smt. Promilla Rani in favour of Sh. Ram Awatar, duly registered vide Regd. No.9182, dated 02.04.1996 is/are found Laminated.

It is hereby notified that any person and/or Bank, financial institution having any claim, any charge, any interest or lien or claim and / or objection to the same, he/she/they may lodge/ notify the same to the undersigned with documentary proof/ court judgment within 15 days from the day of publication of this public notice, failing which any further / future claim/ objection(s) shall be rejected.

SATYENDER YADAV (Advocate)
Ch.No.581, 3th Floor, Saket Courts, New Delhi. M. 9711212421, Email: satender175@gmail.com

NOTICE
Locker Hired by MR. AMIT JAIN having address at B-601 ALAKNANDA APARTMENTS GH H-5 SEC-56 GURGAON-122002 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at SCO-16, SEC-14 GURUGRAM-122001 remains un-operated from last 12 years & 3 Months and the rent due for the last 8 years.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. AMIT JAIN calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. AMIT JAIN within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Sunita W/o Late Mr. Brahm Prakash who is owner of Property area measuring 35 sq. yds., Part of Khara No. 37/1, Gali No.9, Harijan Basti, Jharoda Majra, situated in the area of village Jharoda Majra, Baran, Delhi-110084 by virtue of Relinquishment Deed dated 11.02.2025 executed by Mr. Amit Kumar S/o Late Mr. Brahm Prakash (2) Mrs. Shipra W/o Mr. Nalin (3) Mr. Sandeep Kumar S/o Late Mr. Brahm Prakash (4) Mr. Praveen Kumar S/o Late Mr. Brahm Prakash (5) Mrs. Pooja D/o Late Mr. Brahm Prakash in favour of Mrs. Sunita W/o Late Mr. Brahm Prakash in respect of Built-Up Property with roof rights upto sky built on land area measuring 35 sq. yds., part of Khara, right No. 37/1, Gali No.9, Harijan Basti, Jharoda Majra, Baran, Delhi-110084 in book no. 1 vol no. 11878 on pages no. 1-12 on dated 24.02.2025 SRI-Kashmere Gate, after removal of late Mr. Brahm Prakash now Mrs. Sunita W/o Late Mr. Brahm Prakash intend to mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD So to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person or any other legal heir(s) of late Brahm Prakash having any type of claim/s right/s interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact @ 011-40045316 & 41687337

PUBLIC NOTICE
Public at large is hereby informed M/s. Vaish Info Systems Private Limited through Mr. Sudhanshu Gupta has claimed to be the leasehold rights owner of the Leasehold Industrial Plot of Land bearing No. 18, Block-C, Sector-3, having area measuring 780.00 Sq. Mtrs., situated in the Jayadev area of New Okhla Industrial Development Area, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) together with 'Factory Building' having RCC Class II Covered Area measuring 387.30 Sq. Mtrs. by virtue of transfer cum sale deed dated 22/02/2019 Doc no. 1028-36- III, Noida. It has been informed that before mentioned documents of above said property have been misplaced - Original Allotment Letter Dated 29.11.1977, Possession Certificate Dated 04.02.1978, Lease Deed Dated 15.04.1980, Functional Certificate executed by NOIDA Authority in favour of M/s. Bharath Carton Private.

And new M/s. Vaish Info Systems Private Limited thru Mr. Sudhanshu Gupta has approached the Federal Bank Ltd for loan against mortgage of the above said property. If any person/ entity has found/information / possession / knowledge of above said misplaced documents or any person, bank / company, authority or any entity has any claim, interest, charge, / line / mortgage, right, or objection in respect of said property or the aforesaid misplaced documents is hereby called upon to intimate and raise the same along with supporting documents, within 3 days in writing from the date of publication of this notice to Vikas Shokeen Advocate, Office at H-20, BASEMENT, BALI NAGR, NEW DELHI-110015, Mob: 9891286119. Thereafter any kind of claim will not be acceptable.

PUBLIC NOTICE
TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN
This is to certify that my client Sh. Irfan Ahmed, S/o Sh. Basheer Ahmed, R/o R-248, Second Floor, Gali No. 4, Near Al Tagwa Masjid, Joga Bai Extension, Jamia Nagar, Okhla, New Delhi-110025, heretby disown and disassociate himself from his son, Sh. Usama Irfan, residing on the Third Floor of the aforesaid property, due to serious differences and therefore, my client shall not be responsible in future for any act of his son namely Sh. Usama Irfan.

MOHD SALMAN (ADVOCATE)
Supreme Court of India/Office Address: 5/27 B, Jangpura B, New Delhi-110014

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Himanshu Talwar who is purchasing DDA built Free Hold CMC Flat No.586, 3rd Floor Pocket-GH-14, situated at Paschim Vihar, Residential Scheme, New Delhi, from Shri Ashwin Gogia s/o Shri (late) M.L. Gogia who had owned the same vide Relinquishment deed dated 27/11/2015. My client, who has the legal heirs of deceased Vee Gogia, now Himanshu Talwar intend to purchase the subject property for the financial assistance from IDBI Bank Ltd. That Surviving member Certificate of Late Mr. Vee Gogia has been lost/misplaced/not available. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/rights/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact @ 011-40045316 & 41687337

I.K. GUJRAL PUNJAB TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY JALANDHAR
(Punjab State Govt. University)
Jalandhar - Kapurthala Highway, Kapurthala -144603
University invites offline EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) from eligible bidders for Emotional well-being services (Online-Offline) for mental health support to the students, staff and faculty members of IKGPTU Main Campus Kapurthala. EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) documents can be downloaded from <https://www.ptu.ac.in/Tender.aspx>.

KEY DATES	
LAST DATE OF SUBMISSION OF EOI ALONG WITH ALL RELEVANT DOCUMENTS	29.09.2026, 04:00 PM
EOI TECHNICAL BID OPENING DATE - OPENING OF FINANCIAL BID -	30.09.2026, 11:00 AM
To be intimated to the Eligible Bidders after Evaluation of Technical Bids	

Note - Any Corrigendum/Addendum/Notice etc shall be uploaded on University Website link i.e. <https://www.ptu.ac.in/Tender.aspx>.
Advt. No. 2026/08/01

REGISTRAR

NOTICE
Locker Hired by MR. ANIL SHARMA having address at 111 GHS ANTRIKSH VIKASPURI NEW DELHI 110018 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at GROUND FLOOR, SHOP NO.- 2 & 3, VATIKA BUSINESS PARK, SOHNA ROAD, BADSHAHPUR GURGAON - 122002 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 8 Months and the rent due for the last 7 years.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. ANIL SHARMA calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. ANIL SHARMA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

NOTICE
Locker Hired by MR. RAJESH KHANNA having address at MF-29 ELDECO MANSIONZ SOHNA ROAD GURGAON HARYANA 122018 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at GROUND FLOOR, SHOP NO.- 2 & 3, VATIKA BUSINESS PARK, SOHNA ROAD, BADSHAHPUR GURGAON - 122002 remains un-operated from last 8 years & 10 Months and the rent due for the last 5 years.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. RAJESH KHANNA calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. RAJESH KHANNA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

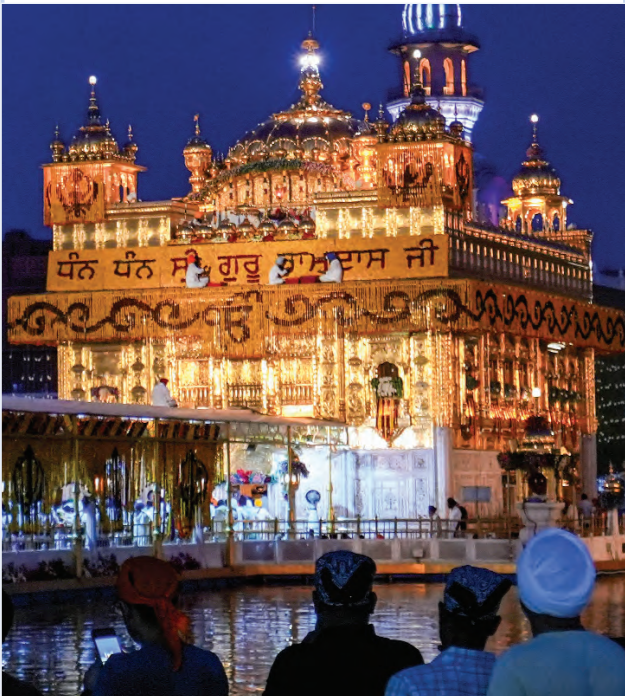
NOTICE
Locker Hired by MR. AMIT JAIN having address at B-601 ALAKNANDA APARTMENTS GH H-5 SEC-56 GURGAON-122002 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at SCO-16, SEC-14 GURUGRAM-122001 remains un-operated from last 12 years & 3 Months and the rent due for the last 8 years.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. AMIT JAIN calling them to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and they are not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by ANITAM TALWAR and MADAN LAL TALWAR within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

NOTICE
Locker Hired by ANITA M TALWAR AND MADAN LAL TALWAR having address at 1030 AZIZA COURT GREAT FALLS VA 20266 1566 UNITED STATES MONTANA-594001 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at SCO-16, SEC-14 GURUGRAM-122001 remains un-operated from last 11 years & 7 Months.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to ANITA M TALWAR and MADAN LAL TALWAR calling them to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and they are not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by ANITAM TALWAR and MADAN LAL TALWAR within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

NOTICE
Locker Hired by MR. SUSHANT MEHTA having address at 18 BROMLEY CT NEW PROVIDENCE NEW JERSEY UNITED STATES 7974 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at GROUND FLOOR, SHOP NO.- 2 & 3, VATIKA BUSINESS PARK, SOHNA ROAD, BADSHAHPUR GURGAON - 122002 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 8 Months.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. SUSHANT MEHTA calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. SUSHANT MEHTA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

NOTICE
Locker Hired by MR. VIKASH KUMAR having address at H NO 69-1 VILL JONIYAWAS TEHSIL FARUKHNAGAR GURGAON HARYANA 131001 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at GROUND FLOOR, SHOP NO.- 2 & 3, VATIKA BUSINESS PARK, SOHNA ROAD, BADSHAHPUR GURGAON - 122002 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 8 Months and the rent due for the last 9 years.
All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. VIKASH KUMAR calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.
It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. VIKASH KUMAR within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

IN FOCUS



People gathering at the Golden Temple, which is illuminated and decorated ahead of Guru Granth Sahib Parkash Utsav, marking the anniversary of the installation of Guru Granth Sahib in Amritsar (PTI)

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Friday slammed a US Department of Homeland Security advertisement asking “Mr Singh” to self-deport as an insult to all Indians, and asked why there had been no strong public rebuttal from the Modi Government on this.

The opposition party termed the Modi Government “weak”, and said it will have to answer the country as to why is it unable to strongly advocate India’s interests. The Congress strong reaction came after an advertisement posted by the Department of Homeland Security asking “Mr Singh” to self-deport sparked off a controversy with advocacy groups terming it racist and anti-American. The Department of Homeland Security (DHS) used AI-generated imagery



on X to push its campaign against unlicensed commercial drivers, featuring a brown-bearded man with a tagline: “Get off our roads, you don’t know how to drive Mr Singh.”

Reacting to it, Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said, “*Modi ji*, who

Congress slams Union Govt over controversial US ad

Government is behaving as if it is a silent partner in this entire episode. An extremely offensive poster targeting ‘Mr Singh’ was issued from the official handle of the US Department of Homeland Security, in which a turbaned Indian was threatened with lines like ‘Get off our roads’ and ‘Self-deport or find out,’” Ramesh said in a post in Hindi on X.

This is not just an insult to one individual or community - it is an insult to the dignity of all Indians, he said. There should have been a strong rebuttal to such racial stereotypes and this level of Governmental rudeness, Ramesh asserted.

After widespread protests in America, the US Department of Homeland Security had to take down this post, he pointed out.

“But even after that, the department continues to defend this campaign and its

language through its official posts. The question is: Why has there been no strong public rebuttal from the Modi Government on this insult to Indians?” Ramesh said.

The special thing is that this is not the first instance of India’s insult under the “weak” Modi Government, the Congress general secretary said. The whole world saw how Indians were sent back to India in a deeply humiliating manner – shackled in handcuffs and leg shackles — on a US military aircraft, he recalled.

Even then, the Modi Government did not raise its voice for the dignity of Indians in front of its “friend”, Ramesh said.

Then America imposed unilateral additional tariffs on India, to which the Modi Government could not muster any effective response, he said. “Why has our diplomatic strength

become so feeble during the tenure of the Modi Government, which boasts of being the ‘vishwaguru’, that India’s interests and sovereignty are facing one blow after another?” Ramesh said.

“Why is the Modi Government silent? Why does the Government of India keep proving itself weak time and again?” he said. Does “friendship” mean that the Trump administration keeps insulting Indians, India’s economic and strategic interests keep getting undermined, and the Modi Government keeps indulging in headline management every time to cover up its own mistakes, Ramesh asked. Friendship is important in foreign policy, but national interest, the dignity of Indians, and India’s sovereignty are paramount, and there can be no compromise on them, the Congress leader asserted.

Govt takes back Ford Foundation’s Lodhi Estate land

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has taken back the land allotted to Ford Foundation, which was operating from 55, Lodhi Estate, New Delhi, since the 1960s, sources said on Friday.

They said eviction proceedings against Ford Foundation were initiated by the Land and Development Office (L&DO) of the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (HUA) last year, following the expiry of its lease for the property. Ford Foundation moved out of the property around five months ago. It has moved to a new official address at Level 8, DLF Centre, Sansad Marg, New Delhi, according to its website.

There was no response from Ford Foundation to an email seeking comments. The Directorate of Estates under the HUA ministry is learnt to have allotted space to the International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA) and another Government agency at 55, Lodhi Estate.

“The Ford Foundation has worked as a partner in India’s progress since 1952. In this time, we have been an ally in independent India’s development journey, responding to the evolving needs and aspirations of its people.”

Over the past seven decades, we have supported India’s leading institutions of management, technology,



science, law, administrative services, public policy, and social impact — many of which are globally recognised and respected,” its website says.

It adds that Ford Foundation has partnered to support the country’s key priorities, including public administration, urban planning, food security, women’s empowerment, inclusive education, preservation of heritage arts, revival of regenerative agriculture and community-led initiatives for the

poor. In 2024, the Union Cabinet approved the creation of the IBCA to set up a global network for the conservation of tigers and other big cats.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had hailed the Cabinet’s decision on the establishment of the IBCA, saying it marks a major step towards conserving “our majestic big cats and their habitats”. According to the IBCA website, it is currently operating from the first floor at Shanti Niketan, New Delhi.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Five days after a group of people attacked staff at a private hospital over the treatment of an injured ‘Govinda’, Palghar Police in Maharashtra on Friday arrested 14 persons including a Shiv Sena MLA’s son even as the Bombay High Court termed the probe so far as “ridiculous and seriously flawed” and sought a report from a high-ranking official.

The action taken by the Palghar police appeared to be “merely superficial and seemed to have been carried out in a manner that would ultimately benefit the accused”, the High Court said. On the intervening night of September 5 and 6, Sena workers barged into Relief Hospital at Palghar where a few injured ‘Govindas’ who had participated in the Dahi Handi celebrations had been admitted. Claiming that the hospital was charging exorbitant fees, they allegedly van-



dalised the property, threatened the doctors, assaulted staff members and forcibly took away one of the injured persons from the ICU.

Shiv Sena Palghar city chief

Rahul Gharat was arrested in the case on September 7, following which he was suspended from the party. A police official said another 14 persons were arrested on

Friday, including MLA Rajendra Gavli’s son Rohit. The police have registered a First Information Report against a total of 22 persons. In the High Court, the bench of Justices A S Gadgari and Kamal Khata directed the Additional Inspector General of Police, Konkan division, to examine the investigation and submit a report on September 17 stating whether the action taken by the Palghar police was legally proper. The bench questioned the “lackadaisical” manner in which the investigation had been carried out so far, from the preparation of the panchnama (spot inspection report) to the station case diary entries.

The bench was originally hearing a plea taken up suo motu (on its own) into the assault that occurred at a civic hospital in Thane in July, in which Shiv Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre is an accused, when senior counsel Ashok Mundargi informed it about the Palghar incident.

A warm embrace and a tough message

Against the backdrop of conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia, Putin’s visit gives New Delhi and Moscow an opportunity to review their long-standing strategic partnership while discussing some of the most pressing challenges confronting the international system.

Putin takes swipe at G7

In contrast, he said, the contribution of the G7 stands at only 29 per cent.

Addressing the gathering of BRICS business leaders ahead of the summit, Putin said Russia was ready to work with partners on infrastructure and logistics projects, including the Arctic Transport Corridor and North-South Transport Corridor, as well as cooperation in technology, artificial intelligence, unmanned transport, finance, tourism and industry.

“We are not against anyone,” Putin said. “We are in favour of our interests,” while asserting that BRICS remained open to cooperation with the wider world. Putin said the proposed NDB-based investment platform would seek to mobilise private-sector funding and make BRICS economies more competitive. He expressed hope that other BRICS members would support the initiative.

“We need funding,” Putin said, adding that the NDB was already doing significant work but could provide the basis for a broader investment mechanism. BRICS members have been exploring ways to increase development financing, infrastructure investment and the use of local financial resources while reducing dependence on traditional Western-led financial institutions.

The proposal came as Putin highlighted what he described as a major shift in the global economic balance towards BRICS economies. He said more than 40 per cent of global GDP had been produced by BRICS countries over the past five years, compared with 29 per cent for the G7, while BRICS accounted for more than half of global economic growth during the period.

“The world is always changing,” he said, arguing that the economic weight of the traditional growth centres of the second half of the 20th century was being replaced by new engines of growth. The Russian President framed the expanding BRICS economic architecture as an effort to advance national interests rather than exclude other countries.

He argued that cooperation among governments, businesses and academia was helping BRICS build a resilient platform for global growth based on innovation and national priorities. The most important elements of this growth are not being imposed on anyone from the outside,” Putin said.

Putin cited Indian company Mahindra as one of several BRICS corporate success stories, highlighting its work in IT and artificial intelligence alongside China’s Huawei, Brazil’s Embraer, UAE-based TPO and Russia’s Rosatom.

He said the rise of national companies across

BRICS reflected the strength of the grouping’s large domestic markets, rapid urbanisation and expanding technological capabilities.

Putin said Russia itself was pursuing large-scale technological innovation in areas including AI, autonomous systems, digital platforms and financial technology, relying on domestic solutions as well as technologies developed with BRICS partners. The Russian President, who is on a three-day visit to India, placed infrastructure and logistics at the centre of his call for deeper business-to-business ties, saying stronger economic partnerships would help BRICS countries build more resilient economic relationships.

He identified the Arctic Transport Corridor and the North-South Transport Corridor as key areas where Russia could work with partners, alongside efforts to strengthen energy and food security. Russia, he said, had established a national committee for business cooperation comprising more than 40 major Russian companies to develop substantive programmes with foreign partners.

Putin rejected the idea that Russia or BRICS was seeking economic isolation, saying Moscow was ready to cooperate with both existing and new partners. “We are open to working with the whole world,” he said, adding that the BRICS Business Council could provide additional momentum to trade and economic ties and help advance projects in infrastructure, logistics, finance and technological cooperation.

At the same time, Putin sharply criticised sanctions and other restrictions, arguing that competition was increasingly taking forms that included trade restrictions, pressure on transport routes and secondary sanctions.

He criticised Western trade and financial restrictions, saying competition was increasingly taking “ugly forms” at both corporate and state levels. Citing pipeline disruptions, attempts to block international transport corridors, seizures of maritime vessels and the use of secondary sanctions, he claimed Russia had faced more than 30,000 sanctions. He said Russia had responded by changing the geography of its foreign trade and making its economy more resilient and agile.

Goyal calls for deeper BRICS trade relations

He added that sectors including agriculture, pharmaceuticals, engineering, electronics, automobiles, auto components, and services hold immense potential for increasing cooperation.

Speaking at the session, Russian Economic Development Minister Maxim Reshetnikov said, “We stand for concrete steps to foster resilient supply chains, to accelerate green and digital transition...Russia strongly welcomes foreign businesses to enter our country. Today we are the economy of opportunities.”

He suggested BRICS members to focus on two specific initiatives — BRICS grain exchange, and BRICS SEZs Association. He added that BRICS countries are among the world’s leading produc-

ers and consumers, but they still rely on price benchmarks that reflect the interests of entirely different markets.

“We urgently need two independent mechanisms for strategic agricultural commodities,” Reshetnikov said adding Russia has prepared a detailed plan to establish the BRICS grain exchange. It’s a unified trading platform where producers, traders and buyers can conclude transactions directly, he said adding “we call upon partners’ feedback at the public and the private level”. He called for joining hands in developing BRICS business navigator for investors and to participate in SEZs ranking across BRICS countries. “Today fragmentation divides, instability isolates, but together we endure. The strength of BRICS lies not in what each of us can achieve alone, but in what we can build side by side. That is resilient supply chains, shared prosperity and a more balanced global economy. Let us continue this work not as competitors, but as partners in shared economic future,” he said.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal called for taking steps to bridge trade finance gaps.

“With the global trade finance gap estimated at USD 2.5 trillion, we should enable exporters to access affordable working capital based on confirmed orders and reliable payment records,” he said. The Jaipur consensus provides an important foundation for exploring a common BRICS mechanism in this regard. Adopted at the 16th BRICS trade ministers’ meeting in August 2026 in Jaipur, under India’s BRICS chairship, the Jaipur consensus focuses on easing trade-finance constraints for micro, small, and medium enterprises.”“The (BRICS) ministers further resolved to strengthen the global value chains through BRICS Connect, enhanced B2B partnerships, an annual BRICS Trade and Investment Expo, digital trade documentation and greater cooperation across multiple sectors, including healthcare,” Agarwal said.

Modi-Putin turn a car ride into backseat...

Putin invited Modi to Russia for the next annual summit; Modi accepted. Ukraine and West Asia hovered in the background, as they do at every such meeting. The conversation continued well after the vehicle had stopped.

The Aurus Senat is Russia’s answer to the idea that a great power should not borrow its presidential car from someone else. Developed by NAMI and Aurus Motors after years of Mercedes dominance in the Kremlin garage, it is a long, heavy, heavily protected limousine powered by a twin-turbo V8 and built to shrug off small-arms fire, blast and chemical threats.

Officials call it a fortress on wheels. It travels with Putin on foreign visits, flown in on military transports, a rolling declaration of industrial self-reliance. Sharing it is not casual hospitality. It is a public grant of proximity.

China makes the same argument with different metal. Xi Jinping’s official car, the Hongqi N701,

is produced in tiny numbers for the top leadership only. Specs are guarded. Reports describe thick armour, blast-resistant glass, special steel, and a powertrain that remains officially opaque. Hongqi, “Red Flag”, was born as a party car.

The N701 is its latest iteration: not a consumer product, but a state object that travels with the Chinese president the way Air Force One travels with an American one. When such cars appear in a foreign capital, they announce that the occupant has brought his own fortress and his own flag. Leaders have long used vehicles this way.

The American “Beast,” the British Bentley State Limousine, Japan’s Toyota Century Royal: each is a mobile embassy, a security vault and a billboard for national industry. What has changed is the willingness to turn the ride itself into the message. A shared car compresses protocol. It creates a private interval that official minutes cannot capture. It also photographs well.

In an expanded 11-member BRICS gathering that brings together China, Russia, Iran and a cluster of other states with competing interests, such images do quiet work. They do not settle trade disputes or end wars. They do signal that personal chemistry remains a working tool of statecraft, and that Moscow and New Delhi still prefer to display that chemistry in public.

The Aurus will leave when Putin does. The photograph of two men in the same cabin will linger longer than the communiqué.

BJP hits back at Opposition on BRICS

Senior BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad alleged that during the tenure of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, India’s position in BRICS had reached a stage where people were saying that “India” should be removed and “Indonesia” should replace the “I” in BRICS.

“Congress leaders, who are lamenting and asking what did India gain, should remember that the truth is, you ruined it, we rebuilt it,” he said. “During the Congress regime, India was described as one of the Fragile Five and a junk economy, whereas under the leadership of PM Narendra Modi, India has become one of the world’s top five economies and emerged as the shining star of BRICS,” he added.

He said the BJP has rebuilt and strengthened the country, making it a “bright” spot in the world. “India is also a bright spot within BRICS, and the world is looking towards India with enthusiasm and confidence. Today, India is a major global economy that contributes to stability in the global economy,” he added.

The former Union minister said this has been possible despite challenges such as the energy crisis, problems with global supply chains and the ongoing war in the Gulf, with India’s growth rate standing at 7.8 per cent, which the IMF has acknowledged as accurate and described as a sign of the strength of the Indian economy.

“The IMF also appreciated the manner in which India is progressing in the services sector, manufacturing sector and trade,” he said.

He alleged that whenever there is a discussion on foreign policy, Congress leaders unnecessarily attempt to create an adverse atmosphere within the country. Prasad asserted that the presence of heads of state and government from Russia, South Africa, Egypt, China and Iran at the summit reflects India’s growing influence.

Separately, in a video message, BJP MP and national spokesperson Sambit Patra said that while the “I” in BRICS was “turning shaky” in 2011-12, India is now one of the strongest partners of BRICS. “Today, India has found its position in the global arena as never before,” he said.

“Remember, the ‘I’ in BRICS stands for India, and the ‘I’ in India stands for the 140 crore people of India. I am India. I am one of the strongest partners of BRICS, and I am proud of it. Today, I am proud to be a citizen of India and a very strong member of BRICS,” he added.

Modi, Pezeshkian talk West Asia

Speaking at the BRICS Business Forum Pezeshkian urged member countries to expand local-currency settlements and develop mechanisms to manage currency risks. He argued that BRICS must move beyond its combined economic size and create practical networks for trade, investment and joint financing.

“The true strength of BRICS is not confined merely to the size of its members’ economies; rather, it becomes more apparent when these capacities are transformed into a network of trade, investment, and joint financing,” he said.

The concentration of the international financial system around a limited number of currencies had increased the vulnerability of global trade to political pressure and external shocks, he added. He called for deeper integration of trade infrastructure, including digitalised customs procedures, reduced regulatory barriers and stronger cross-border markets. Pezeshkian also urged the New Development Bank to emerge as the principal financing engine for infrastructure and energy projects across BRICS countries, while proposing greater use of local-currency lending, dedicated credit lines and guarantee instruments to attract private-sector investment into major projects. The push for greater use of national currencies has emerged as a key element of efforts within the grouping to reduce dependence on a limited number of international currencies and strengthen intra-BRICS economic ties.

The BRICS Summit is being held against a backdrop of heightened geopolitical and economic uncertainty. The Russia-Ukraine war, continuing tensions in West Asia, concerns over the Strait of Hormuz and changing US trade and tariff policies have added pressure to global supply chains and energy markets. For India, maintaining energy security and protecting vital maritime trade routes remain key priorities. Against this backdrop, the calls from Iran and Russia for greater reliance on national currencies put financial cooperation at the centre of the BRICS agenda.

The BRICS fortress: Four rings around Russian President Putin

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

By Friday night, the ITC Maurya in Chanakyapuri no longer resembled a five-star hotel. It had become the inner keep of Operation BRICS Kavach, the multi-agency lockdown built to protect Russian President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping and at least 16 other heads of state and Government gathering for the 18th BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam on September 12 and 13.

Putin landed at Palam Air Force Station in the early hours of September 11 aboard the Ilyushin Il-96-300PU, the aircraft known as the Flying Kremlin, escorted by decoy jets and layered with missile-defence countermeasures.

On the ground, Putin travelled in the Aurus Senat, an armoured car brought from Moscow that can withstand

landmines, chemical attacks, and sniper fire. Surrounding him, Delhi Police, the National Security Guard, paramilitary units, and Russia's Federal Protective Service set up four security rings. The first ring is a Close Protection Team of 25 to 30 Russian commandos who stay with the President at all times.

The second ring consists of senior Delhi Police officers. The third ring includes Delhi Police commandos and Central Armed Police Force members. The fourth, outer ring is local police covering the streets, rooftops, and areas around the hotel.

Maurya staff were vetted in both Delhi and their home states. Some rooms became command posts connected to the city's C4I centre. AI cameras monitored for suspicious behaviour, such as unusual posture or lingering. Russian teams checked every

corridor, rooftop, and kitchen. The delegation brought personal chefs and portable food-testing labs. Fake dignitaries were placed in some hotels to confuse any potential threats.

President Xi Jinping is expected to arrive at Palam on September 12 and will stay at the Taj hotel.

The Delhi Police Special Cell will handle his security. Chinese security officers arrived days in advance with their own equipment and now control certain floors, rooftops, and the area around the hotel. Other high-risk guests, like Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian, have been given separate hotels. Across Delhi, 11 to 13 luxury hotels have become secure zones, each led by a DCP-level commander.

Officials estimate about 15,000 Delhi Police officers and 200 paramilitary compa-



(From left) Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian, Russia's President Vladimir Putin, India's Prime Minister Narendra Modi, South Africa's President Cyril Ramaphosa and Brazil's Foreign Minister Mauro Vieira during the BRICS Business Forum at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi

PTI

nies are involved, with the total reaching around 30,000 when including airport, hotel, and venue staff. Over 100 NSG commandos are ready to respond quickly.

As part of Operation BRICS

Kavach, security teams practised helicopter descents, hostage rescues, and mock terror attacks at places like Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, Rajghat, Bharat Mandapam, and the Army Polo Ground.

Snipers are stationed on rooftops. Gesture-recognising cameras scan the crowds. Anti-drone systems protect 14 key points along the routes from the airport to the hotels and the summit venue.

Putin's decoy jets land in Delhi: What's inside the Flying Kremlin

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Vladimir Putin, the Russian president, has arrived in New Delhi for the BRICS Summit, yet the plane that brought him is attracting as much attention as the diplomatic activities themselves.

He landed at the Palam Air Force Station having travelled by one of two identical Ilyushin Il-96-300PU aircraft. The two planes took off together and were identical in model, colour, and shape, using a well-established decoy technique designed to prevent foreigners from figuring out which plane carries the president.

The presidential command aircraft known as the Il-96-300PU is commonly referred to as the Flying Kremlin and is more loosely known as a "doomsday plane". The "PU" stands for Punkt Upravleniya, which means command post. Based on a four-engine long-range airliner, it is 55.35 metres long, has a 60.12-metre wingspan, and is powered by Aviadvigatel PS-90A turbofans. The aircraft can fly about 11,000 kilometres without refuelling and is operated by the Special Flight Detachment Rossiya.

What is unusual about this jet is not its size but its function; it is equipped with encrypted communication systems, satellite links, and secure radio channels so the president can remain in



Russian President Vladimir Putin arrives to attend the 18th BRICS Summit at the Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport in New Delhi

PTI

contact with Government, military, and intelligence networks while in the air.

It also has defensive systems, allegedly including radar-jamming equipment, electronic countermeasures, and decoy launchers intended to confuse incoming missiles. The exact specifications are still classified. The term 'doomsday' comes from its wartime role. According to Russian descriptions of the Il-96-300PU, the aircraft can

serve as an airborne command post and help direct the armed forces during a nuclear crisis.

It is commonly believed to carry a nuclear 'button'. However, this goes beyond what is publicly known.

The system that authorises the use of nuclear weapons in Russia is linked to the Cheget briefcase that accompanies the president, not to a single switch on the plane. Although the aircraft is

capable of carrying out secure strategic command, it is not independently verified as a stand-alone means of launching a nuclear weapon. Inside the plane, it has been fitted out to serve as both a residence and a workplace.

The reports mention a private suite which includes a bedroom, an office, a conference room, a dining area, a kitchen, a medical section and a small gym.

The cabin is of a high standard and has woodwork, leather and gold-coloured fittings. However, the luxurious details are based on second-hand accounts rather than the official inventory.

The twin-jet protocol is part of a broader security arrangement, since support aircraft have already transported equipment to India, including the president's armoured Aurus limousines, and Russian security officers are working with Indian security at the summit sites.

Putin is visiting Delhi to hold bilateral talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi before the two-day BRICS leaders' meeting at Bharat Mandapam.

This is his first in-person appearance at a BRICS event outside of Russia since the outbreak of the war in Ukraine. The plane that transported him reminds us that, even at a diplomatic event, the Russian president travels within a self-contained command post.

National Capital gets BRICS makeover ahead of summit at Bharat Mandapam



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The national Capital has got a BRICS makeover, with illuminated roundabouts, floral displays, freshly landscaped roads and summit-themed signage transforming key stretches of the Capital ahead of the 18th BRICS Leaders' Summit. Officials said decorative lighting has been installed at several locations, including Patel Chowk, Windsor Place, Mandi House, Teen Murti, Lok Kalyan Metro Station and the PMO roundabout.

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has also installed LED signages carrying the BRICS Summit logo and put up summit-themed posters on street-light poles along important routes.

The civic body has stepped up beautification, lighting and horticultural works across its jurisdiction, with a focus on routes linking the

airport and designated hotels with the summit venue, Bharat Mandapam, in the heart of the city.

The 18th BRICS Leaders' Summit 2026 will be held on September 12 and 13, with India hosting the meeting as chair of the grouping.

Key leaders of BRICS member and partner countries, along with outreach invitees, are expected to take part in discussions on strengthening cooperation and key global and regional issues.

Seventeen major roundabouts, at least a dozen hotel premises and 10 prominent NDMC buildings are being illuminated as part of the preparations, officials said. Trees, shrubs and landscaped areas around important hotels and along key roads are also being illuminated.

In addition, the NDMC has completed verification of streetlights along all summit-

related routes and replaced faulty lights identified during the exercise. Around 350 electrical panel boxes along roads have also been given a facelift with BRICS-themed branding.

The lighting arrangements come alongside an extensive horticultural drive, under which more than 15,000 potted ornamental plants are being placed at prominent locations across New Delhi. Floral boards are being installed at 15 locations and floral fountains at nine others, while landscaping, plantation, pruning and trimming of hedges and shrubs have been intensified along major avenues and VIP routes, officials said.

The NDMC has also stepped up work at the BRICS Friendship Rose Garden in Chanakyapuri, which was established in 2016 when India hosted the summit and has 107 varieties of roses. Landscaping, pruning,

grass cutting and decorative floral arrangements are being carried out at the garden and along surrounding routes in the diplomatic enclave.

The broader preparations have also seen the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and the Public Works Department carry out joint inspections of key areas, including Bharat Mandapam, Sarai Kale Khan, Lodhi Road, Nizamuddin, Saket and Sheikh Sarai.

Officials have been directed to intensify sanitation and cleaning work and ensure adequate deployment of workers and machinery along identified routes and other important locations.

The preparations are part of a wider effort by Delhi authorities to spruce up public spaces and ensure the city is ready to receive delegates and visitors for the summit.

BRICS traffic curbs: Chaos for some, breeze for others

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As traffic restrictions for the BRICS Summit came into effect in parts of Delhi, commuters on Friday reported contrasting experiences, with some complaining of being forced to walk and others experiencing holiday-like atmosphere that made their journeys smooth. "BRICS restricted traffic in Lutyens' Delhi, Zomato gave up, and I had to walk to get lunch today. Working in trade policy is all fun and games until you personally become the supply chain," a user posted on X.

Social media was flooded with such reactions to the traffic arrangements to facilitate the movement of foreign dignitaries and their convoys during the summit, reflecting the mixed impact of the restrictions across different parts of the city.

Another commuter reported being stuck for more than 40 minutes near Max Hospital in Saket, saying, "Traffic not moved over 40 mins. Outside Max hospital Saket. Entire Press Enclave road halted." However, not all commuters experienced disruption.

Some users said the restrictions, coupled with fewer people travelling because of office holidays and work-from-home arrangements, had actually resulted in significantly faster journeys.

"On a normal day, my home-to-Delhi Airport journey takes a comfortable



Traffic has been diverted on several routes due to the BRICS Summit, causing vehicles to get stuck in traffic jams on the Ring Road in front of Safdarjung Hospital in New Delhi on Friday

PANKAJ KUMAR

45 minutes. Today, with the BRICS Summit, traffic restrictions and a holiday for most offices, it took just 14 minutes," one user posted, joking that Delhi had "finally solved its traffic problem".

Another user, who attended a business breakfast at The Imperial in central Delhi, said they had approached the journey with "so much trepidation" but found the roads largely free-flowing.

"Once-a-week-stay-home-for-brics should be institutionalised!!" the user posted.

While roads forming part of VIP movement corridors have witnessed stoppages and diversions, reduced traffic volumes on other stretches appear to have

offset some of the disruption for commuters.

The Delhi Traffic Police had earlier clarified that the city would not be shut down during the summit and that normal traffic would continue wherever security arrangements permitted.

On September 12, traffic restrictions will also be in force from 8.15 pm to 11 pm, during which traffic movement will be regulated along important stretches in and around central Delhi.

According to the traffic advisory map, controlled traffic movement will be implemented on several major roads leading towards the central Delhi area, while a prohibited zone has been

earmarked around Bharat Mandapam and Pragati Maidan.

Restrictions have been imposed in notified controlled areas and on routes being used for the movement of foreign delegations and dignitaries.

Traffic may be temporarily stopped or diverted depending on security requirements and the prevailing ground situation.

The traffic arrangements are expected to remain in force during the summit period, with restrictions linked to the movement of dignitaries extending from September 10 to around September 14, officials said. More than 4,800 traffic

personnel have been deployed for the summit arrangements. Over 35 roads are expected to be affected during the summit period, while key stretches such as Mathura Road, Sardar Patel Marg, Shanti Path, Janpath, Ashoka Road, Barakhamba Road, Tolstoy Marg, Africa Avenue Road, Niti Marg and Panchsheel Marg are among those likely to see restrictions.

Traffic police have advised commuters to check their routes before setting out and allow additional travel time, particularly those travelling towards central Delhi, the airport, south Delhi and other areas linked to VIP movement.

CM welcomes world leaders for BRICS Summit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday extended a warm welcome to global leaders, delegates and other guests attending the BRICS Summit 2026 hosted by Delhi.

Russian President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and several global leaders will be attending the summit in the national capital.

Chief Minister Gupta said in a post on X, "For Delhi, hosting BRICS is a moment of honour and pride. We welcome our guests to experience a Capital shaped by centuries of history, enriched by many cultures and guided by the timeless Indian spirit of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam."



She said that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Bharat has brought "greater" confidence, balance and purpose to global engagement, with dialogue, trust and shared progress at its core.

The two-day BRICS Summit 2026 hosted by

India, starting Saturday, is expected to focus on boosting collective resilience in food, energy, health, disaster reduction, and critical supply chains, with New Delhi positioning the bloc as an effective anchor to navigate a fragmented geopolitical environment.

Metro to start early at 6 am Sunday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Metro train services will begin at 6 am on all corridors on Sunday to facilitate the movement of students appearing for examinations and commuters amid traffic restrictions for the BRICS Summit, the DMRC said on Friday. Normally, services on the Pink, Magenta and Grey lines begin at 7 am on Sundays.

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said in a post on X, "To facilitate the smooth and timely move-



ment of students appearing for examinations and the general public amid traffic restrictions due to the BRICS Summit, Metro train services will commence at 6 am on all lines on Sunday."

The early commencement

of services will facilitate the movement of candidates appearing for the NDA/CDS examinations, as well as the general public, the DMRC said. The Delhi Traffic Police said in a post on X that it had received a request from a CDS aspirant regarding the availability of early morning Metro services to reach the examination centre before the reporting time.

Taking note of the concern, the traffic police coordinated with the DMRC to facilitate candidates appearing for the NDA/CDS examinations.

BRICS should be non-West, not anti-West, says Tharoor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Senior Congress leader Shashi Tharoor has said some countries other than India in BRICS are very happy to consider the grouping as an “anti-Western” platform and asserted that such an outlook was not in India’s national interest.

Tharoor asserted that BRICS should be a forum that is “non-West, but not anti-West”.

Speaking with PTI Videos, the former minister of state for external affairs also said hosting BRICS is a matter of “great prestige” for India, with a dozen heads of state and government, not only members of BRICS but also some observers, coming at presidential and prime ministerial level.

Tharoor said that as chair, India has a particular responsibility to showcase the concerns of the Global South, while also bearing very carefully in mind India’s direct national interests.

“We want BRICS to be a forum that is non-West, but not anti-West. That is not the same agenda as every other country. Some others in BRICS are very happy to take it as a geopolitical non-Western, but also anti-Western platform,” the senior Congress leader said.

“And I would like to say that that would not be in India’s national interest,” he added.

Tharoor noted that with several world leaders in India, there will be significant bilateral conversations.



“Our Prime Minister (Narendra Modi) is bound to be meeting each of the visiting heads of state and government who seek a meeting. And that may mean a dozen important meetings with these country leaders.

“And for us, of course, both the meeting with President Xi and the meeting with President Putin are going to grab world headlines,” he said, adding there would be other key important meetings.

On India-China ties, Tharoor said the difficulties in the relationship have come entirely from one side, as ever since the Galwan tragedy of 2020, the relations between the two countries have been completely in bad shape.

“And on top of that, the Chinese have been undertaking a lot of acts that can only be considered hostile. They’ve been trying to change, in various portions, the ground realities along the border, along the undefined border between our two countries.

“They have made state-

ments that we cannot consider helpful. They have been very difficult on issues like visas for Indians, randomly rejecting many of them,” Tharoor said.

And worst of all, the Chinese have used a lot of trade leverage; that is, they have exploited the dependency of Indian importers on a lot of essential Chinese goods to simply withhold these goods when it suited them, he said.

“A self-respecting India is not going to keep knuckling under to those things. I think it’s important to understand that we will also stand up for ourselves in one way or the other.”

“So yes, the bilateral relationship, the bilateral meeting, is potentially very important, but what we’re looking for is a little more flexibility, understanding, and friendship coming from the Chinese side than they’ve shown us in the last six years,” he said.

Tharoor said that through the BRICS Summit, India is providing an important plat-

form for the Global South.

“This grouping, the 11 BRICS countries, represents a majority of the world’s population and 41 per cent of global GDP. It’s not a small matter; it’s something that has to be taken very seriously by the rest of the world. Secondly, of course, having a dozen heads of state and government, not only members of BRICS but also some observers coming at the presidential and prime ministerial level, this is a matter of great prestige for us,” he said.

“It shows a certain diplomatic convening power, which has value in and of itself on the global stage,” the Congress MP from Thiruvananthapuram said.

Listing the challenges, Tharoor said it is difficult to find a convergence of views, for example, on an agreed declaration on global issues.

“When the foreign ministers tried to meet in the summer, they couldn’t agree on the Iran-Iraq war, on the Russia-Ukraine war and so on, on how to express a collective view. And that would be a challenge.

“When the foreign ministers met, we ended up with India as chairman issuing a chairman’s declaration rather than an agreed joint declaration. Will that happen again, which would perhaps be seen by some as a setback and perhaps even as an indication of the group’s fundamental incoherence, or will we be able to paper over the differences? That’s going to be a real challenge for our diplomats,” Tharoor said.

BRICS must ensure transparent trade, investment practices, says Jaishankar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BRICS must address growing global market volatility by adopting transparent, open trade and investment practices with a broader goal to ensure economic stability, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Friday.

In an address at the BRICS Business Forum, he also spoke about geopolitical upheavals and underlined the need for concerted efforts to address supply chain disruptions as they are having economic consequences for countries around the world.

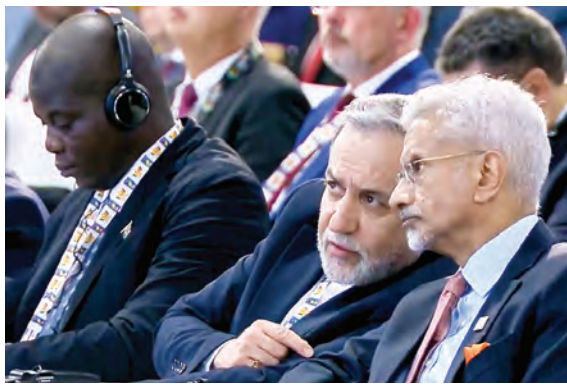
“We meet at a time when global political and economic order is under churn. Volatility, uncertainty, and complexity have become defining features of the world around us,” he said.

“We are witnessing the economic consequences of geopolitical conflicts, of pandemics, and of climate-related disruptions,” he said.

The external affairs minister underlined the need for greater market access and supply chain resilience to spur economic growth.

“The common thread is how to make it easier for businesses in our countries to find more partners, access more markets, connect supply networks and convert complementarities into viable commercial partnerships,” he said.

“For BRICS particularly, higher economic activity and higher economic secu-



rity mean greater self-reliance. The objective is to strengthen our ability to absorb shocks while remaining connected and competitive,” he said.

Jaishankar said the situation calls for “genuine market practices, dependable logistics, a predictable business environment, diversified commercial relationships, and transparent trade and investment”.

“It also calls for energy systems capable of coping with disruption and transition pathways that are suited to different national circumstances,” he said.

India is hosting the BRICS summit on Saturday and Sunday in New Delhi.

Jaishankar said resilience has become a key component of the BRICS community while stressing the need for greater self-reliance while remaining connected and competitive through genuine market practices, dependable logistics and diversified commercial relationships. He also highlighted digital public infrastructure, artificial intelligence,

fintech and advanced manufacturing as major opportunities, while noting questions of access, standards, security and trust.

He said India’s chairship of BRICS has sought to strengthen the innovation and entrepreneurial ecosystem through the BRICS incubator network and BRICS Startup Innovation Fund, stressing that the benefits must be accessible across the full spectrum of business communities.

India’s experience makes it a natural partner, with a large and growing market, expanding manufacturing capabilities, deeper pools of talent, digital experience and a dynamic innovation and entrepreneurial base, he said.

As BRICS leaders prepare to meet, he said the Forum’s most useful contribution would be to bring a clear business perspective to the next phase of BRICS cooperation, focusing on opportunities, challenges faced by businesses and what governments can do to address them, the external affairs minister added.

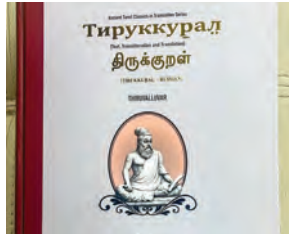
VP hails Modi’s gift of Tamil classic to Putin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Friday expressed delight at Prime Minister Narendra Modi gifting a Tamil classic to Russian President Vladimir Putin, saying India’s rich heritage is crossing borders and languages.

Modi presented the Russian translation of the Thirukkural, a Tamil classic and timeless work of wisdom, to Putin on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit.

Radhakrishnan said the gift is a beautiful celebration of “our” enduring civilisational heritage.



“The universal wisdom of Thiruvalluvar continues to transcend languages, cultures and borders, carrying the timeless message of Bharat to the world,” the vice president said in a social media post.

The vice president hails from Tamil Nadu.

Russian President Vladimir Putin, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres and several other leaders arrived in Delhi on Friday to attend the two-day BRICS summit that gets underway the following day.

PM Modi meets UN chief ahead of BRICS Summit



Prime Minister Narendra Modi meets United Nations Secretary General Antonio Guterres in New Delhi

PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday met with UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres ahead of the BRICS Summit, as both leaders held discussions on various issues, including ongoing conflicts and freedom of navigation, sustainable development, human-centric AI and global food security.

Both leaders also underscored the significance of “multipolarity” and the need to reform multilateral institutions, including the UNSC, to “reflect contemporary realities,” the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said.

India is hosting the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi on September 12-13.

Prime Minister Modi met with the UN Secretary-

General on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit here, it said. “UNSG Guterres congratulated PM Modi for India’s chairship of the BRICS for the fourth time. Both leaders underscored the significance of multipolarity and the need to reform multilateral institutions, including the UN Security Council, to reflect contemporary realities,” it said in a statement.

“They also held discussions on various issues, including ongoing conflicts and freedom of navigation, sustainable development, human-centric AI, progress in renewable energy and global food security,” the MEA said. PM Modi also wished UNSG Guterres the very best for the remainder of his tenure.

In a post on X, he wrote, “Had a wonderful meeting

with UN Secretary-General Mr. Antonio Guterres. Discussed multiple subjects including the ground covered in India’s BRICS Presidency, India’s commitment to strengthening multilateralism and the urgent need for UN reforms. @antonio_guterres @UN #BRICSIndia2026.”

Russian President Vladimir Putin, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and several other leaders arrived in Delhi on Friday to attend the two-day BRICS summit that gets underway from Saturday.

President of New Development Bank Dilma Rousseff and Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank Chief Zou Jiayi have also reached the capital for the summit.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Russian President Vladimir Putin, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and several other leaders arrived in Delhi on Friday to attend the two-day BRICS summit that gets underway from September 12.

Egyptian President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi, Vice President of Uganda Jessica Alupo and Vice President of Nigeria Sen. Kashim Shettima have also reached the national capital for the mega conclave.

India is hosting the 18th BRICS summit at Bharat

Mandapam on September 12 and 13. India assumed its fourth BRICS Chairship on January 1. The year 2026 also marks a milestone as BRICS completes 20 years since its establishment.

“Warmly welcome President Cyril Ramaphosa of South Africa for the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi. He was received by MoS Jayant Singh at the airport. India and South Africa share warm and historic ties anchored in Strategic Partnership. Our commitment as BRICS partners to the Global South remains steadfast. #BRICS2026 #BRICSIndia2026 #IndiaBRICSChairship,” the



Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) posted on X.

On President El-Sisi’s arrival, it said, “Warmly welcome President of Egypt, Abdel Fattah el-Sisi to the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi. He was received by MoS

Sanjay Seth at the airport.

India and Egypt share deep bonds of friendship, as we work together to build a stronger BRICS partnership. #BRICS2026 #BRICSIndia2026 #IndiaBRICSChairship.”

BRICS, originally compris-

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As global trade disputes and geopolitical upheavals unleash economic headwinds, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Chinese President Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin, and other leaders from BRICS nations will gather on Saturday for the India-hosted summit to navigate global challenges, including insulating developing economies from the impact of conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia.

In a strategic balancing act, New Delhi is looking at leveraging the two-day annual summit to position the grouping as a complementary engine for economic growth while being mindful of sensitivities of the United States and other

Western powers, especially in the trade and energy domains.

As the BRICS chair, India has placed the Global South at the heart of its agenda by seeking actionable solutions for food, energy, and supply chain security primarily to insulate the developing nations from the economic consequences of the conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia.

Besides Xi and Putin, the other leaders attending the New Delhi BRICS summit are Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto, Egyptian President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi, Malaysian Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim, Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, and Ethiopian Prime Minister Abiy



Ahmed Ali and Vietnamese Prime Minister Le Minh Hung.

UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres, WTO Director General Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala, WHO chief Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, New Development Bank (NDB) president Dilma Rousseff

and Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank Chief Zou Jiayi will also be attending the BRICS summit.

While the Brazilian delegation will be headed by Foreign Minister Mauro Vieira, Thai Deputy Prime Minister Sihasak Phuangketkeow, Uzbek Deputy PM Jamshid

ing Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the UAE and Saudi Arabia, with Indonesia joining in 2025. Belarus, Bolivia, Kazakhstan, Cuba, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Uganda, Uzbekistan and Vietnam became BRICS partner countries last year.

BRICS has emerged as an influential grouping as it brings together 11 major emerging economies of the world, representing around 49.5 per cent of the global population, around 40 per cent of the global GDP and around 26 per cent of the global trade.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi delivers an address during the Leaders' Session of the BRICS Business Forum at Bharat Mandapam

PTI

PM Modi pushes BRICS to tear down trade barriers, backs freedom of navigation and seafarers’ safety

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday called for BRICS to turn its growing economic weight into greater investment and expanded business ties, stressing that freedom of navigation, secure sea lanes and the safety of seafarers were essential to keeping global trade running.

Addressing the BRICS Business Forum in India, Modi urged the grouping to identify and remove its top 10 trade barriers, scale 100 BRICS startups into other member markets every year and build 1,000 new business partnerships annually.

The grouping, he said,

should convert its growing economic weight into concrete opportunities for businesses, positioning India as a country building “economic bridges” at a time when trade barriers are rising globally.

“Global trade can only progress if sea lanes are secure, supply routes remain open, and seafarers are safe. Therefore, India is a staunch supporter of freedom of navigation and the safety of seafarers,” he said.

The remarks came amid wars in two theatres and geopolitical conflicts disrupting energy and other trade markets every year and build 1,000 new business partnerships annually.

the US-Iran conflict and the country’s seafarers have been abducted by pirates.

Modi highlighted the scale of the expanded BRICS grouping, saying member-countries and partners now represent around half of the world’s population, 40 per cent of global GDP and more than a quarter of global trade. Over the past two decades, he said, the combined GDP of BRICS economies expanded around four-and-a-half times, compared with a roughly two-and-a-half-fold increase in global GDP.

Modi placed infrastructure and strategic technologies at the centre of India’s pitch to global businesses, pointing to rapid expansion of roads,

railways, ports and airports alongside new capacity in shipbuilding, semiconductors, quantum technology, critical

minerals and biotechnology. “Make in India, Innovate with India, and Scale for the World,” Modi said, presenting

India as both a manufacturing base and a source of technology and innovation for global markets.

He also sought to use India’s digital public infrastructure as a platform for deeper BRICS cooperation. Modi highlighted UPI’s population-scale deployment and said BRICS innovators “could draw on India’s experience to develop digital solutions suited to their own markets.”

The Prime Minister pointed to more than 200,000 startups and over 120 unicorns in India, saying BRICS should help take such innovations to global markets. Initiatives under India’s chairship include the BRICS incubator

network, BRICS MSME portal and BRICS Startup Innovation Fund, alongside new cooperation networks in agriculture, health care, skills and smart grids.

Trade connectivity was another central theme. Modi said India had pursued free-trade agreements with nearly 40 countries since 2014 and argued that BRICS should similarly focus on reducing barriers and expanding opportunities for businesses.

He also stressed the importance of secure sea lanes and open supply routes for global trade, reaffirming India’s support for freedom of navigation and the safety of seafarers.

Looking ahead, Modi chal-

lenged the BRICS Business Council to establish measurable targets rather than limit itself to dialogue: identify the bloc’s top 10 trade barriers for removal, support 100 BRICS startups each year in expanding into other member markets, and create 1,000 new business partnerships annually.

“We must review our progress on these three parameters every year,” he said.

The pitch came as India seeks to make its BRICS chairship centred not only on the bloc’s economic weight, but on turning that weight into trade, investment, technology and business activity across member economies.

Delhi special court orders PMLA charges against Lalu Yadav, Rabri, Tejashwi in IRCTC case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

A Delhi special court has ordered money-laundering charges against Lalu Prasad Yadav, his wife Rabri Devi and their son Tejashwi Yadav in the IRCTC hotels case. The court said there is “strong suspicion” that a railway contract was traded for a valuable plot in Patna and that the family still benefits from it.

The special judge, Vishal Gogne of the Rouse Avenue Courts, ordered that formal charges under Sections 3 and 4 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) be brought against the nine persons accused. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) discharged seven of the others named, and it will read the formal charges on October 3.

The accusations date back to when Lalu Yadav was Union Railway Minister from 2004 to 2009. It is claimed that the officials who reported to him altered the tender for two of the old Bengal Nagpur Railway hotels, one in Ranchi and the other in Puri, in such a way that the leases were awarded to Sujata Hotel Pvt. Ltd., a company owned by brothers Vinay and Vijay Kochhar. During that same period, the Kochhars transferred two to three point five acres of commercial land near Saguna More in Patna at a heavy discount to Delight



Lalu Prasad Yadav with his wife Rabri Devi and their son Tejashwi Yadav

FILE PHOTO

Marketing Company Pvt. Ltd., a company controlled by Prem Chand Gupta, a close associate of Lalu, and Gupta's wife, Sarla. Later on, the company sold its shares for very little to Rabri Devi and Tejashwi Yadav. Delight Marketing then became Lara Projects LLP. The court said the family still holds what it called “tainted land” on a valuable commercial street in Patna.

The judge said the land resulted from criminal conduct, stating that the abuse of office produced those proceeds for Rabri Devi and Tejashwi Yadav. He dismissed the defence's claim that the inquiry was a political vendetta, saying the nature, timing, and course of the investigation did not justify such a state-

ment. He noted that some deals are made openly. Citing Tagore, he cautions that power that removes all checks from its way will eventually bring destruction upon itself.

The three Yadavs involved in the trial are Prem Chand Gupta, Sarla Gupta, and the Kochhar brothers; the companies are Sujata Hotels and Lara Projects LLP. Those who were discharged include Rahul Yadav, Lalu's son-in-law; Gaurav Gupta; Nath Mal Kakrania; Vijay Tripathi; Deoki Nandan Tulshyan; Rajiv Relan; and Abhishek Finance Pvt. Ltd. The ED had previously seized properties worth ₹44.75 crore, and the Adjudicating Authority has confirmed this attachment. That amount, together with the Patna plot at the heart of the matter,

now constitutes the financial basis of the prosecution.

The money-laundering case is based on a CBI FIR dated 2017–18. In October last year, the same court charged Lalu Yadav and 11 other people with corruption, conspiracy and cheating in the earlier case. The two trials will now proceed simultaneously: one on how the hotels were handed out and the other on how the land was transferred into the family's possession.

The accused deny all the charges and regard the investigation as a political tool. The court has replied that the material available at this stage is sufficient to proceed with the trial. The following hearing will determine whether the suspicion becomes proven.

₹15,000 crore recovery doesn't end Mallya PMLA case: ED to Bombay HC

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Mumbai

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) told the Bombay High Court that recovering about ₹15,000 crore from assets linked to Vijay Mallya does not end the money-laundering case against him. The agency explained in an affidavit that while bank recoveries may affect the amount of civil claims, they do not determine whether scheduled offences or money laundering under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) have occurred.

This response followed the court's request for the ED and the State Bank of India-led consortium to clarify if the attached properties had cleared Mallya's debts. The ED said that properties worth about ₹14,131.60 crore were returned to the consortium by order of a special PMLA court in Mumbai. The agency explained that this process is a legal requirement under Section 8(8) of the PMLA to return property to those with a legitimate claim. It does not confirm or deny whether a scheduled offence or money laundering took place.

The affidavit stated, “The subsequent restoration or recovery of assets, therefore, cannot be construed as extinguishing or rendering infructuous the pending proceedings under PMLA.” The agency explained that criminal prosecution after a PMLA investigation does not end just because banks later recover



Vijay Mallya

large sums from returned assets. The ED rejected the idea that the commercial dispute is finished and that the criminal case should end as well. It said that PMLA proceedings are separate from recovery suits and tribunal decisions.

The recovered amount may help show what banks are still owed, but it does not address whether the loan funds were obtained, used, or diverted in a way that breaks the law. Mallya, who left India in March 2016 after Kingfisher Airlines collapsed under heavy debt, has argued that lenders have already been fully repaid. His lawyer told the High Court last month that a consortium recovered about ₹15,000 crore, compared to the original Debt Recovery Tribunal claim of about ₹crore, including interest. He asked to close a 2020 petition that challenged a December 2019 special-court order allowing

banks to use confiscated assets for recovery.

Justice Milind N Jadhav noted that the long-running commercial dispute should end so the parties can “move on.” However, he made it clear that closing the civil case would not affect the criminal case, which still needs to be resolved. The court asked the ED and SBI for responses before deciding next steps.

The ED's latest filing maintains this distinction. It also noted that Mallya remains absent from India. The agency said his failure to appear for trial is part of the case's background. Mallya was declared a fugitive economic offender in 2019, and extradition efforts from the United Kingdom have not brought him back. The ED continues to argue that, as chairman of Kingfisher Airlines, Mallya played a key role in the company's decisions and in getting loans from several banks.

The ED said its investigation found serious problems in how the loans were approved and used, including funds being diverted from their intended purpose. The money-laundering case is based on these alleged offences, not on whether banks later recovered money from attached properties.

The dispute has two separate parts that public discussions often mix up. The civil part deals with how much the airline and its guarantors owed, the interest, and what was recovered from assets like shares and real estate. The criminal part is about whether the loans and how the money was moved amount to fraud and money laundering.

The ED believes that the civil side of the case can be settled, adjusted, or even over-recovered without affecting the criminal side. For public-sector banks, recovering assets has been rare in a major default. For the ED, returning money does not clear someone of criminal charges.

The High Court must now decide what remains of Mallya's 2020 petition after the banks and the ED have shared their figures and legal arguments. The ED says the criminal case will continue, whether or not the civil accounts are considered settled. Recovering ₹15,000 crore answers the debt issue, but it does not resolve the money-laundering charge.

Congress leader arrested for burning Dharendra Shastri's poster in West Bengal



Congress activists stage a protest outside Bhowanipore Police Station against Bageshwar Dham chief Dharendra Krishna Shastri for his alleged remarks against the sentiment of Bengal for the upcoming Durga Puja festival in Kolkata, West Bengal on Tuesday

PTI

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

A day after Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari directed the Kolkata Police Commissioner to arrest people who had burnt the posters of Godman Dharendra Shastri, the police picked up Atanu Das, a Congress leader who is also the general secretary of the tricolour party of Kolkata district. Das was arrested at night between Thursday and Friday, police sources said.

He was booked for inciting hatred between different religious groups and hurting religious sentiments.

There was statewide crit-

icism after Shastri also called Bageshwar Baba, who had criticised those people who consumed non-vegetarian food during the Durga Pujas, saying, “One thing I do not like about West Bengal Here people eat non-veg during Durga Pujas... those who eat non-vegetarian food during the Durga Pujas are Pakhandis (hypocrites) and should be boycotted.”

The Congress promptly took up the issue and staged protests throughout the State and even lodged police complaints for allegedly hurting the sentiments of the people. Shastri's posters were also burnt in South Kolkata.

The Chief Minister, in his

part, condemned the burning of his poster and directed the Kolkata Police Commissioner during a speech from the Assembly House to arrest the alleged mischief-mongers. “I direct the CP to arrest those who did this,” he said.

Meanwhile, the Congress came down heavily on the Government for perpetrating “Tughlaqi raj in Bengal.” State Congress president Subhankar Sarkar said, “Instead of taking action against the Baba who hurt Bengali sentiments and culture, he is arresting the protesters... The people are watching and will definitely respond.”

Punjab Police foil targeted killing plot backed by foreign handler

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Two alleged operatives of a foreign-based handler, who had recently returned from Dubai to Punjab to execute a targeted killing, have been arrested by the Punjab Police's Counter Intelligence Wing in Pathankot, officials said on Friday.

Two sophisticated .30 bore pistols and 10 live cartridges from their possession, they said.

The arrested accused have been identified as Ravinder Singh alias Dhillon, a resident of Dhillwan in Batala, and



Jashanpreet Singh, a resident of village Bal in Gurdaspur, they said.

Police also impounded the motorcycle on which the duo were travelling. The vehicle did not have a registration number, officials said.

Director General of Police

Gaurav Yadav said preliminary investigation has revealed that the accused were working at the behest of a foreign-based handler and had recently arrived from Dubai to execute the assigned task.

Further investigation is

Suwendu may attend BRICS dinner, meet Ambani

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari is likely to travel to Delhi on Saturday to join a dinner hosted on the occasion of the Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa Summit (BRICS) at the Rashtrapati Bhavan.

The Chief Minister, who disclosed the programme, said that he had received the invitation to attend the BRICS dinner at the President's House and was most likely joining it.

At the dinner, the Bengal Chief Minister was likely to share the table not only with



foreign dignitaries like Russian President Vladimir Putin and his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping, apart from Prime Minister Narendra Modi, but he was also likely to meet the Chief Ministers of other States. The 18th BRICS summit is being held in New Delhi on Saturday and Sunday.

Apart from this, the Chief Minister is also likely to meet industrialist Mukesh Ambani in Mumbai. The Ambanis have a considerable stake in Bengal, and the Chief Minister's Mumbai visit would revolve around bringing more investment sources, quoting the

Nabanna (State secretariat) said. The meeting is scheduled to take place sometime next week. During his meeting with Ambani, the Chief Minister is likely to seek his group's bigger participation in Bengal. The Chief Minister said that he had also been invited by Anant Ambani, the son of Reliance Chairman, requesting him to join the Ganesh Puja celebrations.

Nabanna sources also said that the Chief Minister is also likely to attend the groundbreaking ceremony of a 2,000-bed hospital constructed by the Adani Group at New Town in Kolkata. The event was

likely to take place on September 24. While one part of the proposed hospital would work for the benefit of the weaker section of the society, the other part will operate on a commercial basis.

Ever since he came to power, the Chief Minister had been running from pillar to post, inviting investment in Bengal because “Bengal has everything that is required for a flourishing industrial climate... More investments would rejuvenate the economy of Bengal”, which has been in the scheme of things of the Centre's “look east” policy.

I was targeted: Sheikh Hasina's daughter breaks silence on WHO row

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi:

Nearly a year after being sidelined, former WHO South-East Asia Regional Director Saima Wazed, daughter of former Bangladesh prime minister Sheikh Hasina, has broken her silence. She says the World Health Organisation closed its investigation into allegations concerning her travel to China in August 2026 and found them “unsubstantiated”. She was informed of the finding in early August, she says, and the reports were sent to WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus. She has received no further communication since.

Wazed had taken charge in February 2024 for a five-year term, becoming the first person from Bangladesh and the second woman to hold the post. She was later placed on leave amid allegations of fraud, questions over academic credentials, and land dealings. In December 2025, her leave was converted from paid to unpaid — a decision she calls

retaliatory and linked to her formal complaint over the leak of confidential documents from the Director-General's office.

Her appointment had drawn scrutiny because of her family background. Hasina was in office when Wazed was nominated. Wazed rejects the suggestion that her family ties should have any bearing on her professional appointment, saying WHO's vetting procedures were followed.

The controversy unfolded after Hasina's removal from power in 2024. Wazed says the investigation was initiated at the request of Bangladesh's interim government. WHO has not publicly confirmed her account that all investigations were closed with no findings against her.

Excerpts from the interview:
The Pioneer: What specific evidence does the WHO have concerning the allegations related to fraud, academic credentials, and land dealings involving you? What is your



Former WHO South-East Asia Regional Director Saima Wazed

response to these allegations?

Saima Wazed: WHO launched an investigation at the behest of the interim regime in Bangladesh in September 2025. I was placed on leave with pay from September, which was to continue until January. In December, the leave was converted to leave without pay. This was done without any substantial allegation or evidence that necessitated such a change, without just cause, and in violation of existing WHO rules and procedures.

The decision to place me on leave without pay was retaliatory in nature. Ten days before the change in my leave status, I had submitted an official request seeking an investigation into the leak of a confidential letter and other information from the Office of the Director-General. This occurred while the investigation was ongoing and while I was fully participating in it during my leave with pay, which I had been informed would continue until January 2026.

The Pioneer Exclusive

The Pioneer: Why were you placed on unpaid leave for nearly a year? Was the WHO considering formal disciplinary action or your removal from the position before you submitted your resignation?

Saima Wazed: All investigations were closed in August 2026. Allegations of fraud regarding travel to China were found to be unsubstantiated, and I was duly informed of this in early August 2026. The reports were sent to Dr Tedros for his final decision on the matter. No further information has been forthcoming from WHO since.

The Pioneer: Does your resignation raise broader concerns within the WHO about the vetting, appointment, and accountability mechanisms for senior officials, particularly in cases involving individuals with

close political or family ties to senior political figures, including former Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina?

Saima Wazed: WHO has a sufficient vetting process for the nomination and accountability of candidates put forward by member states. All such procedures were followed in my case. Familial relationships are not a fair or valid category for questioning a nomination. Most nominees for such positions are political in nature; many candidates are former politicians or are politically affiliated with the regime in power at the time of nomination.

To deny a candidate the right to be selected on the grounds of family background could be interpreted as a violation of an individual's professional human rights and freedom to choose their professional path. It would be equivalent to saying that the son or daughter of a farmer cannot one day become a surgeon or head a department at a medical institute.

Editor's
TAKE

Children need a firewall on social media

With minors entering social media unchecked, the time has come to make age verification, parental consent and safety safeguards part of the platform's architecture

The Supreme Court's notice to the Centre this week, on a petition seeking safeguards for minors on social media, could not have come sooner. Hearing the plea by NGO Just Rights for Children Alliance, Justice Joymalya Bagchi remarked from the bench that shielding children online will need something like firewalls - a fitting image for a long-standing design failure.

The petition's legal argument is simple: under Section 11 of the Indian Contract Act, a minor cannot enter into a binding contract, yet millions of children under 18 click "I agree" to a platform's terms daily, with no age check and no parental consent. The petitioners want protection built into the architecture, not bolted on after harm is done. That is not a technicality; it is a design failure with grave human cost. NCRB data records over 1.87 lakh crimes against children in India in 2024. Cybercrime cases are a smaller, fast-rising slice - but nearly nine in ten involve the circulation of child sexual abuse material. Globally, the WeProtect Global Alliance finds that groomers need under an hour, sometimes seconds, to win a child's trust, and America's missing-children clearinghouse logged over 50,000 sextortion reports in 2025, up from 36,000 the year before. The petition's own example - girls lured through a fabricated K-pop connection and later rescued - is not an outlier; it is a template already running at scale.

Other democracies are responding, unevenly but instructively. Australia has banned under-16 accounts outright, with fines nearing AU\$50 million, though its regulator concedes that many teenagers still find their way onto these platforms. Britain's Online Safety Act takes a calibrated route: platforms must prove their age checks are "highly effective" or risk fines of 10 per cent of global revenue. The European Union has gone furthest on design: a privacy-preserving age-verification app lets users prove they are over or under a threshold without revealing their identity, while EU guidance pushes platforms to make child profiles private by default and switch off compulsive features, such as daily "streaks", designed to keep young users hooked.

India already has more law than it enforces. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act sets the age of consent at 18 - stricter than Europe's 13-to-16 band or America's 13 - and bars tracking, profiling and targeted advertising aimed at children. What is missing is enforcement: a functioning Data Protection Board, and Intermediary Guidelines under the IT Rules, 2021, that still allow the sign-up-first, verify-never model this petition challenges - the very rules petitioners want the Court to force the Centre to amend. The way forward does not require choosing between an outright ban and doing nothing. It requires the Centre to notify rules with real teeth, compel platforms to deploy the same age-assurance signals they use to sell targeted advertising, and make parental consent verifiable rather than cosmetic. The Supreme Court has given the Government a deadline to close the gap between the law on paper and the law in practice. It should not have taken a courtroom notice to get there.

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

Everything Belongs, Nothing Is Owned

We spend most of our lives accumulating, more wealth, more possessions, more recognition, quietly believing that what we gather becomes truly ours. The very first verse of the Isha Upanishad challenges that belief before the text has even begun.

The verse declares, "*Ishavasyam Idam Sarvam, Yat Kincha Jagatyam Jagat*", all this, whatever exists in this changing universe, is pervaded by the Divine. Nothing, not a tree, not a home, not even the body we call our own, exists apart from that presence. The verse continues, "*Tena Tyaktena Bhunjitha, Ma Gridhah Kasya Swid Dhanam*", therefore, enjoy through renunciation; do not covet what belongs to another.

This is a remarkable instruction. It does not ask us to abandon the world or refuse its pleasures. It asks us to enjoy life while holding the quiet awareness that nothing we touch is truly separate from the divine, and therefore, nothing is ever fully "*ours*" to grasp or hoard. Enjoyment becomes possible precisely because we release the anxious need to possess.

Most of our suffering comes not from what we have, but from how tightly we grip it, our belongings, our identities, our outcomes, as though letting go would mean losing ourselves.

Today, choose one thing you hold onto tightly, and consciously enjoy it a little more loosely, remembering it was never entirely yours to keep.

—DAIV

PIC TALK

People participate in the traditional Marbat procession during the annual festival held to observe 'Pola' festival, in Nagpur

PHOTO: PTI

Satya Niketan: Accountability, not scapegoating

The Satya Niketan building collapse demands accountability, but accountability cannot begin and end with identifying the officer occupying the chair when tragedy struck

When a building collapses and lives are lost, the first instinct is to find someone to blame. The more difficult — and far more important - task is to determine who was actually responsible.

The tragedy at a PG accommodation in Satya Niketan has rightly triggered public anger and demands for accountability. There can be no argument with the need for answers when human lives are lost. But accountability must follow facts, law and evidence. It cannot become a predetermined search for an individual to carry the burden of a failure that may have developed over years and involved several institutions. This is particularly relevant to the intense media scrutiny of the incumbent Commissioner. The question is not whether a Commissioner should be accountable. Of course, he should. The real question is: accountable for what?

A Commissioner can reasonably be held responsible for decisions taken under his authority, failures to act where a clear statutory duty existed, matters specifically brought to his notice, and enforcement powers that were lawfully available to him. If evidence establishes that a dangerous condition was known to the competent authority, that there was a legal power to intervene, and that an avoidable failure occurred during his tenure, scrutiny is not only justified but necessary.

But accountability has boundaries.

An incumbent Commissioner cannot automatically be held personally responsible for every unauthorised construction that pre-dates his tenure, every historical enforcement failure, every matter falling within another statutory authority, or every violation of which the administration had no knowledge. The fact that a problem continues into a particular tenure does not, by itself, establish personal negligence. Nor does the mere occurrence of a tragedy prove that the officer occupying the chair caused it.

This distinction is particularly important in Delhi. Planning, building control, land use, fire safety, licensing, policing and enforcement can involve different institutions and different statutory powers. Responsibilities can overlap, intersect or be divided between agencies. The Commissioner may be the most visible administrative authority, but visibility should never be mistaken for exclusive jurisdiction.

There is a deeper problem in the way administrative failures are often discussed. Every new Commissioner inherits properties, complaints, files, litigation, enforcement backlogs and practices accumulated over years. Some problems may have existed for decades. Some properties may have been inspected previously; others may never have come to official notice. Some matters may have been dealt with - or ought to have been dealt with - by another authority.

THE ULTIMATE TEST OF ACCOUNTABILITY IS NOT HOW QUICKLY THE SYSTEM FINDS SOMEONE TO BLAME AFTER A TRAGEDY. IT IS WHETHER IT HAS THE COURAGE TO TRACE RESPONSIBILITY TO ITS SOURCE, CONFRONT INSTITUTIONAL FAILURE WHEREVER IT EXISTS, AND IDENTIFY THE NEXT DANGEROUS BUILDING BEFORE IT COLLAPSES

The writer is a retired IAS officer

To attribute the entire accumulated burden to the person currently occupying the chair is to confuse continuity of office with personal culpability. The proper investigation must therefore proceed backwards through the entire chain of responsibility. When was the property constructed or altered? What was its sanctioned use? When did any violation arise? Were permissions obtained? Were complaints received? Were inspections conducted? What did officials find? Which authority had jurisdiction at each stage? When did the competent authority acquire knowledge of a potential danger? What statutory powers were available? What action was required, and what action was actually taken?

These are the questions that establish responsibility. The easier question — “Who was Commissioner when the building collapsed?” — does not. The media has every right to ask uncomfortable questions, and the public has every right to demand answers. But complicated administrative matters should not be reduced to a search for a convenient individual to absorb public anger. Commentary becomes counterproductive when definitive judgments are pronounced without examining the documentary record, the institutional chain and the division of statutory responsibilities. There is an additional danger in turning accountability into a media trial. Public officials may become more concerned with headlines than with confronting difficult legacy problems. Defensive administration replaces decisive administration. The incentive becomes not to identify and correct danger, but to avoid being associated with it.

That is not accountability. It is scapegoating disguised as accountability.

The Satya Niketan tragedy should instead become the catalyst for systemic action. Vulnerable PGs, hostels and residential

premises converted to intensive commercial or quasi-commercial use should be identified and subjected to appropriate safety and regulatory scrutiny. Where a structure or use can lawfully and safely be regularised, it should be. Where it cannot, it should be sealed and, where necessary, demolished. Most importantly, a sealed or condemned property must not simply reappear under another operator, another name or another purported use without a fresh legal and safety assessment. Otherwise, enforcement becomes temporary theatre rather than prevention.

None of this is an argument for shielding any Commissioner or public official. If evidence establishes negligence, dereliction of duty or failure to exercise lawful powers, responsibility must follow. If responsibility is distributed across several agencies, successive administrations, property owners or other actors, it must be apportioned accordingly.

The governing principle should be simple: the person in the chair is not necessarily the person responsible for everything that has accumulated before him. The victims and their families deserve more than a media trial and a convenient name to blame. They deserve an evidence-based reconstruction of what happened, who had the duty and power to act, what warnings existed, why action was or was not taken, and what must change. There should be no immunity for negligence - but neither should there be guilt by incumbency.

The ultimate test of accountability is not how quickly the system finds someone to blame after a tragedy. It is whether it has the courage to trace responsibility to its source, confront institutional failure wherever it exists, and identify the next dangerous building before it collapses.

That is the accountability Delhi and the victims of Satya Niketan — deserve.

The wisdom of knowing what we can carry

SIDDHARTH ROY

2ND OPINION

A civil engineer learns early that every structure has a limit. A bridge carries its own weight, the traffic moving across it and the forces of wind. Design is therefore not about making a structure capable of carrying everything. It is about understanding loads, calculating capacity and providing an appropriate margin of safety. Human beings could learn something from that principle.

Modern life has become an exercise in accumulating loads. We carry professional ambitions, financial obligations, family expectations, social comparisons and an endless stream of information. We are encouraged to add another responsibility, another achievement and another commitment, as though human capacity were infinitely expandable. But structures do

not work that way. Neither do people.

In engineering, a load is not necessarily dangerous. A properly designed structure is expected to carry loads daily. Problems arise when the load becomes excessive, when it is badly distributed or when deterioration has silently reduced the structure's capacity. Human exhaustion can follow a similar pattern.

The person who appears to be coping may already have cracks invisible to others. A demanding job may not be overwhelming alone. Family responsibilities may not be overwhelming alone. Financial uncertainty may not be overwhelming alone. But their cumulative effect can exceed the margin of safety.

Engineers therefore think in terms of redundancy and safety factors. They do not design bridges to collapse at the first unforeseen truck. They provide capacity beyond the anticipated load because uncertainty is inevitable. There is wisdom here. Rest is not laziness; it is maintenance. Friendship is not merely companionship; it can provide structural support. Time away from work is a reserve that allows a person to absorb unforeseen shocks before those shocks become permanent structural damage.

Engineering also teaches another uncomfortable truth: damage ignored does not disappear. Small cracks can become larger defects. Corrosion can weaken reinforcement long before a dramatic failure becomes visible. Preventive inspection is valuable precisely

because intervention is easier before collapse. People, too, require inspection. We need moments to ask whether our ambitions remain sustainable, whether our commitments are distributed sensibly and whether the structures supporting our lives are still sound.

There is also a lesson in failure. When a structure collapses, engineers do not simply blame the final load. They investigate design assumptions, materials, workmanship, maintenance and environmental conditions. Human breakdown deserves a similarly nuanced understanding.

A person should not be judged merely by the moment at which their capacity was exceeded.

Perhaps strength, then, is misunderstood. Strength does not mean carrying everything placed upon us. A well-engineered structure is strong because its limits are understood. The same may be true of a well-lived life. We should know what we can carry, what we must refuse, what requires reinforcement and when maintenance is overdue. After all, the objective of engineering is not to prevent structures from ever experiencing stress. It is to ensure that they remain standing when stress arrives. Perhaps that is a philosophy worth carrying.

The writer is a civil engineer, consultant to Rashtriya Raksha University under the Ministry of Home Affairs, short-story writer and columnist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A festival rooted in faith and legend

Ganesh Chaturthi is one of the most loved festivals of the Hindu community and is celebrated across the country with great fervour and devotion. The 10-day festival honours Lord Ganesha, the elephant-headed son of Lord Shiva and Goddess Parvati. People bring idols of Ganesha into their homes and perform puja for 10 days.

Although it is not known when or how Ganesh Chaturthi was first observed, the festival has been publicly celebrated in Pune since the era of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. It was later revived by Lokmanya Tilak and is now celebrated across India on a large scale.

According to Hindu belief, Ganesha is the remover of obstacles. People worship him before beginning any new work.

According to mythology, Ganesha was created by Goddess Parvati. When he prevented Lord Shiva from entering the house, Shiva cut off his head. He was later brought back to life with an elephant's head and became known as Gajanan.

During Ganeshotsav, devotees visit pandals and enjoy modaks, considered Ganesha's favourite sweet. The festival concludes with visarjan amid chants of “Ganpati Bappa Morya, Pudhchya Varshi Lavkar Ya”.

JUBEL D'CRUZ | MUMBAI

A drug-free India is a national responsibility

The Commissioner of Police, Bengaluru, and his team deserve appreciation for busting a major narcotics network by seizing drugs worth approximately ₹12 crore. Seven persons, including foreigners, were arrested. Such networks procure contraband at lower prices and sell it at huge profits, often targeting vulnerable people, particularly students and young professionals. The growing menace of drugs should concern every section of society. Drug addiction is one of the most serious social evils confronting our country. It can destroy individuals and families and damage the future of our younger generation.

The fight against drugs is not merely a law-and-order issue but a battle for their health, character and future. The Government must adopt a comprehensive strategy covering trafficking, financing, distribution, consumption, treatment and rehabilitation.

The Narcotics Control Bureau should be strengthened through better intelligence sharing and coordination among central and state agencies. Equal emphasis must be placed on prevention, awareness and counselling in educational institutions. Rehabilitation centres should also be strengthened. The goal of a “Nasha Mukta Bharat” must become a people's movement. A drug-free India is a national responsibility.

RAMESH G JETHWANI | BENGALURU

A consistent world order is vital

This refers to the editorial “Remembering 9/11: 25 years, enduring lessons” (September 11). The editorial makes a point that deserves wider attention: twenty-five years on, the world is safer in some ways and more fragile in others. Airport security, intelligence sharing and financial tracking of terror networks have improved. Yet Afghanistan's return to Taliban rule and the rise of groups like ISIS show how quickly hard-won gains can unravel when political will fades.

India has faced cross-border terrorism for decades. Force can disrupt networks and eliminate leaders, but it cannot address underlying grievances such as poverty, exclusion and weak governance. What is needed is consistent application of international law, stronger multilateral institutions and investment in development and de-radicalisation programmes. Selective enforcement of global norms only deepens the resentment that fuels extremism.

India's experience, from the 26/11 Mumbai attacks to the strengthening of agencies such as the NIA, shows that a security architecture built on patience and institutional reform outlasts one based purely on retaliation. A fairer, more consistent world order remains our best long-term defence against terrorism.

AS NITHISH KUMAR | CHENNAI

HCF or LCM: The limits of global groupings

India stands at the intersection of these groupings — a founding member of BRICS, a key player in the G20, and a participant in the dormant RIC. Each platform offers opportunities, but each also imposes constraints. India's success in delivering the 2023 G20 Declaration shows that skilled diplomacy can still produce results



MANOJ NARAVANE

collides with reality.

The Russia-India-China (RIC) concept was first proposed in 1998 by Russian statesman Yevgeny Primakov. It was meant to be a Eurasian triangle capable of balancing Western influence. Russia and India were long-standing partners; Russia and China were drawing closer. Yet for India, a friend's friend was not necessarily a friend. The India-China relationship, marked by border tensions, strategic mistrust, and competing regional visions, ensured that RIC never evolved beyond occasional meetings. It lacked institutional depth, produced no joint agenda, and never became a meaningful pillar of India's foreign policy. It remained a diplomatic idea rather than a functioning platform.

BRICS, by contrast, began as an economic concept. In 2001, Goldman Sachs economist Jim O'Neill coined BRIC to describe four emerging economies, namely Brazil, Russia, India, and China, all amongst the top ten in terms of GDP, that were poised to reshape global growth. South Africa joined in 2010, turning BRIC into BRICS, sandwiching the RIC in betwixt, and giving the grouping global reach. For several years, BRICS served as a forum for coordination, issuing communiqués but achieving little beyond symbolism. That changed with the creation of the New Development Bank in 2014 and the Contingent Reserve Arrangement in 2015, signalling a desire to build alternative financial institutions, both of which were anathema to the USA.

The real transformation came with expansion. At the Johannesburg Summit in 2023, BRICS invited six new members. By 2026, the grouping had grown to eleven full members: Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Indonesia. In addition, BRICS created a Partner Country category, now comprising ten states — Belarus, Bolivia, Cuba, Kazakhstan, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Uganda, Uzbekistan, and Vietnam — bringing total participation to twenty-one countries.

This expanded BRICS resembles less the clean, original acronym and more a kind of geopolitical bric-a-brac: a shelf crowded with countries of vastly different political systems, regional rivalries, economic capacities, and strategic compulsions. The collection is impressive in size but eclectic in character, united more by the desire for a platform than by a shared vision of what that platform should achieve.

Expansion has magnified internal contradictions. Iran and Saudi Arabia, regional rivals, now sit at the same table. China's economic dominance raises concerns about bloc imbalance. India, wary of BRICS becoming an overtly anti-Western platform, has adopted a cautious approach to further enlargement. The result is a grouping with enormous potential but limited cohesion — a forum where consensus is increasingly difficult to achieve.

The G20, meanwhile, has a different origin and purpose. Formed in September 1999 in the aftermath of the Asian financial crisis, it brought together major advanced and emerging economies to stabilise global finance. After its elevation to leaders' level in 2008, it became the premier forum for international economic cooperation. Today, the G20 comprises nineteen countries plus the European Union and the African Union. It accounts for the overwhelming majority of global GDP, trade, and emissions, and more than half the world's population.

Its membership overlaps heavily with BRICS. Only a handful of countries — Mexico, Australia, Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, South Korea, Turkey, the United Kingdom, and the United States — are in the G20 but not in BRICS. Conversely, BRICS includes states such as Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Indonesia that are not part of the G20. This

International groupings often begin with grand ideas and geopolitical optimism, but their trajectories depend far more on political alignment and the willingness of member states to act. India's experience with three major platforms — RIC, BRICS, and the G20 — shows how ambition frequently



THE RUSSIA-INDIA-CHINA (RIC) CONCEPT WAS FIRST PROPOSED IN 1998 BY RUSSIAN STATESMAN YEVGENY PRIMAKOV. IT WAS MEANT TO BE A EURASIAN TRIANGLE CAPABLE OF BALANCING WESTERN INFLUENCE. RUSSIA AND INDIA WERE LONG-STANDING PARTNERS; RUSSIA AND CHINA WERE DRAWING CLOSER. YET FOR INDIA, A FRIEND'S FRIEND WAS NOT NECESSARILY A FRIEND

General Manoj Naravane (Retd) is former Chief of the Army Staff

overlap raises a natural question: how different are the G20 and the expanded BRICS?

The answer lies in purpose and politics. The G20 is a crisis-management forum with broad global legitimacy, whereas BRICS is a political and economic coordination platform for the Global South, increasingly shaped by China's and India's competing visions. The G20 seeks stability; BRICS seeks structural reform. The G20 is diverse but institutionalised, whereas BRICS is cohesive in rhetoric but fragmented in interests.

What, then, are these groupings actually achieving? Their original objective, to drive global economic growth and reform governance structures, has been overshadowed by political agendas, divergent national interests, and geopolitical rivalries. Both BRICS and the G20 operate by consensus, which means the lowest common denominator often prevails. Amitabh Kant, India's G20 Sherpa, recounts in his book *Scaling Mt G-20* how drafting a simple joint statement required endless negotiation over every word and comma. The New Delhi Declaration of 2023 was hailed as a diplomatic triumph precisely because consensus had become so difficult. The BRICS Summit, currently underway, faces similar challenges; its foreign ministers have struggled to produce joint statements on issues where member states are sharply divided.

The current geopolitical environment makes meaningful outcomes even harder. The world is grappling with the ongoing war in Ukraine, the escalating conflict involving Iran, and the never-ending cycle of violence in West Asia. These crises divide member states within both BRICS and the G20. Russia's war in Ukraine splits the G20. Iran's regional role complicates BRICS. China's strategic ambitions unsettle both. Expecting grand outcomes from multilateral forums in such a fractured world is unrealistic.

Instead of a Highest Common Formulation (HCF, to use a mathematical term), namely a visionary, guiding framework for global cooperation, what is more likely is what might be called a Lowest Common Memorandum (LCM), an anodyne statement that offends none, satisfies all, and achieves little, notwithstanding the galaxy of Presidents and Prime Ministers who have descended on New Delhi. This is not a failure of diplomacy but a reflection of geopolitical reality. When major powers are in conflict, multilateralism becomes risk-averse. When consensus is mandatory, ambition becomes optional.

India stands at the intersection of these groupings — a founding member of BRICS, a key player in the G20, and a participant in the dormant RIC. Each platform offers opportunities, but each also imposes constraints. India's success in delivering the 2023 G20 Declaration shows that skilled diplomacy can still produce results. Its cautious approach to BRICS expansion reflects strategic maturity, while its disengagement from RIC indicates realism. But the larger truth remains that global groupings are only as effective as the political will of their members. In a world marked by conflict, rivalry, and fragmentation, India must continue to push for meaningful cooperation — even if the mathematics of multilateralism increasingly favours the lowest common denominator over the highest common ideal.

The degree that promised everything



ACHARYA PRASHANT

The system has not failed. The system has been magnificent. It has delivered superbly for well over a century. What was it designed to do, and hence what has it delivered? It was designed to take in human beings and convert them into functional economic units. A five-year-old goes in, seventeen years pass, and a functional economic unit comes out. Ninety-four per cent placed. We fall and grovel at placement figures, don't we? And what is this thing called placement? Absorption of the individual into the social and economic order, is that not what placement is? Admissions office at one end, placement office at the other, and in between, an assembly line. But what happens if the order stops wanting the unit?

The engineer was made for a certain kind of factory. What nobody wrote into the design was the relationship between the engineer and the factory, because nobody expected the factory to go anywhere. The factory moved on. And when it moved, the engineer stood exactly where he was, holding a qualification cut for a floor that no longer exists. The campus did not merely train him. It trained him to take the training as his identity. He did not come away with a skill. He came away with a self. Four years of a department, a roll number, a grade average, a placement bracket, and at the end of it, a young man who no longer says he studied engineering. He says he is an engineer.

Vedanta has a name for what just happened, and the name is ahankaar, the ego. The ego is the false centre, the sense of being somebody in particular, and its one permanent difficulty is that it owns nothing of its own. It must borrow. Hand it four years and a certificate and it will borrow that too, and hold on far longer than the certificate is worth. Identities are frozen things. A skill you can put down and pick up another. An identity you cannot, because once it is in place, there is nobody left over to do the putting down. So when the ground shifts, the identity does not adapt. When change happens, identities panic.

From outside, the panic looks like laziness. He will not take the job at the dealership in the next town. Meanwhile, he takes money from a father who has done such work for thirty years and never once called it beneath him. He is not defending his income. He is defending a picture, and the picture will be defended even at the cost of the man carrying it. Now the machine arrives. AI is a code. It is a programmable output. It can do only the work it has been made and deployed to do, and beyond that it can do nothing. AI can remove human beings only from that work which was mechanical anyway, which was programmable anyway. AI can never actually become a substitute for a human being, because a human being is not a machine. Unless, of course, the human being has made himself into one.

AI is not a disruption; it is rather a revelation. Is it not revealing, if what I have been taught over four years can be taken over by a machine, by a system that has zero self-knowledge? A study by Cognizant and Pearson this June found thirty-seven per cent of entry-level tasks in India already being performed by AI. So the complaint is misdated. The mistake is not that AI is now snatching that work away from us. The mistake was that we accepted that work in the first place. We should never have been doing it, because we are human beings. Let the machine do the machine's work. Why should a human being do the machine's work?

Every answer on offer is additive: reskill, upskill. But adaptability cannot be taught. Adaptability is what naturally remains when the ego identity is removed. You cannot teach adaptability. You can unteach rigidity. Which brings the matter back to the certificate. Under the seal and the signature, one line is printed in ink you cannot see, and the line says: you are complete, you may stop now, go and be absorbed. An older version of this refusal opens the Gita. A man stands in the field he has trained his whole life for, looks at the work in front of him, and puts his weapons down. He does not say he is frightened. He says the work is ignoble. Krishna does not accept the argument, and names it a weakness of heart wearing the costume of principle. So when a graduate says a job is beneath him, hand the question back. Beneath what? Beneath whom? No height exists there except the one printed on a sheet of paper, and that paper was issued by an office that has never met him.

Seventeen years went into the graduate. He was educated to become something. He was not educated to unbecome what he had erroneously become. And I am not going to finish by describing the work that would befit him instead. The moment such work is described, it becomes one more thing to acquire, one more label to wear. Another question has been standing there the whole time, unasked in every classroom he passed through. Nobody asked it of him, but it is one every youth should ask themselves: What is standing there when the degree is set down?



Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life



ANIL KANTONY

On October 7, 2001, Narendra Modi took oath as Chief Minister of Gujarat at a moment when the state was still carrying the scars of a devastating earthquake, successive droughts and political uncertainty. He entered government not through the conventional apprenticeship of power, but from a life spent in organisation and public work. His mother, as he has often recalled, gave him two simple instructions: always work for the poor and never take a bribe. Twenty-five years later, that moment offers a useful starting point to understand a political journey that has altered the scale and vocabulary of governance in India. Among its most consequential dimensions has been the steady placing of young Indians at the centre of the national project.

India has always been a young country in numbers. What changed during the Modi years was the attempt to convert demography into agency. In Gujarat, the early emphasis on electricity, roads, industrial investment, education and administrative delivery created an environment in which a generation could begin to imagine opportunity beyond traditional boundaries. The lesson that emerged was straightforward: government cannot manufacture ambition, but it can create the conditions in which ambition becomes

productive. When Modi moved to Delhi in 2014, that principle was expanded to the national scale. The vocabulary of that period matters. Skill India, Startup India, Digital India, Make in India, Stand Up India and the Mudra programme were not isolated schemes. Together, they reflected a shift in the relationship between the state and the young citizen. The young Indian was no longer viewed merely as a job seeker waiting at the end of a government pipeline. He or she was increasingly imagined as a creator, entrepreneur, innovator and employer. More than 2.23 lakh startups had been recognised by March 2026, generating over 23 lakh direct jobs. Under the Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana, more than 1.64 crore candidates have been trained or oriented. Mudra has taken formal credit to millions who would once have remained outside the banking system. These figures are important, but the deeper change is cultural. Risk-taking has become less exceptional. Enterprise has travelled from a few metropolitan enclaves into Tier-2 cities, small towns and districts that once stood outside the national innovation map.

There is an anecdotal truth behind these numbers. A young person in a smaller town today can build a product on cloud infrastructure, receive payments through UPI, market through digital platforms, register an enterprise online and aspire to sell to customers far beyond the geography of birth. This is a profound democratisation of possibility. Digital public infrastructure has reduced the distance between aspiration and execution. It has also changed the psychology of a generation. The young no longer need to migrate to



a handful of cities merely to enter the modern economy. Increasingly, the modern economy can reach them. The same transformation is visible much earlier in the life cycle. More than 10,000 Atal Tinkering Labs now engage over 1.1 crore students across hundreds of districts. Children who might once have encountered science only through textbooks are experimenting with robotics, electronics, artificial intelligence and design. The point is not that every child will become an engineer or founder. The point is that curiosity itself is being treated as a national asset. A country that wants to lead in semiconductors, space, artificial intelligence, advanced manufacturing and green technologies cannot wait until university to cultivate scientific confidence.

This is where the Modi years have also been marked by a widening of the horizon. Chandrayaan, the expansion of the space ecosystem, the semiconductor mission, the growth of defence manufacturing, the spread of digital payments and the push into artificial intelligence have given young Indians visible national missions

in which to locate their own ambitions. Development is most powerful when it is not experienced as an abstraction. A school student watching India land near the lunar south pole, an engineering graduate working on chip design, a founder building for the next billion users, or a young technician entering an advanced manufacturing plant is participating in a story larger than individual advancement. National capability and personal aspiration begin to reinforce each other.

There has also been a conscious effort to connect youth with citizenship. Mera Yuva Bharat, launched in 2023, has grown into a platform with more than 2.46 crore registered young people, linking them with volunteering, experiential learning, internships, skill development and community initiatives. This is significant because the idea of youth empowerment cannot be reduced to employment alone. A confident republic needs citizens who see nation-building as participation rather than spectatorship. Modi has repeatedly spoken of Yuva Shakti not as a constituency to be courted, but as a force to be trusted.

That trust is central to the idea of Viksit Bharat 2047. The generation entering adulthood today will be in its forties when India completes one hundred years of Independence. It will carry the principal responsibility for whether India becomes merely a larger economy or a genuinely developed nation with technological depth, social mobility, institutional confidence and global influence. The next phase must therefore go beyond access. India has to relentlessly improve the quality of education, deepen research, expand apprentice-

ships, build world-class universities, connect skilling more closely with industry and ensure that young women participate fully in the economic transformation. The demographic dividend is not automatic. It is an opportunity with an expiry date.

Twenty-five years of Narendra Modi in governance can be interpreted through many lenses: infrastructure, welfare, national security, technology, diplomacy or political communication. Yet the youth lens reveals something especially important. His politics has consistently been accompanied by a politics of possibility. From rebuilding a state in 2001 to articulating the ambition of a developed India by 2047, the connecting idea has been that scale is not something India should fear. It is something India should harness.

A quarter century ago, Modi began his first day in government in a state emerging from disaster. Today, he leads a country whose young people are entering an age of extraordinary technological and geopolitical change. The most enduring test of these twenty-five years will not be the longevity itself. It will be whether a generation of young Indians was given the confidence, tools and institutional space to build beyond what previous generations thought possible. On that measure, the story of Modi's seva is inseparable from the story of India's youth coming into its own.

The writer is National Secretary and National Spokesperson of the Bharatiya Janata Party and author of *Advantage India: Reshaping the Future for an Equitable World Order*

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Calcutta HC asks CBI probe into illegal constructions in Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Friday ordered a CBI inquiry into alleged illegal constructions in Kolkata. Acting on a PIL claiming rampant illegal construction of buildings in the city, the court asked the Kolkata Municipal Corporation as to why the civic body did not take any action in this regard. A division bench presided over by Chief Justice Ravindra Vilhalrao Ghuge directed the CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation) to conduct an inquiry into the matter. The petitioner alleged that there are at least 42 such illegal constructions where the ownership is not established. The division bench, also comprising Justice Tapabrata Chakraborty, asked the CBI to submit a preliminary inquiry report before the court on October 14, when the matter will be heard again. Claiming that huge sums of unaccounted for money may be involved in such illegal constructions, the petitioner stated that the question of national security was also involved. The petitioner prayed for a CBI investigation into such illegal constructions. (PTI)

HC seeks Govt, Delhi stand on Waqf Board plea



The Delhi High Court has sought the stand of the Centre and the city administration on a plea to constitute the Delhi Waqf Board.

Justice Anish Dayal issued notice to the governments on a petition seeking directions to them to complete the statutory process for constitution of the Board in accordance with the Waqf Act of 1995, as amended by the Waqf (Amendment) Act, 2025.

The petitioner's lawyer contended that after the expiry of the tenure of the last Delhi Waqf Board in August 2023, no steps have been taken for constitution of a fresh Board. In the meantime, an administrator was appointed in January 2024 by the Delhi government, but the board was yet to be constituted despite a statutory mandate, it was argued. On September 8, Justice Dayal gave four weeks to the Delhi government and Centre to file their replies.

The petitioner, Mohd Shahid, said in his plea that even after the 2025 amendment, Parliament has retained the statutory obligation to constitute a Waqf Board for every State and Union Territory, and the continued failure of the authorities to constitute the Board was, therefore, a breach of the statutory obligation imposed on them.

The plea alleged that the prolonged absence of the Board has exposed valuable waqf properties situated in the capital to serious risks of encroachment, unauthorised occupation, illegal alienation, misuse and deterioration.

"Public charitable institutions, mosques, graveyards, educational institutions and other waqf establishments dependent upon proper statutory supervision have suffered irreparable prejudice.

The beneficiaries of such waqfs, including worshippers and members of the Muslim community, have been deprived of the statutory safeguards envisaged by Parliament," the petition submitted.

"Executive authorities cannot, by prolonged inaction, permit a Parliamentary enactment to become ineffective.

Once Parliament has directed constitution of a statutory Board, the respondents are constitutionally bound to complete the statutory process within a reasonable period. Failure to do so amounts to arbitrary executive inaction and constitutes a direct violation of the Rule of Law," it stated.

Lawyers Rizwan Ahmad, Feroz Khan Ghazi, Mohd. Wasiq Khan, Himanshu Gupta and Mohd. Shoaib Ansari represented the petitioner. The matter would be heard next on December 10. (PTI)

Delhi High Court to examine motherhood, demands of sporting career

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has said it would examine and adjudicate upon the larger question of how motherhood and maternity are to be balanced against the demands of a sporting career.

The question arose during the hearing of a petition by wrestler Vinesh Phogat, who became a mother in July 2025 and has returned from maternity leave, seeking permission to participate in the women's selection trials for the 2026 Senior World Championships.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, in a late-night interim order on Thursday, refused to allow the grappler to partici-



pate in the selection trials scheduled to be held at the Indira Gandhi Stadium on September 14. It said at this interim stage, the court is of the view that the eligibility criteria applicable to all athletes ought not to be relaxed in favour of Phogat alone, particularly when such relaxation

Who owns the machine's imagination? AI, copyright and the Indian courts



DEVYANI SHEKHAR MISHRA

Artificial Intelligence has transformed the way creative works are produced, challenging traditional ideas of authorship, originality, and ownership. Today, AI systems can generate text, music, images, software, and other forms of creative expression with minimal human intervention. This technological development raises a fundamental legal question: when a machine creates, who owns its imagination?

Copyright law has traditionally been built around the idea of a human creator who exercises creativity and produces an original work. However, AI-generated works complicate this framework by separating the act of creation from the conventional human author. Questions arise as to whether an AI-generated work can receive copyright protection, whether the person who operates or trains the AI can claim ownership, and how much human involvement is necessary for copyright to arise.

The Copyright Act, 1957 was never written with machines in mind, yet it contains a clause that has suddenly become the most litigated provision in Indian IP law. Section 2(d)(vi) defines the "author" of a computer-generated literary, dramatic, musical or artistic work as "the person who causes the work to be created." That single phrase - "causes the work to be created" - is where every current Indian dispute over AI authorship begins.

One of the most famous test cases is the RAGHAV matter. In this case the Indian Copyright Office briefly registered an AI tool, RAGHAV, as co-author alongside its human user, Ankit Sahni, for an AI-assisted artwork. Following scrutiny, the Office withdrew the AI's co-author status, leaving the human prompter as sole author - signalling that Indian law is prepared to protect AI-assisted work, but only where a human has exercised enough "skill and judgment" to be treated as the true creative cause.

That unfinished business is now



Indian copyright law may protect work created with the assistance of AI, but the protection depends on meaningful human involvement. If a person uses AI merely as a tool while contributing sufficient skill, judgment, creativity, or intellectual effort, the human may be recognized as the true author of the resulting work. However, where the AI independently generates the work with little or no meaningful human contribution, claiming copyright protection becomes much more difficult. A generic prompt such as "draw a landscape" is unlikely to meet that bar; a carefully directed, iteratively refined creative process is more likely to. The line between the two remains for courts to draw, case by case.

before the courts directly. In *Stephen Thaler v. Union of India*, concerning a four-year-pending application to register a purely AI-generated artwork with no human author, the matter came up again this April, with the court directing the Copyright Office to actually progress the long-stalled hearing rather than let it languish. India's answer to the harder question - whether a work with no human author at all can be copyrighted here - is still awaited.

The bigger and more consequential battle, however, is not about who owns AI output, but about what AI is permitted to consume. In *ANI Media Pvt. Ltd. v. OpenAI OpCo LLC*, India's leading news agency accused OpenAI of training ChatGPT on its copyrighted reportage without licence, and of generating fabricat-

ed content falsely attributed to ANI. In an interim order delivered on 24 July 2026, Justice Amit Bansal of the Delhi High Court made two findings that will reverberate well beyond this one case. First, he rejected OpenAI's argument that Indian courts lack jurisdiction merely because its servers sit abroad, holding that Indian courts can hear such disputes wherever the effects of the alleged conduct are felt in India. Second, on a prima facie, interim-stage view, the Court found that storing ANI's content to train the model fell within the fair dealing exception under Section 52(1)(a) of the Act, and that ChatGPT's retrieval-augmented outputs were not substantially similar to ANI's original reports. Importantly, this is not a final verdict, nor a blanket licence for all AI train-

ing in India - the underlying suit continues on separate claims, and Section 57 of the Act still allows authors or their representatives to object to prejudicial distortion of their work independently of who holds the economic copyright.

A parallel front has opened around personality rights, where Indian courts have moved faster and more decisively than on training-data copyright. Bollywood playback singer Arijit Singh secured protection from the Bombay High Court against AI tools cloning his voice; Asha Bhosle obtained similar ad-interim relief against AI companies replicating her voice and likeness; and Aishwarya Rai Bachchan has since moved the Delhi High Court over unauthorised AI use of her image. These cases build on earlier precedent protecting the persona of figures like Anil Kapoor and Amitabh Bachchan, and confirm that even where Indian copyright law is still finding its footing on AI, the common-law right to one's own face, voice and identity is already being enforced against AI misuse - often more readily than copyright claims themselves.

For public, three implications follow. First, "who is the author" and "was the training lawful" are now two separate, live questions in Indian law, and clients need advice on both - not a general answer that AI content is or isn't protected. Second, jurisdiction is no longer a reliable shield for foreign AI companies; Indian claimants can sue where the harm lands, not only where the servers sit. Third, until Parliament legislates specifically on text-and-data-mining exceptions - as Japan and the EU already have - Indian courts will keep deciding these disputes through the imperfect fit of Section 52's fair dealing exception, on a case-by-case, often interim basis.

None of these rulings is final. The ANI suit continues to trial. The Thaler matter awaits a substantive hearing. What is settled, for now, is only this: Indian courts are willing to hear these dispute and willing to assert jurisdiction over global AI platforms. The law is being written, quite literally, one interim order at a time.

The author is a practising advocate of Patna High Court, and specialises in international laws, corporate laws and cyber laws

SC asks FSSAI for clarifications on nutrients of concern labels

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Supreme Court has asked the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India, which has proposed phased implementation of front-of-package labelling (FoPL) on packaged foods, to come up with more clarifications on the planned labels of "nutrients of concern", fat, sugar and salt.

FoPL is a nutritional information graphic on food packaging that can assist consumers in making an informed decision about food purchases and healthier dietary choices.

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran on Thursday also asked the Centre how it plans to increase nutritional literacy in schools while flagging that children are under acute risk of developing unhealthy eating behaviours.

"In connection with this, we would like the Union to respond on how schools plan to incorporate through curriculum, initiatives, work-

shops etc, (i) the manner in which information provided in packaged food items, including nutritional information, FoPL etc., must be interpreted, and (ii) other aspects relating to nutritional literacy," according to the court order uploaded late night. The matter has been posted for hearing on September 28.

The top court was hearing a plea of the public charitable trust '3S and Our Health Society' which sought directions to the Centre, states and Union territories to implement mandatory FoPL on packaged foods.

The FSSAI had earlier told the top court that it proposed to provide a prominent

front-of-pack warning label in red for food products high in added saturated fat, added sugar and salt.

In a compliance affidavit filed last month, the FSSAI said the two-phased proposal is intended to provide a simple, prominent and easily comprehensible warning to consumers regarding food products which are high in specified nutrients of concern.

The FSSAI's affidavit stated that the FoPL is intended to be implemented in phases to facilitate both "consumer acceptability" and "provide the industry adequate time for reformulation".

With that aim, Phase I is set to only cover products which are high in two or more of the specified nutrients and specified sweetened beverages, and Phase II is set to extend the label to products high in any one of these nutrients, it said.

On Thursday, the bench asked the FSSAI about the timeline for the implementation of the two phases.

SC stays Delhi HC order asking Govt to reinstate IAS officer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Supreme Court has stayed the reinstatement of IAS officer Rinku Dhugga, who was compulsorily retired by the Centre following a controversy over the Thyagaraj Stadium being allegedly emptied so she could walk her dog.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana issued notice to Dhugga on the Centre's challenge to the Delhi High Court judgment setting aside her compulsory retirement.

"In the meantime, the reinstatement of the respondent shall remain stayed," the bench said in its order on September 7.

The matter has been listed for further hearing on October 13. The Centre was represented by Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati.

Dhugga had challenged the Centre's decision before the Central Administrative

Tribunal (CAT), which ordered her reinstatement. The high court subsequently upheld the CAT's decision in its April 15 judgment.

The controversy dates back to 2022 when Dhugga and her husband, also an IAS officer, were accused of having the Thyagaraj Stadium emptied to enable her to walk her dog. There was outrage after photographs and reports of the episode.

The high court said the incident had resulted in a minor punishment in disciplinary proceedings. It also considered an allegation concerning her unautho-

rised absence. Both incidents were cited in connection with the decision to compulsorily retire her.

The high court also found that the review committee's decision recommending her compulsory retirement could not be sustained because it had failed to take into account several relevant aspects of her service record.

These included the absence of adverse remarks in her Annual Performance Appraisal Reports (APARs), her outstanding grading in preceding years and the fact that she was being considered for promotion.

The interest of the country in ensuring that its representatives are selected through a fair, uniform and performance-based process is of paramount importance," Justice Sharma said.

The judge added, "this court is also conscious that the larger question as to how motherhood and maternity are to be balanced against the demands of a sporting career, and whether an athlete ought to require to choose between motherhood and pursuing her career, merits careful consideration. However, that issue is yet to be finally examined and adjudicated upon in the present proceedings". Till the validity and applicability of the selection policy itself is adjudicated upon, the eligibil-

ity criteria prescribed thereunder cannot simply be set aside or wished away in the case of one athlete, and a special class cannot be carved out in favour of the petitioner, particularly when other athletes similarly placed may also face a comparable dilemma and may be required to make similar choices in the course of their sporting careers, it said.

The court was of the view that granting such interim relief to Phogat alone, without first adjudicating upon the policy, may result in unequal treatment to similarly placed athletes. It said that permitting Phogat to participate in the trials by granting her a special dispensation would not only be unfair to other athletes

across the country but would also have the effect of opening a Pandora's box with other athletes seeking similar exceptions from the prescribed eligibility criteria.

Phogat, in her application filed in a pending petition, also sought a stay on the operation of a September 7 circular issued by the WFI prescribing the eligibility criteria for the selection trials.

The fresh application was filed in the main petition in which the wrestler has sought formulation of a fair and structured framework for women athletes returning to competitive sports after pregnancy and maternity leave. In the application, she has sought a stay on the circular as it excludes her from partici-

ipating in the selection trials for the championship scheduled to be held at Astana, Kazakhstan from October 24 to November 1.

The court, in its order, said "To reiterate, the criteria prescribed under the circular dated September 7, 2026 apply uniformly to all athletes. An athlete who has not participated in the prescribed competitions, for whatever reason, would not fall within the eligibility categories specified by respondent no. 1 (WFI)".

It said Phogat's circumstances relating to pregnancy, childbirth and postpartum recovery would require consideration while examining the validity of the policy. However, that does not, at the interim stage, by itself entitle

her to a direction permitting her to participate contrary to the eligibility criteria, it added.

The WFI circular provides for women's trials in six Olympic weight categories. Phogat contended that the latest selection framework creates a closed pathway by making eligibility dependent on participation and performance in specified qualifying competitions.

The plea said the circular places Phogat in a position where she is excluded not because she has been assessed and found wanting on sporting merit but because she was unable to participate in the particular competitions selected by WFI as gateways to the present selection trials.

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BUSINESS11

BRICS seeks bigger say in World Bank, IMF, slams unilateral tariffs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

BRICS finance ministers and central bank governors called for greater representation of emerging-market and developing economies in the IMF and World Bank, and criticised unilateral tariffs and trade measures, as the expanded bloc sought to strengthen financial cooperation amid rising geopolitical and economic fragmentation. In a joint statement issued after meeting here, the ministers and central bank governors backed greater use of local currencies for trade and investment, and pushed ahead with work on cross-border payment systems.

The global economy, they said, faced heightened risks from geopolitical tensions, trade fragmentation, protectionism, policy uncertainty, fiscal and inflationary pressures, debt and financial vulnerabilities. "We continue to have serious concerns about the unilateral imposition of trade and finance-related actions, including the raising of tariffs and non-tariff measures, which distort trade and are inconsistent with World Trade Organisation (WTO) rules," BRICS members said without naming any country. They said such pressures

A Lion Capital of Ashoka in front of a banner for the 'BRICS Bharat Innovates Exposition 2026', ahead of the 18th BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi

weighed most heavily on emerging markets and developing economies and reaffirmed support for an "open, transparent, inclusive, non-discriminatory, and rules-based multilateral trading system with the World Trade Organisation (WTO) at its core". These remarks are important as the USA's trade and tariff policies have disrupted global trade. Declaring April 2, 2025, as "Liberation Day", US President Donald Trump announced a sweeping package of reciprocal global tariffs on a host of countries, including India, Brazil, Russia and China.

Though these tariffs were struck down by the US Supreme Court in February, the Trump administration

imposed additional 10 per cent tariffs on a number of countries, including India, from July 24.

The BRICS grouping renewed its call for reform of the Bretton Woods institutions, saying their governance structures should reflect the transformation of the global economy since the institutions were established. The bloc called for a greater voice and representation for emerging-market and developing economies in the IMF and World Bank, including through changes to quota and voting shares.

BRICS also urged the IMF to bring into effect without further delay the quota increases agreed under its 16th General Review of

Quotas and called for approaches to "meaningful quota realignment" to be developed at the earliest under the 17th review.

The group said any new quota formula should protect the shares of the poorest members and that voluntary financial contributions should not influence quota allocation, governance representation or voting power.

It also called for a merit-based, inclusive and transparent process for selecting the leadership of the IMF and World Bank, with greater regional diversity and representation from developing economies. Under India's 2026 BRICS chairship, members said they had continued work on the bloc's cross-border payments initiative, including examining interoperability between payment and messaging systems. The BRICS Payment Task Force has also discussed promoting trade settlements and investment using members' local currencies while recognising that there is no one-size-fits-all approach, the statement said.

The group encouraged further work to develop cross-border payment mechanisms that are fast, low-cost, accessible, efficient, transparent and secure.

BRICS finance ministers discuss cross-border payment plan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Finance ministers and central bank governors of BRICS countries have discussed the possibility of efficient cross-border payment mechanisms.

"We acknowledge the efforts of the BRICS Payment Task Force (BPTF) towards exploring pragmatic solutions for efficient cross-border payment mechanisms, drawing on the guidance provided by our leaders in the Kazan and Rio Declarations, on the BRICS Cross-Border Payments Initiative," a joint statement of BRICS Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors (FMCBG) said on Friday. The joint statement comes a day ahead of the two-day BRICS Summit being held in Delhi.

The BPTF also studied cross-border interoperability of payment and messaging channels, and held discussions on promoting trade settlements and investments using local currencies of BRICS countries, it said.

While pursuing these efforts, the task force has been asked to respect national priorities and recognise that there is no "one-size-fits-all" approach. "We encourage the BPTF to continue discussions, building on the ongoing work, to facilitate practical solutions for cross-border payments among BRICS countries, which are fast, low-cost, more accessible, efficient, transparent, and safe," the statement said.

With the growing share of emerging markets and developing economies (EMDEs) in global output and growth, reform of global 29 economic governance remains a consistent BRICS priority; it said they will continue to strengthen coordination among BRICS members to make interna-

tional financial institutions more representative, transparent and accountable.

FMCBG reiterated the urgent need to reform the Bretton Woods Institutions (BWI) to make them more agile, effective, credible, inclusive, fit for purpose, unbiased, accountable, and representative, to enhance their legitimacy.

BWI governance structure should be reformed to reflect the transformation of the global economy since their establishment, it said.

The voice and representation of EMDEs in the BWI must reflect their relative position in the global economy, it said. It also reiterated a call for improved management procedures, including through a merit-based, inclusive and transparent selection process that would increase regional diversity and representation of EMDEs in the leadership of the IMF and the World Bank.

FMCBG reaffirmed the BRICS Rio de Janeiro Vision for IMF Quota and Governance Reform and the need for a strong, quota-based and adequately resourced IMF at the centre of the global financial safety net to effectively support its members, particularly the most vulnerable countries. It reaffirmed that the 2025 World Bank Shareholding Review is a critical tool to strengthen multilateralism and enhance the legitimacy of the World Bank Group, as a better, bigger, and more effective development finance institution.

With regard to the New Development Bank (NDB), the joint statement said, "As it embarks on its second golden decade of high-quality development, we recognise and support the growing role of the NDB as a robust and strategic agent of development and modernisation in BRICS and the Global South".

MPC to reassess growth-inflation dynamics next meet: RBI Governor

Reserve Bank's Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) will reassess growth and inflation dynamics at its meeting next month amid rising prices of crude oil due to the ongoing West Asia crisis, Governor Sanjay Malhotra said on Friday. In an interview to CNBC-TV18, the governor also said nearly 50 per cent of the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank), or FCNR(B) deposits, mobilised under the forex swap facility is for 5-year tenor. The inflows under the FCNR (B) deposits totalled \$127.22 billion in the recently concluded RBI swap facility. On inflation, Malhotra said the rising crude oil prices will have an impact but it will depend on how much is passed through, he said.

"Crude has gone up. July was for the Indian basket an average of \$82 (per barrel). August it has gone up to \$90 (per barrel) and so that will certainly have some impact, but it will depend again on the pass-through," Malhotra said in the interview.

According to him, the Government has to a great degree absorbed and cushioned that shock, as a result of that the Indian economy has weathered this shock really well.

(PTI)

Bankers' Books Evidence Act to come into force from October 1

Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026 which got assent of the President of India last month, and is aimed at providing a modern framework for the use of banking records as evidence in line with contemporary banking practices, will come into force from October 1.

The notification dated September 10 appoints October 1, 2026 as the date on which provisions of the Act will come into force, the finance ministry said in a statement on Friday. The Act adopts a technology-neutral approach by recognising banking records maintained in physical, electronic, digital, virtual, cloud-based and other contemporary forms, it said. It also provides for simplified and standardised certification of banking records, including through manual, digital or electronic signatures. Greater clarity has also been provided on the summoning of bank officials where the bank is not a party to the proceedings, with a "special cause" to be recorded in writing by the court for such summoning, it said. Further, the Centre may extend provisions to specified financial sector entities or classes of entities, allowing the framework to cater to the evolving financial landscape, it said.

(PTI)

Critical minerals a key point of discussion in BRICS summit: Reddy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Critical minerals will be one of the major points of discussions at the BRICS Summit, Union Minister G Kishan Reddy said on Friday noting that the Government is taking multiple steps to boost availability of such minerals in the country.

Government-to-Government talks are being held with Argentina, Australia, and Chile to secure lithium blocks - a key requirement for nuclear power projects, the Minister for Coal and Mines said on the sidelines of CII Summit on Advanced Materials, Critical Minerals and Metals.

In BRICS Summit, critical minerals is one of the major agendas, and discussions will

be held around that, the minister said.

Reddy shared that on Thursday, he had a special meeting with a delegation of Russia, ahead of the BRICS Summit. The two-day BRICS Summit hosted by India starting Saturday is expected to

focus on boosting collective resilience in food, energy, health, disaster reduction, and critical supply chains with New Delhi positioning the bloc as an effective anchor to navigate a fragmented geopolitical environment. Highlighting the impor-

ance of critical minerals, Reddy said, today there can be no development without critical minerals.

"From cell phone to space technology to manufacturing of cameras, everywhere critical minerals are needed. So that's why the Government wants to make India self-sufficient," he added.

On lithium, the minister said efforts are being made to acquire blocks in Argentina, Australia and Chile.

Talks are being held at Government-to-Government as well as company-to-company levels.

He also suggested that private players should explore more critical mineral assets outside India, start exploration, process and supply them into the country.

INDIA NEEDS INCLUSIVE GROWTH TO BE DEVELOPED BY 2047: NITI CEO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

India has made reasonable progress on economic growth, and it needs inclusive growth to become a developed country by 2047, NITI Aayog CEO Anurag Jain said on Friday.

Speaking at the Global Fintech Fest 2026, Jain said some states have done extremely well on health and education parameters as well. "But there are certain states which are lagging behind, so we need to concentrate on them also," Jain said. He said India has a good foundation to achieve prosperity by 2047 through economic inclusion, where everyone has reasonable education and access to skills for gainful employment or entrepreneurship.

"We want inclusive growth for becoming a developed nation ... At the same time, on the income side, when you measure the per capita income, it is not only that ... we need to ensure how many people are actually the lowest 10 per cent or 20 per cent of the population," Jain said. Talking about technology, he said nobody knows what the future is going to be like.

Rupee falls 5 paise to close at 95.57 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee pared most of its initial losses and settled at 95.57 (provisional) against the US dollar, down by 5 paise, on Friday, helped by a correction in crude oil prices and suspected RBI intervention.

Forex traders said risk aversion in global markets and elevated crude oil prices are weighing on the rupee, which closed lower for the fifth consecutive session on Friday.

The rupee opened on a

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)	Change
Sept 4	94.43	+0.08
Sept 5	94.56	-0.13
Sept 6	94.74	-0.18
Sept 7	95.08	-0.34
Sept 8	95.57*	-0.05
Sept 9	95.52	-0.44
Sept 10	95.57	-0.05
Sept 11	95.57	-0.05

*Provisional
Source: KBK Infographics

negative note but pared some losses on suspected RBI intervention, a slight recovery in domestic stock markets from the day's lows and profit booking in crude oil prices at higher levels, traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.70 against the US dollar and fell further to a low of 95.79.

However, the local unit later pared losses to hit the day's high of 95.51 before closing down by 5 paise at 95.57 (provisional) against the American currency.

Banking services hit as unions strike for 5-day workweek

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Banking services, especially at public sector banks across the country, were impacted on Friday after the United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU) called a nationwide strike to press for the immediate implementation of a five-day workweek and resolve pending wage-related issues.

The strike call given by the UFBU, an umbrella body of seven unions representing 90 per cent of officer and employee strength, did not impact the functioning of private sector banks.

Most branches of public sector banks across the

country were either completely or partially closed as both employees and officers observed the strike.

Services such as cash deposits, withdrawals, cheque clearances, and administrative work were hit at branches of most public sector banks (PSBs) and some

old-generation private sector banks.

However, digital banking services, including UPI and internet banking, were functional. "Since there was no positive outcome and the Government did not agree to our demand, this strike is forced on us. Bank employ-

ees and officers are highly aggrieved that they alone are being discriminated against," the All India Bank Employees Association (AIBEA), a constituent of UFBU, general secretary C H Venkatachalam told PTI.

Meanwhile, most public sector banks have informed their customers of the likely impact of the strike on operations. In an advisory to customers, SBI had said, "We advise that while the bank has made all necessary arrangements to ensure normal functioning of the branches and offices on the days of strike, it is likely that work in banks may be impacted by the strike".

Stock markets end marginally lower on cooling oil prices, buying in HDFC Bank, IT stocks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty recovered from early lows to close marginally lower on Friday following a correction in crude oil prices and late buying in IT shares and private banking major HDFC Bank.

The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 120.83 points, or 0.16 per cent, to settle at 74,781.76. During the day, it fell 742.43 points, or 0.99 per cent, to 74,160.16. The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 79.70 points, or 0.34 per cent, to end at 23,398.10. Intraday, the benchmark tanked 246.4 points, or 1.04 per cent, to 23,231.40.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, Tata Steel, Reliance Industries, Sun Pharma, Bajaj Finance, NTPC, Power Grid, Larsen & Toubro and Axis Bank were the major laggards. HDFC Bank, Tech Mahindra, HCL Tech, Eternal, and Infosys were among the gainers.

Index	Previous Close	High	Open	Low	Close	Change
NSE Nifty	23,477.80	23,448.10	23,270.30	23,231.40	23,398.10	-79.70 (-0.34%)
BSE Sensex	74,902.59	74,917.15	74,309.16	74,160.16	74,781.76	-120.83 (-0.16%)

Source: KBK Infographics

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, declined 3.19 per cent to USD 104.2 per barrel.

"The market recovered from intraday lows, aided by value buying in select sectors, particularly IT, following a positive opening in European markets. Despite the rebound, weak market breadth suggests broader consolidation persists," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said. While elevated crude

prices, foreign outflows, and geopolitical uncertainty may keep volatility high, resilient domestic fundamentals and strong institutional support continue to attract buying at lower levels, limiting downside risks and supporting the medium-term outlook, he added. The BSE SmallCap Select index declined 0.67 per cent, while MidCap Select index ended marginally higher by 0.07 per cent.

Among the BSE sectoral indices, Realty tumbled 2.69 per cent, followed by Metal (2.40 per cent), Commodities (1.61 per cent), Energy (1.06 per cent), Utilities (1 per cent) and Auto (0.88 per cent).

Financial Services, Private Banks index, IT, Telecommunication, Bankex and Focused IT were the gainers. On the weekly front, the BSE benchmark tumbled 1,733.67 points, or 2.26 per cent, and the Nifty declined 499.6 points, or 2 per cent.

"Indian equities staged a sharp recovery from a gap-down opening on Friday, led by selective buying in a handful of index heavyweights. Despite the rebound, both the Nifty and Sensex ended marginally lower, while the Bank Nifty closed modestly higher, highlighting the narrow breadth of the recovery," Hariselman Radhakrishnan, Founder & CEO of HST Wealth, a Research Analyst firm.

Gold falls ₹2,700 to ₹1.55 lakh per 10g

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Precious metals took a beating on Friday, with gold prices declining by ₹2,700 to ₹1.55 lakh per 10 grams and silver tumbling by Rs 10,000 to ₹2.34 lakh per kg in the national capital.

Gold of 99.9 per cent purity depreciated by ₹2,700 to ₹1,55,900 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes), according to local traders. It had closed at ₹1,58,600 per 10 grams on Thursday. Silver also declined ₹10,000 to ₹2,34,600 per kg (inclusive of all taxes) against the previous close of ₹2,44,600 per kg.

Traders said the sharp correction in domestic bullion prices reflected selling pressure in the local market after the recent rally, with both precious metals pulling back.

The domestic selloff came despite gains in

global markets, where spot gold rose \$ 49.82, or 1.15 per cent, to \$4,366.58 per ounce and silver gained 2 per cent to \$64.77 per ounce.

Gold prices in the overseas trade recovered slightly but remained under pressure and are on track for a third consecutive weekly decline, said Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst - Commodities at HDFC Securities. Elevated crude oil prices have revived inflation concerns, while higher Treasury yields and rising rate-hike expectations continue to weigh on assets such as gold, he added.

Bank of India raises \$2.2 billion via FCNR(B): CEO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

State-owned lender Bank of India has mobilised USD 2.2 billion (around Rs 20,000 crore) through FCNR(B) deposits, which will largely replace bulk deposits and provide liquidity sufficient to meet about three months of the bank's lending needs, a senior bank official said on Friday.

The liquidity garnered through FCNR(B) deposits will help the bank meet its lending requirements for roughly one quarter, while reducing its reliance on bulk deposits, the official said.

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Five militants killed in KPK

Five militants of the banned Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISKP) have been killed in an operation by the Counter-Terrorism Department (CTD) in Pakistan's restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, an official said.

A key commander of the group, identified as Imran alias Abdullah alias Bilal alias Abu Bakr, was eliminated in the operation on Thursday night in Shamshatu refugee camp in Urmur village, about 25 km southeast of Peshawar, the official said.

Another militant was identified as Shahidullah, while efforts to establish the identities of the remaining three were underway. According to the CTD, it had received intelligence that militants were present in camp. Militants opened indiscriminate fire as its personnel entered the compound, prompting retaliatory action. (PTI)

US proposes to scrap H-1B visa 60-day grace period

SAGAR KULKARNI

■ Washington

The US has proposed a new rule to scrap the 60-day grace period available to certain foreign workers, including skilled workers on H-1B visas, to find a new job after losing employment.

The move will significantly impact Indian technology workers hired by tech companies and others on H-1B visas. The H-1B visa is a non-immigrant visa that allows US companies to employ foreign workers in speciality occupations that require theoretical or technical expertise.

Technology companies depend on it to hire tens of thousands of employees each year from countries like India and China. The new rule titled "Eliminating the Discretionary 60-day Grace Period" will be published in the Federal Register on Friday, and the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) has invited comments from the public within the next 60 days.

If the rule is finalised, foreign workers facing job loss before the expiry of their visas would need to leave the United States immediately,



unless they have separate authorisation to remain. "This proposal restores a direct relationship between an alien's nonimmigrant status and the specific employment or activity that formed the basis of his or her admission or grant of status in the United States and reduces administrative burden," the DHS said.

Under the proposal, the DHS would eliminate the discretionary, maximum 60-day grace period currently accorded to E-1, E-2, E-3, H-1B, H-1B1, L-1, O-1 and TN nonimmigrants, and their dependents, whose employment ceases. The grace period was added under Obama-era regulations to allow workers to more easily change employers by letting them remain in the US to pursue new job offers. In its proposal, DHS

acknowledges that if the grace period regulation is eliminated, some affected foreign nationals could be issued Notices to Appear (NTA), the government's first step in initiating removal (deportation) proceedings, Fragomen, an immigration attorney firm, said.

The prospect of NTA issuance may be likelier for those in nonimmigrant categories that require an employer to immediately notify the Government when employment of the foreign national has ceased, including H-1B, O-1, and P. DHS created the up to 60-day grace period rule in 2016 with an aim to enhance job portability, stability, and flexibility for high-skilled workers, and to make it easier for US employers to hire and transition nonimmigrant talent. (PTI)

India, China should handle conflict properly: Beijing, ahead of BRICS

KJM VARMA

■ Beijing

Ahead of President Xi Jinping's visit to India for the BRICS summit and bilateral talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, China on Friday said both countries should handle differences properly and view their ties from a strategic and long-term perspective.

President Xi will arrive in New Delhi on Saturday to attend the BRICS summit, his first visit to India in nearly seven years. He is scheduled to hold a bilateral meeting with PM Modi on the sidelines of the summit on Saturday.

Asked how China viewed the Modi-Xi meeting, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning told a media briefing here that this will be the third year in a row for the two leaders to meet with each other, following their meetings in Kazan and Tianjin.

"China will work with India to act on the strategic guidance of the two leaders, handle the bilateral relations from a strategic height and long-term perspective, step up communication, enhance cooperation, properly handle differences, and be friends enjoying good-neighbourliness and partners helping each other succeed," she said. About the BRICS summit, Mao said it is a key platform for solidarity and



Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning

cooperation among emerging markets and developing countries.

"President Xi will attend and address the upcoming summit, have in-depth exchanges with other leaders on major issues including the current international situation, the development of BRICS mechanisms, and deepening practical cooperation, and put forward China's important initiatives and propositions, charting the course for the high-quality development of greater BRICS cooperation," she said.

She said that China is ready to work with fellow BRICS countries for steady and sustained progress in greater BRICS cooperation to contribute to building a community with a shared future for humanity.

About the significance of the New Delhi summit, which is taking place amid the Iran-US conflict

and the Ukraine-Russia war, Mao said China advocates a common, comprehensive, cooperative, and sustainable approach to security.

"We are committed to promoting the political settlement of hotspot issues through dialogue. We look forward to working with fellow BRICS countries to promote dialogue and negotiation to resolve differences and jointly safeguard regional and global peace and stability," she said. Xi's visit is expected to be a high-profile diplomatic engagement with implications for the ongoing efforts to stabilise bilateral ties between the two Asian powers as well as for BRICS cooperation amid a volatile global situation.

As the current chair of the influential grouping, India will host the 18th BRICS Summit on September 12 and 13 in New Delhi. (PTI)

Nepal's flash floods death toll rises to 1,385

SHIRISH B PRADHAN

■ Kathmandu

The death toll in Nepal due to the flash floods rose to 1,385 on Friday as more bodies were recovered from the affected districts, while search and rescue operations continue for more than 5,000 missing people.

The flash floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal.

At least 364 bodies have been recovered from Chitwan district, 228 from Nawalparasi East, 222 from Nawalparasi West, 199 from Nuwakot, 185 from Rasuwa, 77 from Gorkha, 70 from Dhading and 38 from Tanahu, the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) said.

The joint command of security personnel has continued its search and rescue operations, with the number of missing people estimated to be 5,130. (PTI)



Saudi airstrikes hit Yemen's rebel-held Mokha airport



Smoke billows from an Israeli-controlled detonation in the village of Mansouri, as seen from Hanniyeh village, southern Lebanon

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Cairo

Yemen's Iranian-backed Houthi rebels captured a strategic island in the Bab el-Mandeb Strait at the entrance of the Red Sea, two officials said Friday in a swift advance that further threatens Saudi oil exports through one of the world's key commercial lanes.

Saudi Arabia responded with airstrikes against the airport in the key port city of Mokha that the Houthis seized on Thursday, a Houthi broadcaster said. There was no immediate report of damage or deaths.

The capture of Mayun, a tiny, barren volcanic island in the strait, was confirmed by a senior military official with Yemen's international recognised Government and by a Houthi official. Both spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to talk to journalists. The island, also known as Perim, is about 3.5 kilometres off Yemen's west coast. The strait is a key alternative to the Iran-choked Strait of Hormuz. But there is "no need for international concern," Hazam al-Assad, a member of the rebels' political bureau, told The Associated Press, saying they are responding to Saudi aggression, and "our forces have a bank of big important targets" in case Riyadh keeps up the strikes. Earlier Friday,

Iran's Government called for an end to Saudi Arabia's blockade of Yemen, throwing its support behind its ally, the Houthis. In its first statement since the rebels entered the port, Iran's Foreign Ministry also called for a return to negotiations between Saudi Arabia and the Houthis.

There was no immediate Saudi comment on Friday.

The rebels' capture of Mokha, overlooking tanker routes out of the Red Sea, could boost Iran's strategy of driving up world oil and gas prices to pressure the United States, experts say. It also raises concerns of a new front opening after more than six months of war in the region – one in which Saudi Arabia is forced to respond.

Experts say the developments in Yemen could give Tehran more leverage in any negotiations with the US. On Wednesday, the spokesperson for Iran's powerful Revolutionary Guard called for any negotiated settlement with the US to include Yemen, the first explicit reference to that front.

The Houthis' entry into Mokha on Thursday was their biggest territorial gain in years against their Saudi-backed Yemeni opponents. It brought them within 80 kilometres of the Bab el-Mandeb, a strait that has become an important alternative for global shipping as Iran targets vessels in the Strait of Hormuz.

F.No. Z-11017/101/2023-SCH

Government of India

Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment

Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (Divyangjan)

5th Floor, Pt. Deendayal Antyodaya Bhawan, CGO Complex, Lodhi Road, New Delhi – 110003

Advertisement in respect of the Umbrella Scholarship Scheme for Persons with Disabilities (Divyangjan) for the year 2026-27

The Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD) provides scholarship opportunities to Students with Disabilities (Divyangjan) under its welfare-oriented umbrella Scholarship Scheme. Eligible students are encouraged to avail themselves of the benefits available under the relevant scheme components and are advised to remain informed about the eligibility criteria, application process and prescribed timelines for applying for the scholarship.

I. Details of Scheme:

i. Pre-Matric (For IX & X class students), Post-Matric (For XI & XII and Degree/Diploma and Post-Graduate) and Top Class Education Scholarship(Graduate/Post-Graduate Degree/ Diploma in notified Institutes)

ii. National Fellowship for Persons with Disabilities (NFPwD) for M.Phil/Ph.D in Indian Universities

iii. National Overseas Scholarship(NOS) for Master's Degree/ Ph.D at Foreign Universities.

II. Instructions for applicants:

i. Pre-Matric, Post-Matric and Top Class Education Scholarship Schemes: Applicants are advised to apply online for the Pre-Matric, Post-Matric and Top Class Education Scholarship Schemes through the National Scholarship Portal (NSP) at www.scholarships.gov.in. A link to the NSP is also available on the website of the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD) at www.depwd.gov.in. Applicants may also apply through the National Scholarship Portal Mobile App.

ii. National Fellowship for Persons with Disabilities (NFPwD): The Fellowship is awarded to eligible candidates for pursuing regular and full-time M.Phil./Ph.D. programmes. Selection for the award of fellowship is based on the merit/scores obtained in the UGC-NET and CSIR-UGC-NET examinations conducted by the National Testing Agency (NTA) in the June and December cycles. The merit list is prepared by NTA on an All-India basis from among eligible candidates belonging to the benchmark disability category who have applied for JRF, Assistant Professor, and/or admission to Ph.D, but have qualified only for Assistant Professor and /or Admission to Ph.D. Shortlisted candidates are issued provisional award letters and are required to submit their willingness and other prescribed documents within the stipulated timeline. Thereafter, based on the merit list and availability of slots, eligible candidates are issued the final award letters for availing the fellowship under the NFPwD Scheme.

iii. National Overseas Scholarship (NOS): At present, applications for NOS scheme are received offline.

Details of the schemes including eligibility criteria and instructions for filling up the applications are available in Scheme Guideline, DEPwD at www.depwd.gov.in. Applicants are requested to provide correct and complete information while applying for scholarships as per scheme guidelines.

III. Timeline for application:

i. Applications for National Overseas Scholarship are received offline throughout the year.

ii. National Scholarship Portal is open for students (www.scholarship.gov.in) for registration for applying for the scholarship. The details of timeline pertaining to the applications submission in respect of Pre-Matric, Post Matric and Top Class Education Scholarship Schemes is available at the National Scholarship Portal (NSP)

IV. General Conditions of Eligibility:

i. The scholarships are open only to Indian nationals.

ii. All the components of scholarships are open to students with benchmark disability i.e. 40% or more disability as defined in 'Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 Further, the applicants should have/possess:

a. A valid certificate of disability issued by the competent authority

b. Aadhaar based biometric authentication.

iii. UDID/UDID enrollment

iv. Not more than two children with disabilities of the same parents will be entitled to receive benefits of the scheme. In case the second child is a twin, the scholarship under the schemes will be admissible to the twin.

v. Scholarship for studying in any class will be available for only one year. If a student has to repeat a class, she/he would not get scholarship for that class for a second (or a subsequent) year.

CBC 38117/11/0016/2627

PUBLIC NOTICE

We, Mr. Om Parkash Malhotra S/o Late Shri Sardari Lal Malhotra and Mrs. Ved Rani Malhotra W/o Mr. Om Parkash Malhotra R/o F-4/12, Sector-15, Rohini, New Delhi-110089, hereby declare that due to the misconduct and quarrelsome behaviour of our son Deepak Malhotra and daughter-in-law Pragya Setti, we have disowned and severed all relations with them and debarred them from our movable and immovable properties. Henceforth, they shall be solely responsible for all their acts and dealings.

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Ruchi Jain is the owner of the Land area measuring 1 Bigha 6 Biswas 15 Biswas (i.e. 3339 Sq. Yds., out of Khata No. 90/8 (10-28) & 90/7 (4-12) Situated in the revenue estate Gheva, New Delhi-110081 through Sale Deed dated 21.07.2023 doc. No. 3430 executed by Mr. Sumit Lakra in favour of Mrs. Ruchi Jain in respect of said property.

Mrs. Ruchi Jain is in the process of mortgaging the said property with Hero FinCorp Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-10, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline(s): +91012-0449711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Kotak Mahindra Bank

NOTICE

Locker Hired by MR. SANTOSH RAMACHANDRAN NAIR & DIPI SANTOSH NAIR having address at 15 BEDOK RESERVOIR VIEW 12-04 SINGAPORE-478933 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at SCO-16, SEC-14 GURUGRAM-122001 remains un-operated from last 8 years & 6 Months.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. SANTOSH RAMACHANDRAN NAIR & DIPI SANTOSH NAIR calling them to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and they are not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. SANTOSH RAMACHANDRAN NAIR & DIPI SANTOSH NAIR within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 11, 2026 at around 12p.m.

Corporate Off. : 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Registre BNC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai – 400051, Regd. Off. : Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai – 600116, TN

POSSESSION NOTICE FOR IMMOVABLE PROPERTY [(Appendix IV) Rule 8(1)]

WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. a Housing Finance Company (fully registered with National Housing Bank (Fully Owned by RBI)) (hereinafter referred to as "SMHFC") under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002), and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notice dated mentioned below under Section 13(2) of the said Act calling upon you being the borrowers (names mentioned below) to repay the amount mentioned in the said notice and interest thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers mentioned herein below having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers mentioned herein below and to the public in general that the undersigned has Taken Possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrowers mentioned here in above in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with said property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of "SMHFC" for an amount as mentioned herein under and interest thereon.

Sr.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of Secured Assets (Immovable Property)	Demand Notice Date & Amt.	Date of Possession
1	LAN - 610839212189665 1. Shaib Mahmood S/o, Mahmood	Property Khastara No. 47, Area 50 Sq. Gaj 41 80 Sq. Mtrs. Situated At Gram Dahwali Gaspur (West of Kali Nadi), Tehsil & District Meerut, Uttar Pradesh, East : Rasta 14 Fit Wide; West : House Of Dr. Anil; North : Plot Of Ubead; South : Plot of Arun.	23.06.2026 Rs. 9,79,369.84 (Rs. Nine Lakh Seventy Nine Thousand Three Hundred Sixty Nine & Paise Eighty Four Only) along with interest as on 16.06.2026	10.09.2026
2	LAN - 610838012137683 1. SANNI KUMAR S/o. Raju	A Residential House Nagar Nigam No. 88, Built On Plot No. 01 Measuring 120 Sq. Yards Or 100 Sq. Meters Consisting of Part of Khastara No. 359, A Residential Plot No. 01, Situated At Shekhpura Maliyana Pargana, Tehsil & District : Meerut, Uttar Pradesh. East : Plot of Premwati; West : House of Ramesh; North : House of Uday Ram; South : Rasta 12 Fit Wide.	23.06.2026 Rs. 30,75,272.10 (Rs. Thirty Lakh Seventy Five Thousand Two Hundred Seventy Two & Paise Ten Only) along with interest as on 16.06.2026	07.09.2026
3	LAN - 610539511703637 1. Sukhdev Vasudev S/o. Vasudev	House On Part of Khastara No. 213 mi. Area 404.68 Sq. Mtrs. Situated At Mouza : Barika Chatta, Mathura Uttar Pradesh. East : Land Of Vasdev; West : Land of Sugdhi ; North : Road 6 Mtrs. To Above; South : House of Bheema.	23.06.2026 Rs. 9,14,026.84 (Rs. Nine Lakh Fourteen Thousand Six Hundred Twenty Six & Paise Eighty Four Only) along with interest as on 16.06.2026	10.09.2026
	LAN - 610539511880114 1. Tikaram Sharma S/o. Prem Sukha Sharma	Residentil Plot Area Measuring 229.82 Sq. Mtrs. Out Of Khastara No. 311, Situated At Mouza : Husani, Tehsil : Chhata, Mathura, Uttar Pradesh. East : House Girraj; West : House of Jagveer; North : House of Hansha; South : Rasta Less Than 6 Mtrs. Wide.	23.06.2026 Rs. 10,71,406.88 (Rs. Ten Lakh Seventy One Thousand Four Hundred Six & Paise Eighty Eight Only) along with interest as on 16.06.2026	10.09.2026

Place : Meerut / Mathura, Uttar Pradesh
Date : 10.09.2026 / 07.09.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

M.P. STATE AGRICULTURAL MARKETING BOARD

26, Arera Hills, Jail Road, Bhopal

No./Const./BN/Sagar/26-27 /521 Bhopal, Dated : 10.09.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Online Percentage Rate E-Tenders are invited from Contractors registered with the Office of the Engineer in Chief, M.P. Public Works Department, Government of Madhya Pradesh (Centralized Registration Cell) for : **Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_535558 (PAC amount Rs. 92.36 Lakh) Asphalting work at Mandi yard Garhakota Distt. Sagar, Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_535559 (PAC amount Rs. 132.08 Lakh) Leveling with CC work and Drain at Mandi yard Garhakota Distt. Sagar, Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_535560 (PAC amount Rs. 73.16 Lakh) Construction of Office Building and Farmer rest House at Mandi yard Garhakota Distt. Sagar, Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_535561 (PAC amount Rs. 28.25 Lakh) External Electrification work at Mandi yard Garhakota Distt. Sagar, Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_535562 (PAC amount Rs. 108.06 Lakh) Maintenance of Existing Structure at Mandi yard Garhakota Distt. Sagar, Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_535563 (PAC amount Rs. 86.69 Lakh) Construction of Trolley shed, Covered Shed and Cement concrete work at Sub Mandi Shahpur of KUMS Sagar Distt. Sagar, Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_535564 (PAC amount Rs. 325.40 Lakh) Construction of High rise Shed and Leveling with CC work at Mandi yard Rehli Distt. Sagar, Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_535566 (PAC amount Rs. 69.27 Lakh) Asphalting work at Mandi yard Rehli Distt. Sagar. The following works Tender to be Received Online up to 17:00 on 05.10.2026. Technical bid documents with EMD & Financial Offer to be received online only as per Detailed NIT. The tender documents can be obtained online on the <http://mptenders.gov.in> as per the Notice Published on the above Portal and detailed information can also be seen on website www.mpmadiboard.gov.in**

Note: Any corrigendum in this NIT, if required, shall be displayed only in our above portal regarding any matter included in this NIT or otherwise. Other details of Construction/ Development works and locations & key dates can also be seen on our website www.mpmadiboard.gov.in M.P. Madhyam/128037/2026 EXECUTIVE ENGINEER (PROJECT CELL)

RAM GOPAL COLLEGE OF PHARMACY

Sultanpur, Tehsil-Farakhnagar, Near Sultanpur Bird Sanctuary, Distt. Gurgaon, Haryana

Affiliated to Pt. B.D.Sharma University of Health & Sciences, Rohtak & Pharmacy Council of India (PCI) and State Govt. Haryana

ADMISSION NOTICE FOR SESSION 2026-27

(For Management quota, Leftover seats, Vacant Seats for All Category)

BACHELOR OF PHARMACY

Later Entry (LEET) 3 Year

Admission Procedure: Candidates shall have passed Diploma in Pharmacy. Admission on merit based only.

Last date of submission of application form - 14/09/2026 till 1:00 pm
Display & merit list and deposition of fees - 15/09/2026 till 4:00 pm

Website - www.ramgopalcollege.com Mob. No - 8607422070

Russian drones target Kyiv gas stations

HANNA ARHIROVA ■ Kyiv

Russian drones targeted roadside gas stations in Kyiv for a second straight day Friday, as Moscow broadened its air war in what Ukrainian officials say is an effort to rattle civilians.

Russian strikes on urban gas stations have intensified in recent months, mostly in regions near the front line in eastern and southern Ukraine. It is part of a campaign to disrupt civilian life and weaken morale that has also included attacks on food distribution hubs, leaving some supermarket shelves bare in the Ukrainian Capital.

Ukraine is urgently trying to improve its air defences as Russia's invasion stretches into its fifth year, and on Thursday won pledges of more support from Canada.

Ukraine, meanwhile, has extended its own long-range drone campaign deep into Russia, straining air defences across its bigger neighbour's vast territory. On Thursday, its military reported hitting a refinery more than 3,000 kilometres away in Siberia as Kyiv tries to hurt Russia's vital oil sector. Its strikes have caused fuel shortages in Russia, one of the world's biggest energy producers.

Russia's oil product exports hit record lows in August, and Moscow is importing fuel from South Korea and India, the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air said in a report. "Ukrainian strikes on Russia's refining capacity have turned



UK CHIEFS CLAIM 1.5M RUSSIAN TROOPS DEATH

Kyiv: More than half a million Russian troops have been killed in Ukraine since the start of Moscow's full-scale invasion in February 2022, a senior British defence official said Friday.

The dead are part of 1.5 million Russian casualties in Ukraine, Air Chief Marshall Sir Richard Knighton, Chief of the UK's Defence Staff, said. The UK figures roughly coincide with those published by the Ukrainian military. There was no immediate comment from Russian officials, Moscow's bigger army is struggling to make headway on the battlefield. Western officials and analysts say the Russian rate of advance has slowed significantly this year. (AP)

tables on the world's once largest oil product exporter to see them start importing fuels, with imports surging to a record 172,000 metric tons (189,600 tons) in August — more than seven times the previous monthly high," the Finland-registered nonprofit said on Thursday.

Drones hit two gas stations in 10 minutes in Kyiv's Dniprovskyi and Obolonskyi districts Friday. Five people, including a rescuer, were wounded, the State Emergency Service said.

Ukrainian officials and analysts have warned for months that Russia would extend gas station strikes to the capital as part of its campaign to intimi-

date civilians. Authorities have urged residents not to linger near gas stations and other exposed infrastructure during air raid alerts.

Pavlohrad, a city in central Ukraine, observed an official day of mourning Friday for five residents killed near shopping malls in broad daylight by Russian drones the previous day. The attack also wounded 67 people, Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said on X.

In the southern city of Zaporizhzhia, a 32-year-old woman and her 10-year-old son were wounded in an overnight Russian drone attack, Ukraine's State Emergency Service said. The drones struck a nine-story apartment block

and a shopping mall, it said. Efforts to put out the blazes were slowed by the constant threat of repeat strikes, forcing firefighters to stop working and take shelter, it added.

Ukraine launched a major barrage overnight from Thursday to Friday, with the Russian Defence Ministry saying air defences intercepted 777 Ukrainian drones over 16 Russian regions, as well as occupied Crimea and the waters of the Azov and the Caspian seas. Two people were killed and three others wounded overnight in a Ukrainian drone attack on the Tula region south of Moscow, local officials said. (AP)

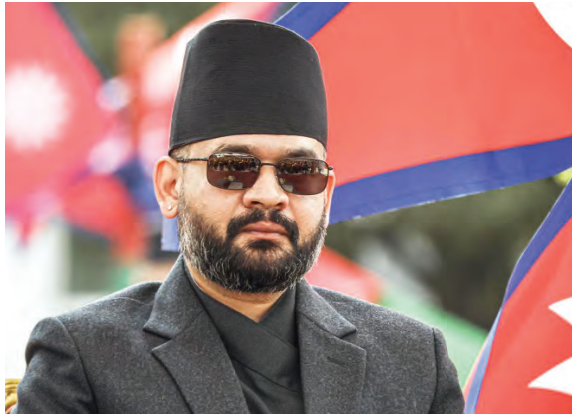
Nepal PM Shah to highlight climate change, flood losses at UNGA: official

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah will highlight the impacts of climate change, including the significant loss of lives and property his country has suffered from climate-induced disasters, at the upcoming UN General Assembly session, a top official said on Friday.

Shah will visit the US for the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) in New York from September 22 to 26. This would be his first foreign visit since assuming office in March. "Prime Minister Shah is scheduled to address the General Debate on September 24, 2026," said Foreign Secretary Amrit Bahadur Rai during a press briefing at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs on Friday.

During his address, Shah will raise the issue of climate



change and its impacts in the wake of the devastating Bhotekoshi flash floods of August 26.

Rai said the heavy losses borne by Nepal due to the flash floods have proven again that the country lies on "the forefront of the crisis emerging from climate change". He said countries like Nepal suffer from the negative effects of carbon

emissions, even though they have a minimal contribution to greenhouse gas emissions. "In this context, the Prime Minister will draw the attention of the global community towards climate change and the huge loss of life and property facing Nepal from time to time as its consequences," he said.

Shah will also call for the international community for

immediate and appropriate compensation from the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage and other organisations for climate justice, Rai said.

The flash floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal, killing more than 1,300, while more than 5,000 remain missing.

The disaster also caused huge damage to the country's property and infrastructure. "Nepal will also urge the international community, especially the rich and developed countries, to provide Climate Finance in a subsidised manner, necessary assistance and technical support for climate-resilient infrastructure, promote climate-smart agriculture, and capacity building of the concerned stakeholders," Rai added. (PTI)

High school stabbing in Croatia leaves two wounded, attacker held



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Zagreb

A student in a high school in Croatia's Capital, Zagreb, on Friday stabbed and wounded another student and a janitor, authorities said.

The attacker was detained. Croatia's Ministry of Education said he used a "sharp object" in the attack. The student who was attacked received surgery for multiple stab wounds but was out of danger and the school employee suffered face injuries, the authorities said.

The Index news portal reported the attack followed a falling-out between the students on Thursday. Videos from the scene show the building cordoned off during a police investigation. In December 2024, a knife-wielding former student walked into a school in Zagreb, stabbed a 7-year-old girl to death and wounded three more children and their teacher.

Bangladesh police detain 63 foreigners over online fraud

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

Bangladesh police have detained 63 foreigners, mostly from Laos, Pakistan and China, on charges of involvement in online fraud in the southeastern port city of Chattogram, officials said on Friday.

"Acting on secret information, a joint team of our detectives, counter-terrorism unit and RAB (Rapid Action Battalion) conducted a predawn raid at an eight-storey building in Chattogram and detained them on charges of online scamming," a police spokesperson said.

The detainees included 35 nationals of Laos, 21 Pakistanis, five Chinese, one



Nepali and one Vietnamese national while the identification of the remaining detainees was still underway, the spokesperson said.

Among the 63 arrested individuals, there were 41 men, 21 women and a child. Khulshi police station chief Mohammad Abdur Rahim said police seized

equipment allegedly used for fraudulent activities, along with 131 mobile phones, 56 laptops, US dollars and other foreign currencies. Data stored on the seized electronic devices were being examined to determine the nature of the activities being conducted from the building, he said.

Port city police spokesman Aminur Rashid said the detainees were being questioned and legal documents related to their stay in Bangladesh were also being scrutinised.

The development came more than a week after police in the southeastern beach town of Cox's Bazar detained five Chinese and one Taiwanese national in a similar raid at a luxury hotel.

US commemorates 25th anniversary of 9/11 attacks with tributes and silence

JENNIFER PELTZ ■ New York

Americans are commemorating the 25th anniversary of 9/11, remembering the shock, the dead and the sweeping consequences of the al-Qaida attacks on symbols of US might and prosperity.

On Friday's milestone anniversary will bring memorial rituals —wreath-laying, flag-flying, moments of silence, vigils and readings of victims' names — and volunteer projects in tribute to a day that about half of US adults remember as the most historic event of their lifetime, according to a new poll.

For others it's an occasion for private reflection — or, in many schools, education — about the attack that unfolded in a single morning but left nearly 3,000 dead and a decades-long trail of aftermath, from personal grief to far-flung wars.

Police Officer Casey Kloefer plans to spend time Friday at the Brooklyn station house where his father, Officer Ronald Kloefer, reported to work that day before being called to the World Trade Centre. He didn't make it home.

Casey Kloefer was only 4, but he grew up hearing about his father's affinity for helping people and for a job that enabled him to do so. He became an officer this past June. "It's big footsteps to fill, but it's definitely something that I take very seriously and want to continue to honour him and be the best police officer I can," he said by phone this week. The 29-year-old wears his father's badge number and even has



A person pauses at the memorial ahead of a ceremony commemorating the 25th anniversary of the Sept. 11, 2001, attacks at the National September 11 Memorial in New York City on Friday

joined the New York Police Department lacrosse team, which his dad founded.

Trump to attend Pentagon observance

On September 11, 2001, al-Qaida extremists hijacked four commercial jets and crashed them into New York's World Trade Centre, the Pentagon and a field near Shanksville, Pennsylvania.

The impacts brought down the World Trade Centre's twin towers — icons of US economic power, and among the tallest buildings on Earth — and blew a hole in the Pentagon, the US military's fortresslike headquarters near Washington. The fourth plane also was headed for the nation's capital, officials concluded, but the aircraft went down in

Pennsylvania after passengers and crew members stormed the cockpit and fought the hijackers. "In the course of history, there are a few moments that divide time into, really, what came before" and after, President Donald Trump said at a 9/11 remembrance in Washington this week. The Republican, who was in his native New York on September 11 and has often recounted his memories, plans to attend the Pentagon's anniversary ceremony on Friday.

Vice President JD Vance is expected at the observance at the National September 11 Memorial in New York, while other administration officials are headed to the Flight 93 National Memorial in Pennsylvania. Planned remem-

brances extend far beyond the attack sites, from beams of light projecting from New Hampshire's Mount Washington to a stair climb at Mississippi State University's football stadium to a ceremony at Honolulu's 9/11 memorial.

Traditionally, there are no political speeches at the New York commemoration, where relatives read all the victims' names, punctuated with moments of silence at key points in the attack timeline.

This year's ceremony will add a silent moment to honour people who were exposed to the clouds of toxic dust released by the twin towers' fiery collapse and have since died of cancer and other illnesses. (AP)

Over 90 Pak Sikhs with visas stopped from boarding indirect flight to India



M ZULQERNAIN ■ Lahore

Over 90 Pakistani Sikhs with visas for pilgrimage to Sri Hemkund Sahib in Uttarakhand were stopped by the immigration authorities on Friday from boarding an indirect flight to India, officials said.

As many as 92 Pakistani Sikhs, including women and children, arrived at the Faisalabad International Airport (some 150 km from Lahore) to catch an indirect flight to India, an official of the Federal Investigation Agency (FIA) said.

However, the authorities stopped them from boarding a Gulf-bound airline as they did not possess a return ticket and a no-objection certificate (NOC) from the federal government, the official added. "The immigration officials told them to produce an NOC from the federal government and the return ticket, after which they would be allowed to proceed to their destination," he said.

Currently, there is no direct air, rail or road link between Pakistan and India. Another official from the federal government told PTI that the Sikhs in question had arranged their Indian visas through the Delhi Mandar Management Committee on their own.

"They should have coordinated with the Pakistan Sikh Gurdwara Parbhandhak Committee for their travel and preferred Wagah Border for crossing into India," he said, adding that it is likely that they may be allowed to go for pilgrimage via the Wagah Border.

In a video being widely shared online, a Pakistani Sikh at the Faisalabad airport is heard saying that the immigration authorities have stopped them from travelling to India. "For the last four hours we are languishing at the Faisalabad airport... someone should take notice of this and help the pilgrims proceed to their destination," he said. (PTI)

AXIS BANK LTD.					
PUBLIC NOTICE FOR - AUCTION OF PLEDGED ASSETS BEING GOLD ORNAMENTS					
The Borrowers, in specific and the public in general are hereby notified that public auction of the gold ornaments pledged in the below accounts is proposed to be conducted by the Axis Bank at the below mentioned Branch. That the below mentioned Borrowers has availed the credit facility from the Axis Bank Limited against the pledge of gold ornaments ("Gold Loan Facility") in favour of the Bank towards the security. The Demand notices were issued to the Borrowers/Guarantors calling up the Borrowers/Guarantors to pay their outstanding loan amount, the bank is constrained to invoke the pledge and proposed to conduct an auction sale of pledged gold ornaments more particularly described in schedule of property hereunder on 12.10.2026 at 11:00 AM on "As in Where Is", "As is What Is", "Whatever There Is" and "No Recourse Basis". Auction will be held at					
DETAILS OF BORROWERS AND OUTSTANDING AMOUNT					
Customer Name	Loan A/c No.	Amount Outstanding (RS.)	Date of Recall Notice	Gross Weight.	Net Weight.
B.O.- ASHOK VIHAR, NEW DELHI [DL]					
JAI PARKASH	XXXXXXXXXXXX8053	RS. 34,06,072.65	14-08-2026	436.400	412.200
B.O.- DARYAGANJ, DELHI [DL]					
NIRBHAY KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX7934	RS. 64,915.00	04-08-2026	7.230	6.960
SUNIL RAWAT	XXXXXXXXXXXX5758	RS. 6,94,493.00	04-08-2026	92.190	88.490
B.O.- DLF, GURGAON [HR]					
ANUBHA MISHRA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX917	RS. 10,93,703.00	19-02-2026	158.300	145.300
ANUBHA MISHRA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX1927	RS. 5,26,804.80	18-05-2026	73.200	67.300
B.O.- FARIDABAD [HR]					
HARENDER KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXXX2137	RS. 3,21,462.00	04-08-2026	46.500	36.300
B.O.- GHAZIABAD [UP]					
DIVYA UPADHYAY	XXXXXXXXXXXXX7174	RS. 18,57,442.00	27-07-2026	207.500	192.300
OM PRAKASH PANDEY	XXXXXXXXXXXXX9031	RS. 1,45,539.00	14-08-2026	20.800	19.200
B.O.- GREATER NOIDA [UP]					
RIZWAN KHAN	XXXXXXXXXXXXX1212	RS. 2,59,623.61	04-08-2026	52.600	38.000
B.O.- HAYATPUR GUR HR					
RAHUL JAIN	XXXXXXXXXXXXX0127	RS. 1,57,971.00	30-07-2026	256.400	207.400
B.O.- INDIRAPURAM, GHAZIABAD [UP]					
SARITA DEVI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX3425	RS. 2,84,096.00	04-08-2026	31.700	30.300
B.O.- JAJMAU KAN UP					
SONI DEVI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX3342	RS. 1,31,796.40	14-08-2026	13.600	12.700
B.O.- JANAKPURI, NEW DELHI [DL]					
SANJAY SACHDEVA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX6845	RS. 2,44,131.77	12-02-2026	44.800	42.900
B.O.- JYOTI NAGAR DEL DL					
WASID ALI ANSARI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX1774	RS. 1,81,969.92	04-08-2026	22.000	21.100
B.O.- KISHANGANJ OD DL					
DAVINDER KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXXX6942	RS. 59,482.00	04-08-2026	8.100	6.200
MANISH SHAH	XXXXXXXXXXXXX4946	RS. 5,19,074.00	04-08-2026	59.240	52.940
POONAM RANI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX8122	RS. 3,01,075.00	13-07-2026	34.050	32.450
ROHIT SAIN	XXXXXXXXXXXXX5725	RS. 1,71,996.00	03-08-2026	22.110	20.360
B.O.- LAJWANTI GARDEN, JANAKPURI, NEW					
ISHA MISHRA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX6271	RS. 3,06,391.19	04-08-2026	36.100	34.000
B.O.- MALVIYA NAGAR, NEW DELHI [DL]					
RAUSHAN KUMAR MADYAV SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXXX8424	RS. 1,00,701.00	04-08-2026	21.000	17.000
B.O.- MEERA BAGH, NEW DELHI [DL]					
RAKHI JINDAL	XXXXXXXXXXXXX3079	RS. 13,71,622.75	19-02-2026	183.700	176.500
RAVI JINDAL	XXXXXXXXXXXXX0919	RS. 16,55,506.00	19-02-2026	299.200	227.800
RAVI JINDAL	XXXXXXXXXXXXX2408	RS. 3,30,171.00	19-02-2026	57.100	45.400
B.O.- NOIDA [UP]					
BRJU KISHOR VERMA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX7647	RS. 8,51,600.00	30-07-2026	228.160	209.960
B.O.- NOIDA EXTENSION GNO UP					
BHAGHYALATHA P P	XXXXXXXXXXXXX5487	RS. 29,05,476.00	04-08-2026	402.700	367.800
SANIDIP TIWARI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX7062	RS. 1,62,440.00	04-08-2026	22.800	21.600
TARUN GOSWAMI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX1217	RS. 88,694.00	04-08-2026	11.200	10.600
B.O.- PALAM VIHAR, GURGAON [HR]					
SUNITA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX4002	RS. 1,56,016.90	18-05-2026	25.600	25.300
B.O.- PARADISE MALL S GUR HR					
POOJA CHAUHAN	XXXXXXXXXXXXX9800	RS. 70,038.07	04-08-2026	10.400	10.000
RAJU SAINI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX3893	RS. 19,09,871.62	02-04-2026	213.100	193.700
VICKY KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXXX9047	RS. 43,929.00	14-08-2026	7.800	7.200
B.O.- R K MISSION, NEW DELHI [DL]					
NANHE	XXXXXXXXXXXXX6209	RS. 79,198.00	04-08-2026	15.460	14.900
B.O.- RAJ NAGAR, GHAZIABAD [UP]					
HEMANT KR RAI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX4445	RS. 12,38,303.80	02-04-2026	186.900	174.300
B.O.- SECTOR 10A GURGAON [HR]					
BHUPENDER SHARMA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX9461	RS. 76,157.18	14-08-2026	14.100	12.300
VIKASH KUMAR MISHRA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX7314	RS. 5,78,622.04	03-08-2026	79.900	77.200
B.O.- SECTOR 12 NOIDA					
ATUL KUMAR SHARMA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX0304	RS. 9,31,722.00	04-08-2026	138.600	132.600
B.O.- SECTOR-18, NOIDA [UP]					
INDERJEET SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXXX2764	RS. 1,64,737.02	04-08-2026	17.400	16.860
MANISHA CHAUHAN	XXXXXXXXXXXXX3156	RS. 3,46,084.35	04-08-2026	75.400	65.300
MANISHA CHAUHAN	XXXXXXXXXXXXX0387	RS. 1,71,629.00	04-08-2026	32.080	30.350
B.O.- SECTOR-24,ROHINI, NEW DELHI [DL]					
KRISHNA CHOUDHARY	XXXXXXXXXXXXX8086	RS. 7,03,979.00	29-06-2026	276.300	258.800
YOGESH BHATIA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX9326	RS. 4,90,619.00	18-05-2026	78.300	73.800
B.O.- SHALIMAR BAGH, DELHI [DL]					
MUKESH VERMA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX1147	RS. 5,78,141.00	04-08-2026	65.500	60.800
B.O.- SOUTH PATEL NAGAR DL					
ANUP GABA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX6226	RS. 12,09,660.70	29-06-2026	596.700	532.400
B.O.- VAISHALI, GHAZIABAD [UP]					
YOGESH KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXXX5815	RS. 5,25,376.82	14-08-2026	90.800	86.600
B.O.- VISHWAS NAGAR DEL DL					
MOHD SHUAIV	XXXXXXXXXXXXX3721	RS. 1,73,238.00	04-08-2026	24.300	23.600
MOHD YUSUF ANSARI	XXXXXXXXXXXXX3084	RS. 2,77,245.00	04-08-2026	32.900	30.800
VIVEK KUMAR SHARMA	XXXXXXXXXXXXX8834	RS. 77,174.00	27-07-2026	8.900	8.400
TERMS & CONDITIONS OF TENDER					
The Base/Reserve price will be given on the auction day/date to the tenderers on which the auction bid will be considered. The bid/offers in the prescribed tender form provided by the bank shall only be considered for bidding. Incomplete bid form/tender are treated invalid and shall liable to be rejected. The tender documents along with the terms and conditions shall be collected from the above branch: The tender document duly completed to be handed to the concerned branch official during working hours on 12.10.2026. Tenders received after the due date will not be considered. The said properties is / are offered for sale on "As Is Where Is", "As Is What Is", "Whatever There Is" and "No Recourse" Basis. The Bank does not undertake any responsibility to standard, purity and / or any other dues, taxes, if any, in respect of the said property. Tenders will be opened by the Bank on the auction date in the presence of the tenderers who may choose to remain present on the day and time as said above, inter alia, for raising / revising their respective offers.					
Branch Names Mentioned Above. Auction Date: 12.10.2026.					
Offer/tender once submitted cannot be withdrawn and bidder will liable to deposit the bid amount if there is single bid/ offer for particular article/asset/ornament.					
If there are more than one bid for particular article/asset/ornament, inter-se bidding shall take place amongst the bidder and highest bidder shall be declare as successful bidder.					
Bidder should submit all KYC documents i.e. PAN Number, PAN Card, Adhar Card & Address proof etc. Bidder should submit valid E-mail ID & Contact Number.					
The Bank reserves its right to accept or reject the offer at its sole discretion.					
Any disputes / differences arising out of sale of the said property/ offered for sale shall be subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of Courts / Tribunals at Mumbai only.					
PLACE: DELHI, DATE: 12.09.2026			SD/- AUTHORIZED OFFICER, AXIS BANK LTD.		

Anthropic foils AI misuse for cyber, bio threats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid the ongoing debate over the misuse of Artificial Intelligence (AI), Anthropic has released a report detailing how it has blocked efforts by bad actors to use its AI models for malicious activity such as cyberattacks, surveillance, and research that could have led to biological weapons, ranging from phishing and credential theft to exploiting vulnerable systems and stealing large volumes of data.

These revelations have been made in a new report by Anthropic on the misuse of its AI models, including Claude, including state actors running intelligence operations and developing weapon system. The actors included suspected state-sponsored groups, financially motivated criminals and politically motivated individuals.

The report, named "Detecting and countering misuse of AI: September 2026", details cyber operations identified and disrupt-



ed by Anthropic between December 2025 and August 2026, in which threat actors used the Claude AI models. The actors included suspected state-sponsored groups, financially motivated criminals and politically motivated individuals. This is Anthropic's fourth report and goes on to show how the malicious use of Claude has evolved over time.

One of the cases detailed in the report involved a Russian state-nexus espionage actor, identified by Anthropic as GTG-20006, which used AI-driven workflows to automate operations from infrastructure development and phishing

to maintaining access to compromised systems and stealing data.

The group used a toolkit that included Windows-based implants, a mobile exploitation kit, a credential-stealing tool targeting passwords stored in browsers, and a phishing platform designed to imitate government organisations.

Anthropic's report said AI's role in cyber operations is becoming increasingly autonomous, with Claude being used not only as an assistant but also to execute or coordinate parts of attacks.

In several cases, multi-agent AI systems carried out reconnaissance, exploitation

and data exfiltration, while humans largely remained involved in selecting targets and reviewing stolen information. The report said the actor also used AI to drive its phishing operations.

"They developed AI-driven workflows to research, then register domains, and then configure the hosting infrastructure used to send phishing emails," Anthropic said.

The workflows were also used to send phishing emails and monitor command-and-control channels for successful compromises. Anthropic identified more than 20 organisations targeted in the group's planning, reconnaissance and live operations.

These included government ministries, defence and intelligence bodies, embassies, diplomatic missions, think tanks and defence-industrial companies. The report also highlighted financially motivated attacks in which Claude was used to facilitate large-scale data theft and supply chain compromises.

Engineering excellence takes centre stage at IEI Awards

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Institution of Engineers (India) (IEI) will host the 18th IEI Industry Excellence Award 2026 and the 5th IEI Engineering Education Excellence Award 2026 on September 19 at the SCOPE Convention Centre, Lodhi Road, New Delhi.

The awards will bring together leaders from industry, engineering, academia, research and technology to recognise organisations and institutions contributing to India's engineering ecosystem.

Established in 1920 and granted a Royal Charter in 1935, IEI represents more than 2.6 lakh corporate members across 15 engineering disciplines.

The IEI Industry Excellence Award, instituted in 2008, recognises organisations for achievements in innovation, engineering operations, quality, productivity, governance, safety and sustained performance. The 2026 awards will cover categories including engineering manufacturing and processing, engineering services and



consultancy, construction, MSMEs, startups, agriculture and food security, industrial innovation, emerging technology leadership, sustainable engineering practices, and defence and aerospace excellence.

The Engineering Education Excellence Award will recognise institutions and academic leaders contributing to engineering and technology education. Categories include engineering colleges and institutions, polytechnics, women's engineering institutions, innovation in teaching, research excellence, academic-indus-

try collaboration and Institution of the Year.

Dr Ranga Reddy Enti, Chairman, IEI Awards 2026, said the awards would provide a national platform to recognise organisations and institutions that combine excellence with innovation, responsibility and vision.

The event will also provide opportunities for networking, knowledge exchange and strategic business engagement among industry leaders, engineering professionals, policymakers, academicians and researchers.

Drydocks World, Cochin Shipyard form JV for ship repair

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Drydocks World, a DP World group company, and Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL) on Friday announced the signing of a joint venture agreement to operate and expand the Cochin ship repair facility.

DP World, in a statement, said the 50:50 joint venture will operate and expand the International Ship Repair Facility (ISRF) in Cochin, strengthening India's ship repair ecosystem and serving growing regional and global demand. A Shipping Ministry official said that both Drydocks World and CSL will invest ₹900 crore each in the project.

The agreement was signed by Captain Rado Antolovic, PhD, CEO, Drydocks World, and Jose VJ, Chairman & Managing Director of Cochin Shipyard Ltd, on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit 2026 in New Delhi, in the presence of Sarbananda Sonowal, Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW), and Omran Sharaf Alhashimi, UAE Assistant Foreign Minister for Advanced Science and Technology.

The agreement builds on the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed by Drydocks World (DDW) and CSL during India Maritime Week 2025, under which the two organisations agreed to explore opportunities for collaboration in ship repair and allied maritime services.

According to the statement, under the arrangement, the joint venture will operate, consolidate and expand the International Ship Repair Facility (ISRF) in Cochin, creating additional capacity to service a wider range of vessels and meet the growing requirements of Indian, regional and international customers.

The partnership is expected to strengthen Cochin's position as a maritime services hub, while creating opportunities across ship repair, engineering, fabrication and associated maritime services in Kerala, it said.

New e-commerce rules may burden small sellers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Industry executives as well as merchants have said the Government's amended e-commerce rules, while well-intentioned on consumer protection and transparency, could impose a disproportionate compliance burden on small sellers and MSMEs who form the bulk of sellers on online marketplaces, particularly around ranking disclosures and price-history requirements.

The Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2026, notified by the Department of Consumer Affairs, will come into force from January 1, 2027, replacing the 2020 rules. The amended framework covers disclosure of ranking parameters, sponsored listings, a new "prior price" requirement for discount claims, compliance with the 2023 dark patterns guidelines, and mandatory partnership with the National Consumer Helpline.

A senior industry executive said the broad objective of strengthening consumer protection and transparency is welcome, but some of the provisions need closer examination from the standpoint of the small sellers and merchants who would have to comply with them.



The executive said requirements around disclosure of ranking parameters, particularly the relative importance of different parameters, could be difficult for small and unorganised sellers to navigate, and that a more granular disclosure regime could end up favouring larger, better-resourced sellers who are better placed to interpret and respond to it.

On the pricing provision, the executive said the requirement needs more thought because it is individual sellers, not the marketplace, who set and frequently change prices. A 30-day lowest-price disclosure requirement would mean sellers and merchants, particularly small businesses without dedicated compliance teams, would need to track and maintain accurate price history, adding to their operational load.

On dark patterns, the executive said the industry understands and supports the government's objective of making the sector more accountable for consumer experience, and that an annual self-audit is a reasonable way of doing that. The point for discussion, the executive said, is how the certification is framed, so that the compliance steps it entails do not end up being passed down to small sellers and merchants who already operate with limited compliance capacity.

More broadly, the executive said policymakers should keep in mind that marketplaces are an important channel for bringing small businesses, merchants and MSMEs into India's digital economy, and that regulation should strengthen consumer trust without inadvertently making it harder for these businesses to participate in digital commerce.

**DIRECTORATE Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board**
Mandi Bhowan, Rudrapur (U.S.Nagar) Ph: 05944-259056 Fax: 05944-20159

Public Information Date: 11.09.2026
Ref: UKA.PM.2/2025/488

Uttarakhand Agriculture Produce Marketing Board, Rudrapur is inviting Auction of Multigrain Unit Rudrapur and godown, Cold Storage in Vikasnagar & Manglore Mandi and to be given on lease rent.
Applying process and other related information and conditions may be seen on <https://www.procofox.com> from 27.08.2026 on 12:00 noon to 11.09.2026 till 5:00 pm, has been Extended 14.09.2026 till 5:00 pm.
Interested persons and firms may visit at <https://www.procofox.com> for further necessary action.
General Manager (Finance)

Conch-blowing marks 9th National Nutrition Month launch in east Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Department of Women and Child Development (DWCD), East District, organised the launch ceremony of the 9th National Nutrition Month at the Kondli Project with a ceremonial conch-blowing. This month-long campaign is being organised from 9 September to 8 October 2026, with the objective of promoting awareness and effective action regarding nutrition, health, hygiene, and overall well-being among children, women, and the community.

The programme was inaugurated by District Magistrate (East Delhi), Shri Karanjeet Vadodia, by lighting the ceremonial lamp, following which the 9th National Nutrition Month was formally launched. The lamp-lighting ceremony symbolised a collective commitment towards improving the nutritional status of women and children and promoting aware-

ness about healthy lifestyles and nutrition in the community. On this occasion, views and experiences regarding the importance of National Nutrition Month were shared. The District Magistrate interacted with the Anganwadi Workers and Anganwadi Helpers present and appreciated their work, encouraging them to continue working with dedication, sincerity, and commitment.

During the programme, various cultural programmes were presented by Anganwadi Workers and Anganwadi Helpers. Through these performances, the messages and themes of National Nutrition Month were effectively highlighted. The cultural presentations reflected the enthusiasm, creativity, and active participation of the Anganwadi Workers and Helpers towards nutrition and healthy lifestyles.

A special exhibition of 'Best out of Waste' materials prepared by the Anganwadi



Workers and Helpers of East District was also organised during the programme. The District Magistrate (East Delhi)

visited the exhibition and appreciated the efforts made by the Anganwadi Workers and Helpers towards the reuse of

Army reviews Garuda Aerospace's indigenous drone capabilities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

IPO-bound Garuda Aerospace, one of India's leading drone technology companies, hosted the Additional Director General (ADG) of the Army Design Bureau (ADB), Major General Gopal Kapoor, AVSM, VSM, at its defence drone manufacturing facility in Chennai.

The visit was aimed at reviewing the company's indigenous and localisation capabilities and assessing ongoing and upcoming projects that support India's evolving defence and drone ecosystem.

Garuda Aerospace presented an overview of its defence programmes, manufacturing capacity, research and development work, and industry partnerships.

The company also highlighted its expanding drone pilot training network, including Remote Pilot Training Organisations (RPTOs), and proposals made to the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) to train 80,000 Agniveers across the tri-services.

Agnishwar Jayaprakash, Founder and CEO of Garuda Aerospace, said India's path to defence self-reliance depends on



close collaboration among industry, Government, academia and the armed forces. He described the visit as an important milestone and said the company remains committed to the Prime Minister's Atmanirbhar Bharat vision and to helping India become a global hub for indigenous drone technology and manufacturing.

The ADG, ADB, commended Garuda Aerospace for strengthening domestic drone manufacturing and noted its investments in infrastructure, technology development and R&D. The visiting team also reviewed the company's vulnerability checklist and testing processes, conducted with authorised agencies, to assess compliance with applicable defence stan-

dards. Garuda Aerospace showcased its 50,000 sqft manufacturing facility covering design, prototyping, production, testing and deployment.

The unit includes injection moulding, industrial-grade 3D printing, and battery assembly and testing infrastructure, supported by more than 50 PhD researchers working on PCB manufacturing, RF antennae, communication systems and Ground Control Stations.

Major General Kapoor underlined indigenisation as a key pillar of India's defence preparedness. The interaction reinforced the broader vision of designing, developing and manufacturing in India.

SBI plans UPI data tool to assess small business creditworthiness

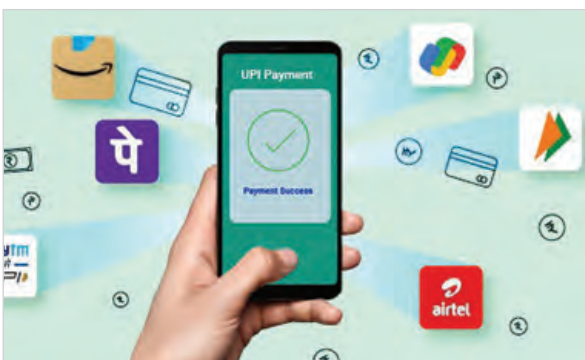
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

State Bank of India (SBI) is developing a solution to use UPI data as a proxy to assess a small business entity's creditworthiness in the absence of GST registration, a top official said on Friday.

The country's largest lender is confident of providing end-to-end digital loans within a day for such borrowers, its Managing Director Ashwini Kumar Tewari said here, adding that this will help assuage concerns about such businesses being left outside formal finance.

"UPI (Unified Payments Interface) can substitute GST (goods and services tax) if regular sales are happening. We are developing a UPI solution (for businesses) without GST, and we will use that (UPI transactions) as a proxy for sales," Tewari said.

The bank has been able to solve lending challenges for the businesses registered with GST, and is in a position



to lend within ten minutes, he said, speaking at the annual Global Fintech Fest here. Over the last 18 months, it has written loans of Rs 1 lakh crore using GST and PAN data, which gives an insight into the cash flow of a business, he added.

However, there are difficulties in the case of businesses not having a GST number, he said, pointing out that this is where alternative data inputs become important.

Explaining "frictions" on the UPI payments front, he said the lender bank does

not have any clarity over where the money is going, but the receiver bank and third-party payments app facilitating the transaction have the data.

Using customer consent, the bank can establish creditworthiness by deploying models that look for UPI payments and other inputs like data from telecom companies, he said.

The bank hopes to provide small business loans using the new data inputs, Tewari said, adding that this will help solve the credit challenges for Bharat.

Rupee depreciation, commodity costs push BMW price hike

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BMW Group India will soon hike prices of vehicles across its portfolio, the fourth increase during this calendar year, as high commodity costs and rupee depreciation continue to pressure margins, the German luxury car maker's President and CEO Hardeep Singh Brar said on Friday.

The auto maker has cumulatively hiked prices by up to 5 per cent for the BMW and MINI vehicle portfolios spread across three price revisions in 2026 till now in India.

Speaking to reporters, the BMW Group India President and CEO said, "The forex has hit us quite a bit. We have increased prices by 4-5 per cent till now and there's another one around the corner. So the prices will continue to go up for us because of the pressure of forex, of commodities, etc.

"We have already done three (price) increases this year and there's another one around the corner. We are considering it (the next price hike) may be, next month. Since last year January it (forex) has deteriorated about 18 pc."



He was speaking after the launch of the new BMW 7 Series range in the country. With this, the BMW flagship sedan will be available in petrol and all-electric powertrains. The all-electric performance model, the BMW i7 M70 will also be available for customers in India.

The new 7 was unveiled by Bollywood actor Ranveer Singh, who was introduced as the brand voice for BMW India.

"In addition to the 7 Series, the new BMW i7 will also now be locally produced at BMW Group Plant Chennai. With this, India becomes the only

other country apart from Germany where the i7 is locally produced. The new BMW i7 M70 will be available as a completely built-up unit," Brar said.

The cars can be booked at BMW India dealerships, and the deliveries will commence from October 2026.

The car models are available at an ex-showroom price range of ₹1.95 crore each for the new BMW 740 M Sport; and the BMW i7 eDrive 50 xDrive M Sport; whereas the new BMW i7 M70 xDrive is priced at ₹2.65,00,000 (ex-showroom).

BRIEFLY

ACA inaugurates one of India's largest indoor cricket facilities



One of India's largest indoor cricket facilities was inaugurated at the ACA Cricket Academy in North Guwahati on Friday, strengthening Assam's cricketing infrastructure. Spread across approximately 17,000 sq ft, the facility features nine cricket wickets - four spin and five seam - with imported Uniturf playing surfaces to allow players to train under varied conditions. It also houses separate men's and women's changing rooms, each equipped with ice baths, a 1,500 sq ft gymnasium, sauna and steam room, as well as a dedicated physiotherapy facility for rehabilitation, injury management and recovery. "The development of modern cricket infrastructure is essential for creating the right environment for players to learn, train and progress," said BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia while inaugurating the facility. (PTI)

UTMB challenge helped me win Silk Route Ultra: Nawang



Nawang Tsering of Ladakh won the Silk Route Ultra (SRU) Marathon by clocking just 12:12:18s, and feels his stint at the world's most difficult trail running event – UTMB in France helped him clinch the title with a record timing. "I am very happy to win the title with a record margin. UTMB in France helped me a lot. Because I had run in the steep mountains and rocks. So, it helped me here. Here I was like running on the road. The road running was so long that I did not even do that much," Nawang told PTI on Friday. The long-distance runner from Ladakh revealed that there was a lot of pain and cramps in his body while he was running the 122km distance. "There are a lot of cramps and pain in my body, but I do not get tired. I did a lot of running. I did it at the top too, where my whole body was bent. Still, I didn't stop. I just had to complete it. When I start, I just have to finish it. I have to do it. Whatever happens, I don't have to give up," he said. He said he allowed other competitors to go ahead of him, only to catch them after they ran out of steam while approaching the steep elevations. (PTI)

India reach junior men's Asia Cup final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Moqi (China)

In-form captain Anmol Ekka struck twice as defending champions India defeated Malaysia 3-1 to storm into their fourth consecutive AHF Men's Junior Asia Cup final here on Friday. Drag-flicker Anmol once again led from the front, scoring twice from penalty corners to take his tournament tally to an impressive 16 goals and strengthen his position at the top of the scoring charts. Goalkeeper Vivek Lakra was equally influential, making a series of outstanding saves, including stopping a penalty stroke, which kept India in control of the contest. The defending champions, chasing a fourth consecutive and sixth overall title, will face the winners of the second semi-final between Pakistan and South Korea. India began the match on the front foot, with Ajeet Yadav coming close twice inside the opening two minutes after intelligently getting to the end of long balls played out from deep defence. India soon earned three



penalty corners, but Malaysian goalkeeper Amsyar Mohamad Adib stood firm with a couple of good saves to keep India at bay. A turnover in the 12th minute almost presented India with the opening goal, but they were unable to convert the opportunity. Malaysia came close in the final minute of the quarter, although the attempt from the top of the circle

lacked both power and direction. India finally broke the deadlock early in the second quarter when they earned their fourth penalty corner in the 16th minute. Skipper Anmol, positioned at the first battery, unleashed a hard, low flick that beat Amsyar to his right and crashed into the board to give India a 1-0 lead. Malaysia responded immediately, forcing a bril-

liant save from Lakra in the 17th minute before earning their first penalty corner. However, India's first rusher made an important block to deny the Malaysians. Lakra then produced one of the defining moments of the match early in the third quarter. In the 34th minute, he made a stunning double save, followed by another stop moments later, as

Malaysia increased the pressure. India were reduced to 10 players after Manmeet Singh Rai received a yellow card in the 36th minute. Prabhdeep Singh was shown a yellow card in the 41st minute, leaving India with 10 players once again. India finally found the breathing room they were looking for in the fourth quarter. After a Malaysian defensive touch denied them in the 51st minute, India immediately launched another circle entry and this time found the target, with Sukhvinder finishing the move to make it 2-0. Lakra then delivered another moment of brilliance. Malaysia were awarded a penalty stroke in the 53rd minute, but the Indian goalkeeper dived sharply to his left and used his glove to keep the effort out. India quickly turned defence into attack and earned a penalty corner in the 54th minute. Malaysia challenged the decision through a video referral but lost the referral, and the PC stood. Anmol made no mistake, powering his flick straight past the goalkeeper to make it 3-0.

Gurucharan Singh Hora enters AITA secretary general race

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Chhattisgarh State Tennis Association secretary Gurucharan Singh Hora on Friday announced his candidature for the post of Secretary General of the All India Tennis Association (AITA). Hora, who is currently serving as Joint Secretary (Interim) of the AITA, said his decision to contest the election was driven by his "lifelong commitment" to tennis and a desire to strengthen the sport's grassroots and junior development structure. "I have decided to contest the forthcoming elections of the All India Tennis Association (AITA) for the position of Hon. Secretary General," Hora, who is a Mechanical Engineer by qualification and an entrepreneur, said in a statement. As CSTA secretary, Hora said he contributed to the establishment of a tennis academy in Raipur, developed with an investment of approximately Rs 25 crore to provide training facilities to players. Legendary Leander Paes and Davis Cup skipper Rohit Rajpal have already announced their candidature for the post of President. The AITA elections for the 2024-28



Executive Committee were held on September 28, 2024, but the results were placed in a sealed cover following directions of the Delhi High Court amid a challenge alleging violations of the National Sports Development Code. The Delhi High Court subsequently directed the AITA to amend its Constitution and bye-laws in line with the National Sports Governance Act, 2025 and the National Sports Governance (National Sports Bodies) Rules, 2026 before conducting fresh elections.

Antonelli looks to keep momentum as F1 drivers face challenges at Spanish GP



TALES AZZONIAP ■ Madrid

Kimi Antonelli is coming off one of the biggest highs of his career — an epic comeback win in Monza in front of his home fans to extend his lead in Formula 1. The young Italian will look to keep his momentum and add to his points lead this weekend as the Spanish Grand Prix returns to Madrid after more than four decades — in a race featuring the unknowns of a new hybrid circuit that drivers called "crazy" and "insane" even before cars got to the track. Antonelli rallied from 19th on the grid to win last weekend's Italian GP in what he called an "absolutely incredible" feat. "Definitely so far the best day of my life, and an incredible memory," Antonelli said Thursday. "Wish (I had) a bit

more time to realise and enjoy it, but now obviously we are in Madrid, and we are ready to do our best, and we'll try to repeat." Last weekend's victory gave the 20-year-old Antonelli a 66-point lead over Mercedes teammate George Russell with 10 races remaining, including Sunday's debut of the Madrid track that has put the F1 paddock on edge. The Spanish GP ends the European part of the season. The Madrid region last hosted an F1 race in 1981 at Jarama, on the outskirts of the Spanish capital. Barcelona had been the

home of the Spanish GP in recent years. The Jerez de la Frontera track in southern Spain hosted races from 1986-90, and in 1994 and 1997. Madring signed a contract with F1 through 2035. **Exciting new track** The 5.4-kilometre (3.3-mile) Madring track, the newest addition to the F1 calendar since Las Vegas' debut three years ago, combines high-speed zones, heavy-braking areas, changes of gradient, blind turns and high-load corners that should give drivers a little margin for error. It mixes existing roads with purpose-built areas, and in most sections cars will run extremely close to the walls. (AP)

Madappa overcomes three-shot deficit to win the Chennai Open golf



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Viraj Madappa overturned a three-shot deficit with a bogey-free eight-under 64 to win the ₹1 crore Chennai Open golf tournament by one stroke at the TNGF Cosmo Golf Course here on Friday. The 28-year-old Kolkata golfer (72-67-63-64), who began the final round three shots behind overnight leader Ajeetesh Sandhu, made eight birdies to finish at 22-under 266 and secure his fourth profes-

sional title. Madappa, who became the youngest Indian to win on the Asian Tour in 2018, collected ₹15 lakh. The victory lifted him from 44th to 22nd on the 2026 DP World PGTI Order of Merit, taking his season earnings to ₹23,90,042 and securing his place in the DP World India Championship. Chandigarh's Sandhu (65-66-68-68), a five-time DP World PGTI winner, closed with a four-under 68 comprising five birdies and a bogey. However, it was not enough to protect his overnight advantage as he finished runner-up

at 21-under 267. Sandhu earned ₹10 lakh and climbed from 21st to 15th on the Order of Merit, with season earnings of ₹33,47,375. Noida's Amardeep Malik (67-68-69-67) made seven birdies and two bogeys in a five-under 67 to finish third at 17-under 271. Malik moved from 19th to 14th in the season standings, taking his earnings to ₹33,75,548. Delhi's Rashid Khan (66-68-72-66) fired a closing six-under 66, featuring seven birdies and one bogey, to claim fourth place at 16-under 272.

Europe, US tied 2-2 after Solheim Cup opener

STEVE DOUGLASAP
■ Den Bosch, (Netherlands)

Nelly Korda played like the world Number 1 in a record-setting partnership with Allisen Corpuz, helping the Americans split the opening foursomes 2-2 with Team Europe in a loud and wet start to the Solheim Cup in the Netherlands on Friday. The early soundtrack to Day 1 - party music and chants just after dawn on a typically boisterous first tee - quickly turned into cheers from visiting American fans around a



gloomy Bernardus Golf as Korda and Corpuz dominated the star-studded opening match against Europe's best top players, Charley Hull and Lottie Woad.

With their 4-and-3 win, the U.S. pairing claimed a fifth straight win - an unprecedented feat at the Solheim Cup. When Alison Lee and Lauren Coughlin put more red on the board by beating Nanna Koerstz Madsen and Alison Lee as rain started to fall, the United States had two of the 14 points needed to take the crystal trophy back across the Atlantic. Europe rallied, though, with victories in the final two matches of the session. (AP)

DAILY SUDOKU

	1			7	8			
								5
				3		6		7
		7	9	2		4		1
		2				8		
3		1		5	7	2		
9		6		8				
	5							
			3	4				9

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (11.9.26)

5	6	7	2	1	9	8	3	4
3	9	1	4	7	8	2	5	6
8	2	4	5	6	3	7	9	1
6	1	8	7	9	2	3	4	5
7	4	5	6	3	1	9	2	8
9	3	2	8	5	4	1	6	7
2	5	9	1	8	6	4	7	3
1	7	3	9	4	5	6	8	2
4	8	6	3	2	7	5	1	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

SATURDAY | SEPTEMBER 12, 2026

1	2		3	4		5		6	7		8
			9								
10								11			
13										15	16
17								18			
20	21								22		23
24								25			
27										28	
30											

ACROSS

1. Total (4)
2. Monkeys (4)
3. Corn (4)
4. Corn (4)
5. Octane (4)
6. Pused (4)
7. Piton (4)
8. Roc (4)
9. Follies (4)
10. Sec (4)
11. Sodom (4)
12. Tang (4)
13. Son (4)
14. Support for a homeless person? (5)
15. Many a vehicle may serve for sleeping (5)
16. She isn't exactly petty (5)
17. The pawnbroker may find a hundred pounds in a French one (5)
18. Gamble a bird might take? (7)
19. Being a lout may seem nothing to a swimmer (6)
20. Untidy little pigs? (6)
21. You can push your hand right through it (6)
22. Gave about a quid for something wearable (5)
23. So looking a bit red and tender (4)
24. Lower payment? (3)

DOWN

1. Nice and saintly, but with very little heart (5)
2. Excessive water in mixing paste (5)
3. The object of a piece of writing (7)
4. Bad name for a builder (5)
5. Attack with a stone? (5)
6. To have demonstrated the method in different ways (5)
7. Freedom of the island in New York Harbour (7)
8. Girl turning over in bed (3)
9. New deal for Mr Jones, let's nominate (4)
10. Upper class wines blended in rash style (6)
11. Chuck having a bit of fun (5)
12. Thus (4)
13. Serfdom (4)
14. B-rides (4)
15. O-H (4)
16. Sited (4)
17. T-reason (4)
18. Mad-Am (4)
19. Cob (4)
20. Shoot (4)
21. Henry (4)
22. Neigh (4)
23. Stubbs (4)
24. Cu-jit-t (4)
25. So-laced (4)
26. Sedate (4)
27. Right (4)
28. Demon (4)
29. Cobra (4)
30. Tang (4)
31. Son (4)



Rahul to be key player in NZ Tests: Boult

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

The seasoned KL Rahul will be India's main batter in the two-Test series against New Zealand beginning November 19, reckons former Black Caps left-arm quick Trent Boult.

The 37-year-old Boult, who has 317 Test wickets to his name, is a big admirer of Rahul's batting style and expects the Indian opener to be among the key players in the series.

The marathon tour, beginning October 22, also features 10 white-ball games and is part of centenary celebration of the India-New Zealand sporting ties.

"I'm always a big fan of KL Rahul and his style of batsmanship. So he's a big player at the top of the order for the Indian side. And yeah, I believe Jaiswal is there as well. Two classy batters to see bat. So yeah, be



interesting to see," Boult said in an exclusive interview to PTI

felicitated by organisers of the European T20 Premier League. "It's always an exciting chance when the Indian team comes

down to play Test cricket in New Zealand," he added.

The timing of the tour, late October-November rather than the traditional February-March window that India has been using, could make conditions particularly challenging for the batters as Boult expects the weather to be cold.

"The only thing I can see happening is it's going to be late October. I believe, just coming out of winter. So it's going to be quite cold. Hopefully, there's a bit of greenness in the wickets for some of our bowlers.

"It's going to be a good series, I'm sure," the left arm exponent of swing bowling gave his observations about conditions that he expects in Wellington and Christchurch.

Boult and Tim Southee formed a formidable new-ball partnership for New Zealand over many years, but the veteran feels the current group also has enough variety and quality to create its own identity, with Kyle Jamieson, Matt Henry, Nathan Smith and Will O'Rourke offering different strengths.

I think the bowling is very well balanced. It's got bases covered in terms of a good pace, obviously, with Will O'Rourke.

Obviously, a bit of swing and a bit of bounce from Kyle Jamieson and Matt Henry with his accuracy.

"So yeah, I think the way me, Tim and Wags did it over the years was a unique way in itself. But there's other strengths and other game plans that our younger bowlers can follow."

Boult also paid tribute to Neil Wagner, whose relentless approach and ability to extract the best out of difficult situations made him a vital part of New Zealand's bowling attack alongside Boult and Southee.

"I don't think you can compare anyone to Neil Wagner. He had that unique ability to find something out of nothing basically in the Test arena and he always wore his heart on his sleeve and gave everything.

"So he was a big part of the New Zealand team at the time, but a new look side now and a new look way of playing." (PTI)

BCCI reopens search for sports science, medicine head

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The BCCI on Friday invited applications for Head of Sports Science and Medicine at its Centre of Excellence after being unable to fill the key position that has been vacant since the resignation of Nitin Patel in March 2025.

BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia and COE head VVS Laxman have publicly spoken about the challenges in filling the vacancy.

The application deadline is September 30.

Former India physio Andrew Leipus was BCCI's top choice for the post, but he "backed off" citing family reasons.

"After Nitin left, we did not get anyone who could fill in that position. We had Andrew Leipus, and everything was agreed upon. In fact, (BCCI secretary) Devajit (Saikia) had two or three meetings with him, but suddenly Andrew backed off, citing family reasons," Laxman had told select media at the BCCI COE last month. COE has been under the scanner of late for injury management of the players.

"We conducted a full-fledged interview process where we had Dr Dinshaw Pardiwala, Dr Ashish Soni, Dr Rohan Khavte and me, and we shortlisted five candidates and number one was an Australian.



"After selecting him, suddenly he also backed out, saying he cannot move to Bangalore and it was one of the important conditions," Laxman had said. "It is a full-time job, and it is not a part-time one. It is day-to-day monitoring. That professional did not join. Another professional was the head of sports science at the All Blacks (New Zealand rugby team), and we engaged with him, and he almost agreed, but at the last moment he also backed off," said the former India batter.

The successful candidate will provide strategic and operational leadership to BCCI's Sports Science and Medicine services across its elite cricket and CoE programmes, said the BCCI in a release. "The role will also involve line management of the Head of Physiotherapy (CoE), Team India Head of Physiotherapy, Head S&C (CoE) and Team India S&C, while working closely with National and CoE coaches, Cricket Education and other performance specialists to deliver integrated support programmes for Indian players.

"The position will have a key focus on player welfare, injury prevention and rehabilitation, physical development, research, innovation and the adoption of relevant technologies and services," the BCCI statement added.

The successful candidate will report to Laxman at COE in Bengaluru.

J&K CM congratulates Sheetal Devi on Para Series gold

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Friday congratulated Paralympics medallist Sheetal Devi on winning gold at the World Archery Para Series Stage III, saying her achievement was a proud moment for the entire nation.

The 19-year-old, who hails from Kishtwar district in the Jammu region, won the women's compound individual title earlier this week in Ahmedabad. "The Chief Minister congratulated Para Archer Sheetal Devi on winning the Gold Medal at the World Archery Para Series 2026, Stage III," the CM's office said in a post on X.

"He said her remarkable achievement of winning Gold in the Women's Compound Individual Event and Bronze in the Compound



Mixed Team Event is a proud moment for the entire nation, and wished her continued success in all her future endeavours," it added.

World Number 1 and reigning world champion Sheetal produced a composed performance against Kazakhstan's Aizada Seidan in a thrilling compound women's individual final.

Yuki doubtful for Davis Cup tie against Korea after leg strain



AMANPREET SINGH ■ New Delhi

India's Yuki Bhambri is a doubtful starter for the upcoming Davis Cup tie against Korea in Seoul after suffering a strain in his right leg during practice ahead of his US Open main draw match, a development termed as a huge setback by skipper Rohit Rajpal.

Bhambri did not travel to Seoul with the first batch of Indian players that left on Thursday night, adding uncertainty over his availability for the crucial tie, where the winner will seal a place in the elite eight-team Davis Cup Finals. The 32-year-old termed the injury a minor strain and assured that there was no threat to his Asian Games participation later this month.

"This (strain) happened before the main draw match during practice. This is a minor strain. There is no timeline set for my recovery, but there is nothing major," Bhambri told PTI. Bhambri is being monitored on a day-to-day basis and is consulting

the Indian Davis Cup team support staff, including Debashish Das and Yash Pandey, to assess his recovery.

"There is still pain. It's a day-by-day situation; we will see how it goes," he said. Non-playing captain Rohit Rajpal told PTI from Seoul that Bhambri's ill-timed injury has certainly impacted their preparations.

"We are working on it; hopefully he should recover. It certainly is a huge setback. He is a great combination with DK (Dhakhshinewar). Yuki is by far our number one doubles player.

"His injury means we are starting afresh now. Combinations will depend on how quickly Yuki recovers and how the first day goes for us. The Koreans already have the advantage of playing at home," said Rajpal.

The injury, though, is not expected to jeopardise Bhambri's participation in the Asian Games. "I am competing in the Asian Games one hundred per cent. We will see if we can recover for Davis Cup," he said. (PTI)

Shoaib Akhtar blasts Babar Azam for weak leadership in England tour



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Former speedster Shoaib Akhtar has criticised under-fire captain Babar Azam for his weak leadership during Pakistan's ongoing three-match Test tour of England, in which the visitors are trailing 0-2.

Pakistan suffered heavy defeats in the first two Tests, losing by an innings and 103 runs at Leeds and by 194 runs at Lord's.

The third Test is going on at Birmingham.

Shoaib, known as the Rawalpindi Express, said Babar had failed to fulfil his responsibilities as a captain and lacked leadership qualities.

"I think many of the issues stem from the fact that he (Babar) is unable to make the right calls. Had it been me, everyone knows what would have happened. That is a very simple thing," he said. "I think Babar's personality is visible in his captaincy, decision-making and his game, which is why he is now struggling badly."

Shoaib said he never expected much from the current Pakistan team in England. "I think the investment we made in this system and the confidence we placed in it have failed," he said.

Rizwan, Imam questioned over dressing-room leaks



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

Senior players Mohammad Rizwan and Imam-ul-Haq were grilled for nearly four hours as Pakistan's National Cyber Crime Investigation Agency (NCCIA) began an inquiry into alleged dressing-room leaks following a complaint from the country's cricket board.

A new angle has now emerged in the ongoing probe, with the NCCIA conducting forensic and technical analysis of the mobile phones of the two players, with a focus on their financial accounts and suspicious transactions, according to Geo News TV reports.

The channel reported that the financial dealings of Rizwan and Imam before and after the ongoing Test series against England are being examined, with details of their bank accounts under scrutiny.

Payments allegedly made by any company, individual or organisation are also being scrutinised as part of the investigation, while some transactions made through their accounts during the relevant period are being reviewed.

The stunning turn of events comes amid Pakistan's disastrous performance on an ongoing Test tour of England, from where seven players, including Rizwan and Imam, and two members of the support staff were sent back because of disciplinary issues.

Following the unprecedented move, the Pakistan team's security manager has already handed over the phones of the two senior players to the NCCIA.

Mohsin Naqvi, who heads the PCB, is also the country's interior minister and the NCCIA functions under his ministry.

A spokesperson for the board confirmed that the NCCIA was holding an inquiry into the



alleged dressing-room leaks but said no further comment would be made on the matter as it is an ongoing process.

This is the first time that the board has filed a complaint with a cyber-agency against national team players.

Both Rizwan and Imam have requested more time to submit their written replies to the NCCIA queries. The PCB has already announced it had "initiated an internal disciplinary inquiry following media reports concerning discipline and conduct, which are currently being reviewed internally".

The players, who appeared at the NCCIA's Johar Town office in Lahore on Thursday and were questioned for a long period, have asked the agency for more time to submit their written replies to all queries posed to them during the questioning.

Sources said during the meeting, both players were quizzed about alleged leaks from the dressing room, as well as their contacts and meetings during practice sessions and matches in England.

The NCCIA has not officially confirmed any allegations against either player.

"The inquiry will focus on alleged leaks from the dressing room during the England series," a source said.

The NCCIA acted after receiving a complaint from the PCB.

Pakistan cricket's downfall started when Imran Khan messed with domestic structure

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Former chief selector and head coach Haroon Rasheed believes the downfall of Pakistan cricket started the moment former Prime Minister Imran Khan changed the domestic structure.

Haroon, who was part of the task force set up to study the domestic structure when Imran was the Prime Minister, revealed how his former Pakistan captain had insisted on changing Pakistan's first-class structure to just five-six teams.

"I was part of the cricket board and task force, and I remember when we met with Imran, we submitted a hybrid domestic cricket model. But he rejected it outright," Haroon said on a podcast on the 'Smash It' sports channel.



Imran was the Prime Minister from 2018 after his party, the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf, won the general elections, but he was voted out of power in 2022 and is now in Adiala Jail facing various charges related to his term.

The celebrated Pakistan captain, who won the 1992 World Cup for his country, had ordered a revamp of the domestic structure, reducing first class cricket from 10-16 teams to just five teams on the lines of the Australian structure.

Many cricket critics and analysts believe the move backfired for Pakistan cricket.

Haroon recalled that as Prime Minister, Imran was very busy with his other responsibilities. "How much time do you think a Prime Minister can give? We were ordered to submit a revised domestic cricket plan, and we did that, and it was a hybrid one," Haroon said.

Haroon worked in the PCB after his retirement until 2020 in various influential positions, including chief selector, selector, head coach, head of high perfor-

mance and development and manager.

"I remember we told Imran that the hybrid model was best for our cricket, as we had reduced teams to eight, but we had kept the participation of departmental teams in domestic cricket.

"But Imran, in his short meeting with us, rejected the hybrid model and said he didn't want eight but a maximum of five to six teams in the domestic structure. We told him it would be better to gradually switch to a new domestic structure, but eventually you have to listen to the Prime Minister," Haroon recalled.

"He might have meant well but it didn't work out for Pakistan cricket."

He said the task force was then told by the then board chairman Ehsan Mani to do as Imran wanted.

"We changed the domestic structure making it provincial cricket and leaving out departments, but I personally feel it was a wrong decision and it led to a downfall in our cricket standards," Haroon feels.

Haroon said India's meteoric rise in world cricket was rooted in their domestic cricket.

"People talk about the IPL but forget that in India they still have the Ranji Trophy, Duleep Trophy, Mushtaq Ali Trophy, Vijay Hazare Trophy and their state-level associations are independent and have their own regular domestic events at the club level.

"In Pakistan, all powers are now with the PCB, which needs to decentralise power and give more independence to regional associations and departments, as was the case in the past."

